

PLAIN

PAROCHIAL SERMONS,

PREACHED IN

THE PARISH CHURCH OF BOLTON-LE-MOORS,

BY THE

REV. JAMES SLADE, M. A.,

VICAR OF BOLTON, AND PREBENDARY OF CHESTER.

London:

C. J. G. AND F. RIVINGTON, ST. PAUL'S CHURCH YARD.

1831.

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BOLTON:
PRINTED BY J. GARDNER.

TO THE CONGREGATION
OF THE PARISH CHURCH OF BOLTON,
THESE SERMONS
ARE INSCRIBED AND DEDICATED,
WITH AFFECTIONATE REGARD,
BY THEIR PASTOR AND FRIEND,

J. S.

ADVERTISEMENT.

THE author has been repeatedly urged to print a volume of his Parochial Sermons; and perhaps he owes some apology to those friends, whose kind advice, on this head, has been for years neglected. He was apprehensive, that the interest, excited by his discourses from the pulpit, would not be adequately revived by their appearance in print; or at most, that they would be impressive only upon those who had heard them: and he moreover thought, that the christian world was already provided with more than a sufficiency of such publications. However, whether these opinions be well founded or not, he has been at length prevailed upon to defer to the wishes and judgment of others.

It is almost needless to observe, that the Sermons were written without any, the most distant, view to publication; they pretend to nothing, but the simple and earnest inculcation of christian principle and practice; and as this is the author's sole object, so does he pour forth his humble prayer, that what, by God's help, he has planted and watered, may, by God's blessing, be increased to the glory of His own great name, and the edification of His Church.

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[Preached March 28th, 1830, and at Chester Cathedral, September 5th, in the same year.]

SERMON I.

AWAKE THOU THAT SLEEPEST.

EPHESIANS V. 14.

Wherefore, he saith, Awake, thou that sleepest, and arise from the dead, and Christ shall give thee light.

IN this chapter the Apostle has been reminding his Ephesian converts of the state in which they were, before they had received and obeyed the call of the gospel. The people of Ephesus were highly endowed, in the world's estimation, not only with riches, but also with talent and learning, and refinement; with all the arts and ornaments of civilized life. And yet, how does St. Paul describe them in the 8th verse? "Ye were sometimes darkness;" how in the 12th? "For it is a shame even to speak of those things which are done of them in secret."

Here, you observe, we have a remarkable declaration from the mouth of an Apostle, that a people, however talented and learned, were still wrapt in the mantle of darkness, with regard to their real good and happiness; with regard to their religious and moral condition. Whatever nature had done for them, to whatever eminence they had been raised by art or industry, they were left far short of the object which it concerned them most to attain—an acquaintance with God, a knowledge and practice of His law; a peace with Him and with their own consciences. So far were they from this, that their characters were stained with the most debasing vices; their secret sins were too abominable even to be mentioned.

Thus we see how little the instructions and advantages of this world have to do with reforming the conduct, or amending the depraved heart of man. And what was true in this instance, is true in all; there is no teaching, there are no rules of prudence, no maxims however wise, no manners however

polished, that can cleanse the heart of its natural unrighteousness, and curb its natural propensity to evil: give what you may, educate as you may, man, if left to his own wisdom and strength, will remain what he is by fallen nature, a weak, a wayward, and a wicked being; an enemy to holiness and to God. There may be a shew of wisdom “falsely so called;” there may be a refined conversation and a polished outside; but there will always be uncleanness remaining within. The evil principles may wear a dazzling veil, and the vices may be clothed in fashionable garments, but they will be evil principles and vices still.

There is but one means by which the darkness of nature can be scattered, and that is by the light of God’s truth; but one means by which the evil spirit of the natural man can be cast out, and that is by the Spirit of God. The blessed Jesus came into the world to reclaim and redeem it from the grossness in which it was sunk; to open a new scene of things; to impart a new life; to banish the thick cloud of error and of sin, in which the world hopelessly and irrecoverably lay; and to raise it to the knowledge and service, the favour and blessing of an offended God. This is the description of the happy effects which the gospel is intended and fitted to produce; “the people that walked in darkness have seen a great light; they that dwell in the land of the shadow of death, upon them hath the light shined.” ^[4] All, without the gospel, are in this miserable condition, whatever they may think of themselves: all who sincerely embrace it, are enlightened and happy, however poor and humble, and of whatever else they may be ignorant.

Poor and humble did I say? It is to them, that this light is the most easily, and frequently, and effectually communicated. The prosperous and the great too often resemble the wealthy Ephesians, “having the understanding darkened, being alienated from the life of God through the ignorance that is in them, because of the blindness of their heart;” ^[5] revelling in the self-sufficiency of their earthly comforts, proud of their acquirements, fond of their own way, they disdain to be taught the humbling truths of the gospel from a fellow-creature like themselves: and often has the minister of the gospel to be thankful to his Lord and Master, that, when he finds his message rejected and despised by his wealthier hearers, it still makes its way into the hearts of some of the poor: grieved he is indeed, that those, who ought to know it best and love it most, should be so deluded by worldly vanities and follies, as to continue, amidst all their advantages of

education, in spiritual darkness and death; set against the messenger, because hating the truth of his message: yet, is it a comfort to him, sincere and unspeakable, that he meets with more success among the ignorant, as they are called, and the children of the poor: that there he finds wisdom, “the wisdom which is from above;” and there he finds friends among the friends of God.

It was so in the Apostle’s day; and with some bright exceptions, it has been the same in every day: “For ye see your calling, brethren, how that not many wise men after the flesh, not many mighty, not many noble are called; but God hath chosen the foolish things of the world to confound the wise; and God hath chosen the weak things of the world, to confound the things that are mighty: and base things of the world, and things which are despised hath God chosen; yea, and things which are not, to bring to nought things that are: that no flesh should glory in his presence.” ^[7]

All these observations have been made, to connect and explain the first word of the text, *wherefore*; “wherefore, he saith, awake thou that sleepest and arise from the dead, and Christ shall give thee light.” Inasmuch as it is impossible for thee to know and to please God, to attain unto holiness and happiness, to save thy soul, by the light of nature, (for nature is in fact, of itself and for such a purpose, no light at all,) turn to the way, which is opened to thee by the shining of the Sun of Righteousness; to that one way, which is opened alike for all mankind, rich and poor, learned and unlearned; turn to thy Redeemer, in humble faith and hearty desire, and “He shall give thee light:” learn of Him and He shall teach thee all that thou needest to know: seek of Him, and He shall guide thee into all righteousness and truth; lean on Him, and He shall support thee, through all the course of thy earthly pilgrimage; and conduct thee in peace and safety to thy journey’s end.

“Wherefore, he *saith*,” there is no particular passage in the Old Testament, in which these words of the text are found; but they seem to allude to several expressions of similar import, in the prophecy of Isaiah. In the 26th chapter, there is a passage which describes the deliverance of God’s people from a state of degradation, both political and spiritual, under the figure of a resurrection from the dead: “Thy dead men shall live, together with my dead body shall they arise. Awake and sing, ye that dwell in dust; for thy dew is as the dew of herbs, and the earth shall cast out the dead.” ^[8] And

again, in the 52nd chapter: “Awake, awake, put on thy strength, O Zion; put on thy beautiful garments, O Jerusalem, the Holy city; for henceforth there shall no more come in to thee the uncircumcised and the unclean; shake thyself from the dust; arise and sit down, O Jerusalem: loose thyself from the bands of thy neck, O captive daughter of Zion: for thus saith the Lord, ye have sold yourselves for nought; and ye shall be redeemed without money:” ^[9a] a powerful call upon the Jewish people to cast away their transgressions, through which they had been brought into a state of grievous captivity, and to throw themselves on the Lord’s mercy, and return to the Lord’s service, that He might break their bonds asunder, and visit them with His salvation. One more passage there is, to which the Apostle clearly alludes, in the opening of the 60th chapter: “Arise, shine, for thy light is come, and the glory of the Lord is risen upon thee. For behold, the darkness shall cover the earth, and gross darkness the people: but the Lord shall arise upon thee, and his glory shall be seen upon thee.” ^[9b] Here the prophet foretels the glorious dawn of gospel light, and calls upon the Church to arise and behold it, shining from afar; to behold it with the eye of faith; to look forward to that Saviour, that great “fountain for sin and uncleanness,” which the law and the prophets did all with one voice proclaim. The prophet adds, “And the gentiles shall come to thy light, and kings to the brightness of thy rising.” The first coming of the gentile world was visible in the footsteps of the wise men, who came “from the east to Jerusalem,” ^[10] to worship the infant Jesus: and ever since our Lord’s return to the heavens, the gospel has been preached to all nations; and accepted, more or less, by the kings and potentates of the earth.

And, as the prophet called on the people of old, to awake and arise and turn to the coming light, so St. Paul invited and animated his converts and their brethren, to awake and behold the glory of the Lord, after it had been fully revealed to the dark and sinful world; and so do the ministers of Christ, in every age, call upon their hearers to arouse from their benighted and lost condition, and let this light shine upon their understandings and hearts, and direct them in the way of life and salvation. For grieved are we to say, that notwithstanding these bright beams of grace and truth have been so long pouring forth their splendour upon the earth, yet are there many dark corners; and many eyes awfully closed against the light: and still more grieved are we to say, that even in the land where these beams have shone

brightest, even in this land, vast numbers yet remain total strangers to their enlightening influence and converting power: numbers who have had the benefit of being educated under the gospel, who have witnessed its happy effects; who have seen what it has done for their relations, or friends, or neighbours, have yet ungratefully and disdainfully turned away from the heavenly light, and “walked on still in darkness;” have sided with the world and Satan and sin, and resisted the salvation of their souls.

O, that they could be brought, O for the grace of God’s Holy Spirit to bring them, to listen to the warning words of that merciful Saviour, to whom, if they now continue to despise Him, they will one day lift up their hands in vain: these are His words, “if the light that is in thee be darkness, how great is that darkness.” ^[12] If, after all the gracious offers of pardon and life, which thy Redeemer has made thee, by His own mouth, and the mouth of His messengers, thou still chooseth unforgiveness and death, going on in the heedlessness of thy impenitent heart, and wantoning in sin, how dreadful is thy condition! how infinitely more dreadful, than if the voice of mercy had never sounded in thine ears. Be convinced: let the love of thy Saviour work upon thee; let the love of thine own immortal soul move thee to fly unto Him, the great, the only, the everlasting Redeemer. Leave thy way of misery and ruin, and turn to Him for comfort and deliverance. Turn, while thou hast the power; the night is fast coming. Thou knowest not how many more sabbaths, how many more invitations and warnings, will be vouchsafed: many thou hast had already; enough of them thou hast already slighted. Come, ye that are strong, for the strong are often laid low; come, ye that are young, for the young are not always spared; come, ye aged, for your hour of trial *must* be nearly run out. Come all, while ye may, to the Lamb of God, for acceptance and for blessing: there is no safety, and no hope in any other: and no hope in Him, when the door is once shut; “we pray you, in Christ’s stead, be ye reconciled to God.” ^[13]

The text says, “Awake thou that sleepest;” it means, awake from the sleep of sin; and very fitly is the state of the sinner compared to a state of sleep: he is quite insensible of his true, his awful condition; he fears not, perceives not, the doom that is awaiting him. Satan has bound up his senses; the eyes of his understanding are closed, and his knowledge of good and evil is utterly prevented. He is to the spiritual world, what the sleeping man is to the natural, unconscious of what is going forward to his advantage or his

injury. Speak to him of mercy, he hears not: “sing him one of the songs of Sion,” it is all in vain: speak to him of divine wrath, of eternal punishment; to what purpose, while his ear is closed? The whispers of conscience, the counsel of friends, “the tongues of men or of angels,” are alike unprofitable, while a deep sleep is cast upon the soul.

And there is a further resemblance: the sinner dreams, of happiness arising from worldly prosperity, from plenty and pleasure: and as the brain of a poor or disconsolate man, in a state of sleep, is often filled with ideas of such things, and he awakes and finds them sadly untrue; awakes from his pleasant dreaming to his state of drudgery and discomfort; so is the sinner often constrained to feel and confess, that his notions of happiness were no better than a dream; that they were unsubstantial and unreal, promising much and bringing little: still he is unconvinced; pursues his course of trifling, his disappointed dreamings, till at length he awakes in another world, and thoroughly perceives the wretchedness of his condition, which it is then too late, impossible to change. From this dreadful, fatal sleep of sin, the gospel is designed to rouse us: and I pray God, that our conscience may be effectually alarmed and awakened; that we may be alive and active in perceiving and following “the things that belong unto our peace!”

The text says further, “Arise from the dead;” from the death of sin; from the state of misery and ruin, in which ye insensibly lie. Here is another significant figure: the impenitent sinner is not only plunged into a condition of helpless wretchedness, but he has no energy to recover from it, no quickening or effectual desire of better things; no more perception of spiritual interests, of heavenly objects, than a corpse has of the natural world. When once the breath has left the body, the busiest scenes of earth can affect it no longer; nothing can “charm the dull cold ear of death:” when the breath of a divine life is not in the soul, when the new-creating spirit of God is not received and cherished, the beauty of holiness and the all-important interests of a spiritual and eternal world produce no effect upon the forlorn understanding and the deserted heart: no representations of spiritual truth can move the heavy ear of a besotted and determined sinner; none, while he is resolved, so to remain: not even the voice of the Son of God, “charm He never so wisely.” Till the heart be moved to repentance, till, the faculties of the soul are recovered from the fascination of stupor and sin, no living impression can be made, even with all the force that truth can

carry. How often do we find this to be the case! how often does the sinner acknowledge the justice, the certainty, the necessity of what is urged upon him, but without any alteration in his character; without any effectual or lasting alteration. His heart is unchanged: the slave of sin; dead in sin; not alive or open to the force of truth, to the doctrines of righteousness or salvation.

Infatuated sinner! thine own conscience accuses thee; thou believest that there will be a world to come, a world of recompence, and yet thou turnest not to prepare for it; pray, when thou fearest; pray, when thou thinkest of these things; cry earnestly to thy Saviour, that he may deliver thee from this “gall of bitterness and this bond of iniquity;” pray for the convincing, converting, life-giving Spirit, that He may “set thine heart at liberty” from the thralldom of sin; and thus enable thee to listen to the call of the gospel, and turn thy feet in earnest to the Redeemer of thy soul. For if thou listenest and turnest not, “dead thou art while thou livest;” and when thou diest, eternally dead; dead to all comfort and happiness for ever; dead in a world of woe.

But if we will (and God grant that we all may) awake and arise, “Christ will assuredly give us light:” “He is the true light, which lighteth every man that cometh into the world;” ^[18] ready to shine upon every soul, to lighten it in darkness and quicken it in death. Believe in Him, and live in Him, and the clouds of ignorance shall be scattered away; and the drowsiness of the soul shall be cast off; and the cold heart of the natural man shall be warm with life again. In the midst of this world’s temptations and trials, troubles and perplexities, we shall see our way clear, our way to the heavenly Jerusalem; a brightness, the brightness of God’s presence, will be resting upon our souls; the world sees it not, but we shall see and enjoy it every hour: dark things will be made light, and “crooked things will be made straight, and the rough places plain:” we shall be living above the world, for “our life will be hid with Christ in God:” ^[19] cheerful we shall be when nature is sad: inspirited when nature is languishing; full of praises and thanksgivings when nature is mourning.

Say, Christian people, have ye never seen the triumph of faith over nature’s weakness and Satan’s power? have ye never, in the hour of trial, witnessed that the Saviour was near? never observed the fainting spirit animated and

sustained? never beheld the closing eye, of the dying saint, beaming with heavenly fire; and the pale features lighted up with the smile of satisfaction and composure and peace? If ye have not, the dying Christian will shew you these things—go to his bed, and learn the lesson; go, and catch the hope, that “Christ will give you light.”

SERMON II.

THE UNSEARCHABLE RICHES OF CHRIST.

EPH. iii 8.

The unsearchable riches of Christ.

THERE is no passage, in the whole range of Scripture, in which the benefits and blessings of the gospel are more strikingly and fully represented, than by these few words: it is elsewhere described as the “pearl of great price,” as “the treasure that fadeth not away,” as “the true riches;” but here, as if in addition to the former descriptions, it is called, under the direction of the Holy Spirit, “the unsearchable riches of Christ:” impossible for men, impossible for angels to search out and discover its full excellency and value. The more it is examined, and the more it is experimentally known, the more is the believer convinced of the propriety and truth of this description; without a deep enquiry indeed, without a vital experience of its blessedness, it is not for any one to understand even the nature of its transcendent riches; to the world at large they are known only by name: but the sincere Christian, who makes them his own, is brought to admire their inexhaustible fulness; and to perceive, how utterly they extend beyond his comprehension, how highly they are removed above his loftiest thoughts and his most ardent imagination: “eye hath not seen, nor ear heard, neither have entered into the heart of man the things which God hath prepared for them that love him.” ^[21] They lie entirely out of the reach of the natural man; and even the spiritual man does but imperfectly understand them.

These unsearchable riches it was the province of St. Paul especially to declare unto the gentile world, that is, unto the world at large, when the offer of them had been rejected by the Jewish nation: in consequence of which blessed communication to the gentiles, the knowledge of them was conveyed, in process of time, to our favoured land.

Many learned persons have believed, that St. Paul himself preached in this island; of this, however, there is no certain evidence; it is enough for us to know, that we are partakers of the benefit of his preaching, that the sound of the gospel, which he sent “forth into all lands,” has long ago reached us; and that we are now in the full enjoyment of this inestimable privilege. He declares, in the chapter, before us, that Jesus Christ, by express revelation, made known to him the great mystery, the unfathomable purpose of His mercy; “which in other ages was not made known unto the sons of men, as it is now revealed unto the holy Apostles and Prophets by the Spirit: that the Gentiles should be fellow-heirs, and of the same body, and partakers of His promise in Christ by the gospel.” Unto me, he says, “who am less than the least of all saints, is this grace given, that I should preach among the Gentiles the unsearchable riches of Christ. And to make all men see what is the fellowship of the mystery, which, from the beginning of the world, hath been hid in God, who created all things by Jesus Christ.” [\[23\]](#)

You perceive here the object of the Apostle’s preaching; it was, that all mankind, we among the number, might be brought acquainted with the glorious scheme of eternal redemption, and be made partakers of its unspeakable blessings. And is there a heart so cold, as not to beat with gratitude, in the remembrance of such mercy; as not to take an interest in such a testimony of divine love? If we knew no particulars respecting it, the very announcement and promise of an infinite treasure, of a treasure in the mansions of eternity, were sufficient to awaken our most profound attention: it often does so, when carried by the missionary to the heathen and the stranger; they, who never heard before the good tidings of salvation, are arrested by the voice of the messenger, and hang upon his lips with a longing anxiety, and receive his message to the comfort of their souls: and can we remain unmoved by such considerations; we, who know the purport of the heavenly message; we, who profess to believe that it is sent for our everlasting salvation from sin and death; to reconcile us to an offended God, to deliver us from the intolerable bondage of Satan, to make us happy while we live, happy when we die, happy for ever in another world, in the kingdom of heaven? Though the mercy is too great to be adequately understood, though “the love of Christ passeth knowledge,” shall this prevent us from contemplation and enquiry? shall we not rather, on this very account, entertain a more fervent desire to understand and know, of

this mystery of goodness, all that is possible to be known? Whoever, indeed, has not this desire, cannot take any lively interest in the revelation which he professes to believe, cannot have sincerely embraced it; knowing, as he does, the subject and purpose of the gospel, he is in a worse situation than many an ignorant heathen; his heart more hard and unimpressible; his eyes more closed against the light; his affections more difficult to be roused and engaged. May the Lord touch the heart of all such heedless professors; or the very publicans and sinners, the darkest and most despised of the earth, will “enter into the kingdom of heaven before them.”

Hoping that we all are deeply concerned in this important matter, that we do place a most exalted value on the riches of Christ, and earnestly desire to partake of them, I beg that we may enter together, with humble minds and spiritual desires, into some examination of their nature and excellency; and enquire in what respects, and for what reasons, they are unsearchable.

1. In the first place, what is the foundation of all our blessedness and all our hope, as the redeemed and adopted children of God; as brought from a state of enmity and rebellion, into favour with Him; as having any claim upon His mercy; any prospect of recovering our lost happiness, of saving our souls alive? What, I say, is the foundation on which we expect these marvellous acts of grace? It is, that the everlasting Son of God left “the glory which he had with the Father before the world was,” ^[26a] and “took upon Him the form of a servant,” ^[26b] the nature of man: it is, that the “Word, who in the beginning was with God and was God,” “was made flesh” and came and “dwelt among us, full of grace and truth.” ^[26c] Here then, in the very outset, is unsearchable mercy; the immensity of the divine Redeemer’s condescension and love! Who can search, who can understand it? “It is higher than heaven, what canst thou know” of it? Admire thou mayest, and adore and love; but it is beyond the stretch of thy created powers to conceive, beyond the capacity of any creature. The great truth is revealed and the work is accomplished; and here thou must leave it, in humble faith and overwhelming emotion.

2. We may consider, in the next place, the preciousness, the value, the efficacy of the incarnation and sufferings of our Redeemer. All the attributes of the Godhead are perfect and infinite; His holiness and justice, as well as His mercy. Man, by transgression, fell into a state of unholiness;

his nature became corrupt; his understanding debased, his affections and passions and desires all sinful; as such he could not possibly be accepted or blest by the infinitely holy God, by Him “who is of purer eyes than to behold iniquity:” he became, to borrow the language of men, vile and hateful in God’s sight; he resembled Satan and the wicked spirits, who fell, for their transgression, from the heavens. And so, with regard to justice; the infinitely just God could not, without some means of atonement or satisfaction, shew favour to a disobedient, offending, rebellious creature; it was contrary to His essential character and nature so to do: nor can we form any true idea of the value of that sacrifice, on the part of another, which could be held sufficient to reconcile the great Jehovah to a creature “laden with iniquity:” the displeasure being infinite, the distance and separation between God and His creatures infinite, the sacrifice must be infinite also, and exceeding the bounds of our comprehension. And yet, strange to say, though the means of the sinner’s re-admission, to the favour and blessing of a holy and just God, must of necessity be beyond our powers of conception, there are persons, who object to the Christian doctrine of the atonement, solely on the ground of its being incomprehensible. But we, my brethren, “have not so learned Christ;” we are ready to bow with thankfulness to the revelation of the great Jehovah, by whose unsearchable wisdom and mercy the plan of our redemption was formed: we are ready to acknowledge with reverence, that “great is the mystery of godliness; God was manifest in the flesh.” ^[29a]

3. Intimately connected with this consideration is the recollection of God’s exceeding love towards us, in that “while we were yet sinners Christ died for us.” ^[29b] In our very state of guilt and rebellion it was, that He came into the world; that He did and suffered so much, “to seek and to save that which was lost.” Suppose that man had never transgressed; and that God had sent an angel, to shew him the way to a happier and higher condition, than that in which he was created: this would have been an act of free and undeserved mercy; but that He should have sent His beloved Son, to “suffer for sins, the just for the unjust,” ^[29c] to be born and to tabernacle in a world of guilt and sorrow; to be exposed to rejection and scorn, to indignity and cruelty; to endure the conflicts of Satan and the bitterest agonies of death; this was indeed an act of love, surpassing the bounds of thought; a mystery of goodness “into which angels desire to look,” but cannot penetrate. Every

believing soul must be overpowered by such a contemplation; must be lost in wonder, love, and praise.

4. Nor can we learn the manner or degree, in which our merciful Lord is at this moment bestowing blessings upon His Church, and upon every individual believer. When He ascended up to heaven, His work of mediation was not finished; He then took upon Him the office of interceding for His people in all ages: presenting their prayers, and desires, and all their services, for acceptance at the throne of grace; pleading His merits for them; observing all their necessities and wants; and sending His holy spirit and His holy angels, to minister to their infirmities: not a wounded spirit, but He is still ready to bind up and heal; not a sigh from a contrite heart, but He knows and answers; not a child of ignorance, but He is willing to instruct; not a returning prodigal, but He meets; not a prayer or thanksgiving, not a godly thought or wish, of a sincere worshipper and pious servant, but He accepts and blesses: He is ever with us, though unseen; with us by His providence and grace; “about our bed and about our path;” pouring his benefits upon us, temporal, and spiritual: yea upon all His people, at every moment of time, throughout the whole world. We are lost in this mystery of mercy—we can but believe, and gratefully apply the benefit to our souls.

5. And what are the privileges of Christ’s redeemed people? What their present state, what their glorious inheritance? How unsearchable both the one and the other! The humble believer, the repenting sinner, the sincere and faithful servant derives, from the fountain of mercy which is opened unto him, a perpetual stream of increasing satisfaction and delight; he finds, that “there is no end thereof;” that it is a fountain, which he never can fathom. The sense of pardon and reconciliation with God affords a comfort to his soul, which flows the more abundantly, the longer he dwells upon it; as he journies onward in the way of salvation, his hopes are more enlivened, and his fears more calmed; even when he began to walk with his God, he felt that all around him was joy, and deemed his recompence in this life amply sufficient; but, at every step he advances in communion with his God and Saviour, he perceives more and more that “His ways are ways of pleasantness and all His paths are peace;” ^[32] and this experience will be enlarged the longer he lives, even beyond his present anticipation. The word of God has fresh stores for him every day; of knowledge, of comfort,

and of grace: the Spirit of God has fresh supplies; to succour his infirmities, to elevate him in prayer and meditation, to guide him in perplexity, to strengthen him in trial, to console him in trouble and affliction, to raise him above the world, and place his affections in heaven. Thus will his joy in the Lord increase, till he comes to the end of his pilgrimage: and, in the end, the riches of redeeming love will be infinitely enhanced: who shall number or declare them? Which of us can now understand the preciousness of a Christian's hope, the comfort of a Christian's peace, at that hour, when his soul is struggling for departure? Who can now enter, as the dying man does, into the vast difference between the bright hope of being saved, and the gloomy fear of being lost; between the prospect of being for ever with the Lord, and the dismal foreboding of the terrors of the evil one? We have now but a slight conception of the feelings and views, in that momentous hour; but we shall one day know: God grant that the knowledge may be peace!

And if we die in peace, then shall we be more than ever convinced of the truth of the text; we shall then perceive, how little we comprehended, in our mortal state, of the blessedness of the saints at rest, of "the rest that remaineth for the people of God." And, at the resurrection, other scenes will follow, with more abundant tokens of confirmation: who can conceive the happiness of rising with the just; of hearing with joy the trumpet of the archangel; of beholding, with an eye of rapture, the beaming of that glorious morn; of meeting the smile of a compassionate Judge and Saviour; of being called to His right hand, "come, ye blessed of my father, inherit the kingdom prepared for you from the foundation of the world:" [\[34a\]](#) what mind on earth is equal to these things?

And then will succeed the consummation of our felicity, "the new heavens and the new earth, wherein dwelleth righteousness;" [\[34b\]](#) the enjoyment of the presence of God and the Lamb; the personal sharing of the service, the honour, and the delight of angels and archangels, through all eternity. Of this we cannot pretend to form an estimate in our mortal condition; while the veil is hanging before our eyes; the holy Spirit, by many a sublime image, lifts our imagination as high as it can be carried; but still, the representation must be feeble, when compared with the glorious reality; after all that has been said, if we arrive at the heavenly city, the appearance will be new, the happiness new to us all. Unsearchable it is now,

unsearchable it will be then; a wonder of love that will never be satisfied, a mansion of glory that will never be completely surveyed.

But we shall doubtless behold, on seeing “face to face,” more of the fulness of the riches of Christ; shall penetrate further into that mystery of divine love, which planned the merciful work of our redemption before the foundation of the world; shall see more of the meetness of the Saviour’s sufferings; of His mighty conquest over sin and death; of the greatness of His kingdom and the “majesty of His glory.” We shall then see and admire that now invisible bond, by which the whole company of the Lord’s servants and people, heavenly and earthly, have been sustained and kept together: how men below, and saints at rest, and angels in heaven, have been bound in spiritual union, through all the ages of time; how the vast multitude of holy creatures in the universe have felt a common interest and benefit in their blessed Lord. ^[36] When they are all assembled together in adoration round His throne, we shall know more of this endearing bond; it will then be manifest, and be perfected for ever.

I need not attempt to go further; certainly none of us will deny the unsearchableness of the riches of Christ. Certainly every one of us is ready to exclaim, O that I may be partaker of them; all this world, nay, a thousand worlds are nothing in comparison. These riches are now offered to you: they are waiting your acceptance; receive them with all your heart, and they are yours; you do not expect them to be forced upon you; you do not expect this happy portion without choosing it, without prayer and without striving for it; ask earnestly, seek diligently, and it shall be yours; your inexhaustible treasure, in time and to eternity.

SERMON III.

THE DESTRUCTION OF THE FLOOD.

GENESIS vi. 6. 7.

It repented the Lord, that He had made man upon the earth and it grieved Him at His heart; and the Lord said, I will destroy man, whom I have created, from the face of the earth.

THE expression in the former clause of the text has, to some persons, afforded matter of surprise; and certainly the language is remarkable; representing the Almighty as repenting of the work of creation, and grieved at the heart, not merely on account of the wickedness of man, but that he was ever made. Yet the language, when properly considered, is no more remarkable, than that of numberless other passages in Holy Writ; it is stronger perhaps; it may carry the customary mode of speech somewhat further; but that is all. We are perfectly aware, that the Godhead is incapable of being affected and changed by contrary passions, as we are; the purpose of Jehovah is fixed, upon the basis of infinite wisdom, from everlasting to everlasting; nothing can occur, of which He was previously ignorant; nothing to afford any grief or uneasiness; “known unto God are all His works from the beginning of the world;” ^[39] and it is impossible for us to interpret the text, or any similar phrase, according to the sense in which we understated such words, when applied to creatures like ourselves.

It was absolutely necessary for the inspired writers, in describing the nature and dealings and dispensations of God, to have recourse to such terms, as we are in the habit of using towards one another. His constant observance of us is represented by saying, that the eye of God is upon all our ways; His gracious readiness to answer our prayers, is represented by saying, that His ear is ever open: but who ever supposes that eye or ear, or any bodily parts, are possessed by the Godhead? So neither are we to impute to God, who is

a pure spirit, any bodily passions; though He is said to love and to hate, to be angry and to be pleased. Of course it only means, that the effect of any particular conduct or transaction of His creatures upon Him, is similar to what it would be upon us, when under the influence of our natural passions; that He rewardeth good, as we do, when we love or are pleased; and punisheth evil, as we do, when we hate or are angry. The text merely intimates the measure, which the Almighty was determined to adopt, in consequence of the great and universal wickedness of mankind; of their having so far fallen from the noble end of their creation.

Having tried many gracious methods of indulgence with them, and sought to reclaim them by every probable and possible means, and having found that His goodness and forbearance, instead of “leading them to repentance,” only hardened them in guilt, He now saw fit to change His overtures of mercy into the sentence of condemnation; and to send a deluge for the destruction of that people, who would not “turn and live:” and this is all that can be intended by God’s repentance and grief.

But it happened in those days, as it has too frequently happened with the sinful and rebellious ever since, that the people believed not the threatenings denounced against them; whether they doubted the power of God to inflict so extraordinary a punishment; or whether they built their hopes upon the vain expectation of His mercy; or whether the wickedness of their hearts and lives led them entirely to cast off the belief of God and His word, and to plunge unheeding into the gratifications and pollutions of vice; whatever were the operating motive, “they would not turn and seek after God.” Yet these infatuated people were not lost for want of further instruction and admonition. God mercifully thinks of His creatures, though they are forgetful of Him. He had raised unto them preachers of righteousness; and sent His Holy Spirit to work upon their consciences, to convert them from the delusions of evil, to teach them the knowledge of His ways, and persuade them to desist from their work of self-destruction. But there is a day, to nations as well as to individuals, beyond which the goodness and patience of God will no longer forbear: “My spirit,” says He, in the chapter before us, “shall not always strive with man.” It had been working in the human heart, ever since the fall; inspiring His servants to point out the way of salvation; and struggling with the wayward inclinations, the perverse opposition of His creatures; to mortify the power

of sin, and lead them to recover the favour and happiness, which their first parents by transgression had lost. But it shall not *always* strive; and the approaching termination of their trial was thus graciously declared to this “disobedient and gainsaying people.” God spake thus by the mouth of Noah: “The days of man (the time which I will allow, to see if ‘haply he will repent and seek after Me,’) shall be a hundred and twenty years.” ^[43a] All this period was to elapse between the denunciation of the divine vengeance and its execution; and to this St. Peter alludes, when speaking of “the long-suffering of God, that waited in the days of Noah, while the ark was preparing;” ^[43b] while Noah himself, the great “preacher of righteousness,” warned all around him of the certainty and the terror of this impending calamity. All entreaties, however, and warnings, and threatenings; all present mercies and past experiences, were vain. They despised the faith and rejected the preaching of the patriarch, and ridiculed his preparation of the ark; but they could not “make the word of God of none effect;” His judgment overtook them in the midst of their rebellious career; the flood came at the appointed time; desolation was spread over the face of the earth; and all its inhabitants, with the exception of one family, were indiscriminately involved in the wide-wasting ruin.

Let us pause for a moment, to apply the consideration of this part of the history to ourselves. To all who are wilfully walking in the ways of sin, the good and gracious God is continually addressing His warning and expostulating voice; by His holy word, abounding with the most awakening admonitions and awful examples; by His appointed ministers, superadding their feeble endeavours to inculcate the doctrines and set forth the terrors of that word “by line upon line and precept upon precept;” by various occurrences in life, by reverses and privations and afflictions and sickness and death; by the strivings of the Holy Spirit, and the alarms of conscience; by flashing at intervals, in vivid colours, the conviction of an hereafter upon the mind and heart; and compelling the sinner to see, whether he will heed it or not, the peril and the dreadfulfulness of his situation. Of all who hear me there cannot be one, but has experienced, more or less, these manifestations of mercy and of terror: Are there not some by whom they have been disregarded? We have all of us been instructed and reminded and admonished, in a great variety of ways; have we “profited withal?” Have we been awakened from the dreams of sensual pleasures, from the stupor

and infatuation of sin? Can we now lift up our hearts in sincerity to God, and thank Him that we have been brought, by this or that warning, into nearer and holier communion with Him; to serve Him in righteousness and truth, and to seek, in right earnest, the salvation of our souls? If it be otherwise with us, if we have neglected the seasons of grace, or if we have returned, after a temporary humiliation and conviction to the vanity of our former habits and pursuits, let us, if we believe the word of God, lay seriously to heart the solemn declarations on this head, with which that word abounds—that there is a limit prescribed even for the divine compassion and forbearance; a period marked out, beyond which God will not manifest His favour, “though it be sought with tears;” beyond which, “His spirit will not strive with man;” and whenever that spirit shall be withdrawn, the conscience will become hardened, the understanding benighted, and the sinner “given over to a reprobate mind.” God allows, indeed He has already allowed, to every one of us, abundant space and opportunity for repentance, as He did of old to the ante-diluvian race; and if we, like them, are negligent of His merciful admonitions, we must expect, like them, to go on from one degree of wickedness to another, till the “measure of our iniquity be filled;” till we are hurried into everlasting perdition.

No doubt, when the threatenings of the Almighty began to be executed; when the mighty waters were descending from above, and rising in billows from the deep below; when these people saw the ark, whose building and preparation they had despised, floating in security upon the surface of the waters, gladly would they have been admitted: no longer did they question the power of God, or the truth of His word; or hold in contempt the preaching of His prophets; earnest then, no doubt, was their supplication for mercy; and they must have wished, in the bitterness of their hearts, that they had listened to the declarations and instructions of that holy minister of God, who was provided with a refuge; who was escaping unhurt amidst the rolling of the waves, which threatened *them* with immediate and inevitable destruction. But their conviction came too late; the days of reconciliation were ended; the door of the ark was shut; never to be opened again, till the flood had wrought its vengeance, and exterminated the sinners from the earth.

Has not the like, the parallel of this dreadful case, been frequently discovered by ourselves? Have we not seen, or at least heard of persons, who have held out impenitently all their lives long against every means of grace and reclaim, by which they have been visited, and then at last, when suddenly overtaken by a sickness unto death, have distressfully desired that comfort and refuge, which they have never appeared to find? Their attention has been called, their eye directed to the ark of salvation, the gospel of the blessed Jesus; but having taken no interest in it before, having discarded and rejected it, they have seemed to behold it only in dismay and despair. Man, it is true, is not an adequate judge in such a case; he could not possibly decide, whether they were saved or not; but there was fear all around; their friends were denied the consolation of persuading themselves, that the door of mercy was opened; the sinner cried in agony, but there was no visible sign, that the cry was heard; no respite to the afflicted conscience; and no repose upon the countenance, that betokened the blessedness of peace.

Suppose not, that this is a scene portrayed for the mere purpose of a momentary excitement or present effect; it is a true description of what has too frequently occurred; and it falls indeed, as every representation must fall, infinitely short of the terrible reality. Readily can we imagine the sufferings and sorrow and distress of the people, who were drowning, with the ark before their eyes; and must we not conclude, that the impenitent sinner under the gospel, when he comes to die, will behold, with even deeper feelings of anguish, the ark of righteousness into which he has never sought to enter; when he finds or fears, that the overflowings of ungodliness are sinking his soul to ruin, can any description exaggerate, can any description equal, the wretchedness of his condition?

The very idea and contemplation of these things may well lead us, with all sincerity and fervour, to implore the grace of God, while it is so freely offered, and to “seek Him while He may be found;” and O that it may lead us gladly and unfeignedly to embrace the covenant of safety, which is graciously propounded to us in the gospel; and to “give all diligence” to fulfil every condition which that covenant contains. We shall not, if we value our eternal welfare, think it sufficient not to “deny the Lord that bought us,” not to despise the means which He has provided for our preservation and deliverance; we shall turn to Him with all our heart,

grateful for the means of salvation, and anxious to employ them all. “Lord what wilt Thou have me to do?” ^[50a] “Speak, Lord, for thy servant heareth;” ^[50b] this is the language that befits a sinner, who has no hope but in God’s covenanted mercy.

“Our time is in the Lord’s hands;” we know not, if little or much remain: Arise, defer not a day. His spirit is now striving within us; to purify our affections, to change our corrupt nature, to form the christian principle and temper in our souls; let us then, without doubt or delay, humbly and thankfully concur with His holy operations, and strive with Him, while we may: not lingering and loitering about the ark with thoughtless indifference, as if our minds were not made up, whether it be worth while to enter; but, in the full and perfect and abiding persuasion, that it is the only refuge for man, let us secure, as far as it is possible, our rest and habitation there; and then we need not fear the overwhelming of the waters, come they ever so suddenly or ever so soon; we shall be raised above them all, unhurt and undismayed; we shall ride safely and triumphantly over the foaming billows; and settle at last upon the heavenly Ararat, the “mountain of the Lord of Hosts,” the everlasting abode of tranquillity and bliss.

But of this happy termination we shall have occasion to speak more at large, in another discourse; when we come to treat of the character of Noah, and the circumstances of his wonderful preservation. In the mean time, let us observe, that the deluge is a subject of most awful consideration; not merely in itself, as sweeping away into perdition almost all the human race, and changing the very form and structure of the globe; but also as being a resemblance and emblem of other visitations of an offended and avenging God:—in the first place, of the overthrow of Jerusalem, and the miserable and general destruction of its rebellious people. “As the days of Noe were, so shall also the coming of the Son of man be. For as in the days that were before the flood they were eating and drinking, marrying and giving in marriage, until the day that Noe entered into the ark, and knew not until the flood came and took them all away; so shall also the coming of the Son of man be;” ^[53a] so unlooked for, so amazing, so disastrous to His enemies.

This stupendous event may also be regarded as typical of another period, infinitely surpassing all the rest in terror and in awe;—the coming of Christ to judge the world, to execute His final vengeance upon those who would

not be reclaimed by His mercy. The face of nature will then be destroyed by another process; by a direful and universal conflagration. “By the word of God the heavens were of old, and the earth standing out of the water and in the water: whereby the world that then was, being overflowed with water, perished: but the heavens and the earth, which are now, by the same word are kept in store, reserved unto fire against the day of judgment and perdition of ungodly men.” ^[53b] “Nevertheless we, according to His promise, look for new heavens and a new earth, (a new state) wherein dwelleth righteousness. Wherefore, beloved, seeing that ye look for such things, be diligent that ye may be found of Him in peace, without spot, and blameless.” ^[54a] All that have ever lived shall be summoned again into existence; the righteous to be separated, and “caught up to meet the Lord in the air,” ^[54b] and to be conveyed into the regions of eternal blessedness; the wicked, to perish, to die, not a bodily but a spiritual death; to be consigned together to a place of banishment and wretchedness and horror and despair. The miserable unbelievers and the obstinate transgressors, in the days of Noah, shall then return to the earth from which they were swept away; not to enjoy again their revelry and licentiousness; not to be favoured with another day of grace; but to receive, with all their companions in evil, with all that have ever “followed their pernicious ways,” the full and eternal recompence of their deeds. This will indeed be a day of desolation, “of lamentation and mourning and woe,” of “weeping and wailing and gnashing of teeth;” of which awful day no words, no example, no past event, nor even imagination itself, can afford an adequate representation.

God Almighty grant, that we may never know its terrors; that we may profit from the warnings and experience, which are mercifully vouchsafed unto us; may embrace, with all our hearts, the covenant of salvation into which we have professedly entered; and, amidst the wreck and ruin of the world, may be delivered with an everlasting deliverance, for the sake, and through the merits, of that omnipotent Saviour, who was with Noah in the ark; who has guarded, and will continue to guard, the ark of His Church in all ages; whose mercy and truth are pledged for the final preservation of His faithful people: God Almighty grant this blessing unto us all, through the aid and operation of that “Holy Spirit, whereby we are sealed unto the day of redemption.” ^[55]

SERMON IV.

THE PRESERVATION FROM THE FLOOD.

GENESIS vi. 8.

Noah found grace in the eyes of the Lord.

IN a former discourse, your attention was called to the execution of divine vengeance upon the sinful race of man, by the tremendous visitation of a universal deluge; I would now direct your contemplation to another point of view; to a fulfilment of the gracious promises of God made to a distinguished believer and a faithful servant; to his preservation from the general ruin; to the covenants of mercy established with him; to the blessings and deliverances thus proclaimed and typified to the Church of God in all ages.

Noah, be it first observed, was possessed of that principle, which is the sure and only foundation of true righteousness; and to which the Almighty has, in every age, manifested His especial favour—the principle of *faith*; of a settled, vital, influential belief in the sovereignty, the providence, and the word of God: he doubted not the truth either of a threatening or a promise, and withheld not the obedience, which his belief implied or required. Of this St. Paul assures us; “By faith Noah, being warned of God of things not seen as yet, moved with fear, prepared an ark to the saving of his house; by the which he condemned the world, and became heir of the righteousness which is by faith;” ^[52] he condemned the world, inasmuch as his example, his preaching, and his deliverance furnished matter of accusation against them; he pointed out and led the way to a place of safety; he escaped destruction, and the rest of the people might have escaped also; and thus he proved, that they justly perished in the unbelief and obstinacy of their hearts. Hence he became the heir of those promises and that happiness, to which the righteous believer, by God’s mercy, is entitled; he was blessed,

not merely with that temporal preservation, which the ark afforded him in the flood; but also with that spiritual and heavenly salvation, of which the ark was an emblem and a sign.

And further; Noah is described, in the verse following the text, as “a just man and perfect in his generations.” His faith, as we have already intimated, was not, like that of many professors of religion, a mere outward and formal assent; it resided in his heart, as well as in his understanding; and shewed itself in his disposition, his character, and his life. Believing in the goodness of God, he loved Him; in the power and justice of God, he feared; in the infallible truth and authority of God, he obeyed. With an enlightened reason and conscience, he studied the duty of ordinary life; his duty to God and man; and he performed it faithfully. “He was perfect in his generations;” not that he had attained unto absolute, positive perfection; for that is impossible to any mere man, in his fallen condition; it was only “the man Christ Jesus,” the incarnate God, that was “holy, harmless, undefiled, separate from sinners;” ^[59] but Noah, in the midst of a “disobedient and gainsaying people,” was sincere and upright; he lived in no wilful or habitual opposition to his God; he had that degree of perfection, which is the mark and fruit of genuine faith; and shews, that the frail creature is brought into a state of acceptance with his Creator. He engaged heartily in the cause of religion; there was nothing in the world, which he was not ready to renounce for it; there was no ordinance, nor command of God, which it was not his unbending purpose to obey; desirous was he “to serve Him, in holiness and righteousness all the days of his life.” And therefore it is yet further said, that “he walked with God;” ^[60a] “setting the Lord (as David speaks) always before him;” ^[60b] living in a perpetual sense of the divine presence; acting as under the continual observation of that Almighty Being, who was acquainted with all his ways; and whose word was “a lamp unto his feet and a light unto his path.” ^[60c] He walked in communion with God, by his life and conversation, as well as by faith, and meditation, and prayer; and he preached to a “backsliding and stubborn generation,” by his example as well as by his word.

We cannot wonder, that such eminent holiness and obedience, shining forth in the midst of so much profligacy and corruption, were honoured with the signal favour of Almighty God. A righteous character, which is always “of great price in the sight of God,” is peculiarly honourable in an age

overspread with impiety and guilt. The man, who stands forth to maintain the cause of God against a universal host of enemies; who is untainted by the moral contagion which is every where diffused around him; who perseveringly opposes the mighty stream of iniquity, which is ready to overwhelm his soul; that man is a spectacle for angels to behold with joy; and one in whom the holy God Himself is well-pleased; he is as “a light shining in a dark place,” made more conspicuous and attractive by the surrounding gloom. Such was Noah; and God distinguished him accordingly by especial tokens of favour and blessing: for He said, “Behold I, even I, do bring a flood of waters upon the earth, to destroy all flesh, wherein is the breath of life, from under heaven; and every thing that is in the earth shall die. But with thee will I establish my covenant; and thou shalt come into the ark, thou, and thy sons, and thy wife, and thy sons’ wives with thee.” [\[62a\]](#)

A question has been raised respecting the nature of the covenant here intended; but the words themselves, taken in connexion with the subject, would lead us to conclude, that the covenant to be established, in the first instance, was a covenant of safety in the ark, during the flood; and this sense is abundantly confirmed by the same word being afterwards used in the 9th chapter, when God made His promise to the patriarch, that the world should never again be so destroyed: “Behold, I establish my covenant with you, and with your seed after you, and with every living creature that is with you—neither shall all flesh be cut off any more by the waters of a flood; neither shall there any more be a flood to destroy the earth.” [\[62b\]](#) Yet, though this was the immediate import of the covenant, it probably had, like the ark itself, a further and a typical signification, which is thus very admirably expressed by one of the best commentators; “I will most certainly make good the promise I have formerly made to thee, of preserving thee and thy family from the said destruction; and further I will make good, in due time, to thee or thy seed after thee, *all* those covenants or promises, which I have made to mankind from the beginning of the world, and which remain to be made good; especially the grand covenant concerning the promised seed, of Messiah: to which end, I will certainly preserve thee and thy family from the destruction I am now bringing on the rest of mankind.” [\[63\]](#)

The first covenant made by God with Adam, was a covenant of works, of unsinning obedience; this was broken, and thence came death. The second covenant made with Adam, was that of grace and salvation by Jesus Christ, who should “come in the fulness of time;” this latter covenant was confirmed with Noah, the representative of mankind in the new world after the flood; and the covenant, thus renewed with him, was to extend to all his posterity; to generations unborn, to all that would become, as he was, “heirs of the righteousness which is by faith.” Through him, deliverance was preached to the people before the flood; through him, everlasting deliverance from sin and death was promised to believers in every future age. In the covenant, therefore, made with Noah, all mankind have an interest, an especial interest at this day; the promised deliverer, whom Noah represented, is come; we “have seen the salvation of our God;” the gospel of peace is proclaimed; and nothing is wanting but our faithful acceptance of it.

Proceed we now with the history of Noah’s preservation: “The waters prevailed exceedingly upon the earth (a hundred and fifty days), and all the high hills, that were under the whole heaven, were covered—and all flesh died that moved upon the earth, Noah only remained alive, and they that were with him in the ark. And the ark rested in the seventh month, upon the mountains of Ararat.” ^[65] Thus was the divine promise literally fulfilled, and the fidelity of the patriarch signally acknowledged and rewarded. What must have been the emotions of this holy man, as he was floating, through the long eventful period, upon the surface of the raging waters! How deep and lively his conviction of the adorable goodness and the perfect truth of God! How fervent his gratitude, how sublime his joy, at escaping unhurt amid the desolation of the world! How indescribable his feelings of horror and of awe, at the sufferings of those countless multitudes, who were perishing around him; over whose lifeless bodies he was riding in peaceful security, reserved to be the father of a new-born world! Similar to these are the impressions of every sincere believer, on beholding both the providential and spiritual dispensations of the Lord. Deeply is he convinced of the “goodness and severity of God;” of His goodness to the righteous, His severity to the disobedient and evil: Every divine promise and every denunciation of divine judgment have been fully accomplished in due season; “not one jot or one tittle of the word of God has failed.” The

Christian, moreover, by his own experience, can testify the truth and loving kindness of God: he has sought and found a refuge in the ark of salvation, in the gospel of peace; he has been taken out of a corrupt and troubled world, and raised above it; so that, while the billows of adversity have been rolling all around, and the overbearings of iniquity have every where prevailed, he has felt himself in a state of security; inclosed by divine mercy “on the right hand and on the left;” protected by the power of Jehovah; all things, even the most unruly elements, “working together for his good:” when “the rain descends, and the floods come, and the winds blow,” he hears and sees it all without dismay; nay, with gratitude to his heavenly Preserver; hoping and believing, that the waves of trouble are bearing him to the celestial Ararat, upon which he shall alight, in God’s appointed time, and “find rest unto his soul.”

But, in the midst of his satisfaction and joy, there is a consideration, which strikes a damp upon his soul, and fills him with grief and terror; it is, the miserable condition of those his fellow-creatures, who have been regardless of their salvation and have perished: the Saviour “called, but they would not answer;” He assured them of the coming desolation, but they would not take heed; He offered them mercy, but they turned away: and the flood came upon them unawares; and it is painful to think of them, where they now are, and how many they have been. And not only for those who are gone, but for numbers still living, does the charitable Christian also feel: it is not for him to be forward in judging, not for him to condemn; “he hopeth all things, and believeth all things;” but when he sees multitudes around him manifestly walking in the “broad way of destruction,” he cannot help feeling both pity and pain; especially if any of his neighbours or friends be found in this awful state of heedlessness and sin; especially if any who are near and dear unto him. He cannot help grieving for them; they will have, at least, his tears and his prayers. Would that such sinners might feel for themselves, what others feel for them; would that they might turn and live! Their case is not like the case of those who were perishing in the flood; they are not yet consigned to destruction; would to God that they might turn and live!

At length, “the waters were dried up from off the earth, and the face of the ground was dry.” “And Noah went forth” out of the ark, and “builded an altar unto the Lord, and offered burnt offerings upon the altar,” in

thanksgiving for his miraculous preservation; “and the Lord smelled a sweet savour;” ^[69] He accepted the incense of the sacrifice, approved and honoured the piety and gratitude of Noah.

In all our deliverances and escapes, in all the benefits and blessings we receive at the merciful hands of God, let us never fail to imitate this bright example of righteousness: be it our first, our immediate act, to waft unto the skies the incense of adoration and praise. The faithful and observant Christian does indeed perpetually notice the interposition of divine Providence in his behalf; and he never fails to render the tribute of his heart at least, if not of his lips, to the great Deliverer: but besides this, there are few of us, who have not, in some striking instances, been wonderfully rescued from imminent danger and destruction; preserved in frightful accident, or raised from a sickness which was seemingly unto death. Has the favour been duly remembered with gratitude? Did it bring us on our knees before the throne of mercy? Did we present our offering with that humble sense of our own unworthiness, and that devout acknowledgment of God’s love, which gave us just reason to believe that the offering was accepted, through Jesus Christ our Lord? And ever since, has an altar been raised in our hearts; have our affections been dedicated to God, as a memorial of the past deliverance, and a fulfilment of the purpose for which we were mercifully spared?

And there is a deliverance greater and mightier than all, of which every faithful servant in the gospel is enjoying, at once, both the hope and the benefit; a deliverance, of which Noah’s was a type, from the bondage and penalty of sin; from eternal misery, and ruin. Are we penetrated with a sense of this marvellous mercy? Do we worship our great Redeemer in spirit and in truth? Do we love Him with all our heart and soul? Do we proclaim abroad our gratitude and love, in the presence of a contemptuous world? Noah was immediately and powerfully reminded of the divine goodness accorded to himself, by beholding the face of nature all desolate and void: and thus, when we behold around us the dismal ravages of sin, and contemplate, with the eye of faith, the ruin which they will finally bring, are there not afforded to *us*, exulting as we are in the hope of our own redemption, abundant memorials of the favour of God to ourselves? “Bless the Lord, O my soul, and all that is within me, bless His holy name. Bless the Lord, O my soul, and forget not all His benefits: who redeemeth thy life

from destruction, and crowneth thee with loving kindness and tender mercies.” [\[71\]](#)

My brethren, if we would find, as “Noah found, grace in the eyes of the Lord,” we must be like him, in faith and obedience, in “faith which worketh by love.” We must be ready, at the divine command, to leave the “poms and vanity of a wicked world, and all the sinful lusts of the flesh,” and prepare the means of our deliverance, in the way which God mercifully points out. We must dare to be singular in the midst of a gainsaying and reviling people; and maintain our integrity in the face of a backsliding age. If, in the hour of danger and destruction, we would have God for our deliverer and friend, we must seek Him and serve Him, whilst we are in health and safety: thus will He be our portion in life, in death, in judgment, and for ever.

We are hereby led, in the last place, to consider the promise and pledge, which God was pleased to afford to the patriarch immediately after the flood; that “the waters would no more become a flood to destroy all flesh.” “I do set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be for a token of a covenant between me and the earth—and I will look upon it, that I may remember the everlasting covenant between God and every living creature of all flesh that is upon the earth.” Whether there had ever been a rainbow before the flood, is a point that cannot absolutely be determined; probably not; but if there had been, it makes no difference; the bow was then consecrated to be the token of a covenant of mercy, between God and man; and whenever the descending shower and the darkened sky recal to mind his former vengeance on the ungodly, we may take comfort on beholding this bright display of majesty and beauty, “this faithful witness in heaven;” [\[73\]](#) our hearts may then be gladdened by the remembrance and assurance of God’s everlasting love: we behold the seal of heaven, ratifying the promise of divine favour: and the believer may justly regard it, not only as a token of security against a future deluge, but also as a hopeful intimation of God’s mercy in all the storms of this mortal life, in every threatening flood. We may view it, with delighted eyes, as a blessed memorial of the truth and faithfulness of that Almighty Protector, whose word is pledged for the preservation of His people, at all times and under all possible circumstances. His mercies, of providence and grace, can never fail; and an earnest of these mercies we may discover, when we look upon the bow in

the cloud; it is, in a secondary sense at least, emblematical of God's everlasting covenant with His faithful people, that He will "never leave them nor forsake them."

Nor is it without authority, that we are thus extending the import of this heavenly sign: St. John in one of his beatific visions, "looked and behold a door was opened in heaven, and behold a throne was set in heaven, and there was a rainbow round about the throne." ^[75] The saints in light are thus represented as beholding the abode of their God, encircled with the token of His covenanted mercy; an evidence to them, that they have finally escaped the devastation of the world; that the floods and storms have for ever subsided; that none of the imperfections and troubles and dangers, from which they have been rescued, shall ever again disturb their mind or mar their happiness.

Hear then, in few words, the conclusion of the whole matter: let the destroying deluge awaken in us, by divine grace, a living conviction of the infallibility of God's word, of the certain "perdition of ungodly men;" let the deliverance of Noah and his family assure our hearts in the expectation of the glorious redemption of every believer and servant of God.

Let us enter the ark of salvation, prepared by our great Redeemer; enter and abide there; and we shall be carried triumphantly over the stormy elements of the world; and be conducted "unto the haven where we would be:" the dove will bring unto us the olive branch of peace; and the transcendent beauty of the celestial rainbow shall appear without a cloud, and bless our souls with the perfect assurance of eternal safety and joy.

SERMON V.

DO THIS GREAT WICKEDNESS AND SIN AGAINST GOD.

GENESIS xxxix. 9.

How then can I do this great wickedness and sin against God?

THE history of Joseph, by whom these memorable words were uttered, is full of interest and instruction. He presents unto us the splendid and rare example of a person advanced, from the lowest estate, to distinction and wealth and power; and yet preserving his piety and integrity unimpaired. Not all the luxury and blandishments of a court of unbelievers could tempt him to forget that gracious almighty benefactor, by whom he had been rescued from danger, and raised to prosperity and greatness. We all know how apt are the understanding and heart of man to be captivated and corrupted by the enjoyment of earthly pomp and pleasure, under any circumstances; but especially when they are attained by a sudden and unexpected elevation. Joseph had been cruelly left by his brethren in a state of utter destitution. Taken out of the pit into which they had inhumanly cast him, he was sold as a slave to a company of people, who were passing by, and carried into Egypt; by accident, as it appeared, but really under the guidance and direction of an all-wise providence, to accomplish the wonderful purposes of His divine will.

The scriptural account of his rapid rise to favour and eminence, in this his new abode, is exceedingly striking; and shews the especial regard which the Almighty bears for His righteous and faithful servants; there is no situation of life too obscure for the notice of His all-seeing eye; none too low for Him to interpose in behalf of His people, and exalt them to usefulness and honour. “Joseph was brought down to Egypt; and Potiphar an officer of Pharaoh, captain of the guard, an Egyptian, bought him of the hands of the Ishmeelites, which had brought him down thither. And the Lord was with

Joseph, and he was a prosperous man; and he was in the house of his master the Egyptian. And his master saw that the Lord was with him, and that the Lord made all that he did to prosper in his hand. And Joseph found grace in his sight, and he served him; and he made him overseer over his house, and all that he had he put into his hand.” ^[78]

Thus favoured and advanced, this holy man never forgot, as too many do, that gracious Being, to whose loving kindness he was indebted; instead of growing vain of his superiority, as if he had raised himself merely by his own talent or industry, he referred all his blessings to God’s bountiful providence, and rendered unto Him the return of a grateful and faithful service.

It was not long before his fidelity was put to the trial; and the manner in which he escaped the snare, that was laid for him, affords a remarkable proof not only of his integrity, but of his faith, his piety, his religion, his gratitude and love to God: the only principles upon which any dependence can be placed in the temptation of an evil hour. Joseph, when powerfully solicited to betray the confidence, and despoil the honour of his master, might have contented himself with declaring the numberless acts of kindness which he had received at Potiphar’s hand; the recompence of faithfulness which he owed for them all; or the fear of bringing upon himself disgrace and ruin, by so atrocious a crime; considerations indeed, which actually had no small influence and weight upon his mind. But he goes much further, and appeals to a higher authority, to a nobler principle; to one which was calculated to give unto every minor consideration a tenfold effect; to secure the performance of that duty, which reason and honour and conscience suggested; he appealed to his God, from the fountain of whose mercy he had derived all his benefits and blessings; and to whom therefore, his sincere unswerving obedience was unreservedly due. Like every pious and good man, he remembers and regards the human ties by which he is bound; and instances, in feeling language, the kindness and estimation of his earthly master; “Behold, my master wrotteth not (knoweth not) what is with me in the house, and he hath committed all things that he hath to my hand; there is none greater in this house than I.” ^[80] But then this man of God, after thus recounting the signal favour which had been shewn him by an earthly master, does not rest his duty upon saying, ‘how can I abuse the unbounded confidence reposed in me; how can I prove

myself so unworthy of my lord?’ But immediately, as if it were the habitual suggestion of his mind, elevates his thoughts and affections to his master in heaven; to Him, who had put it into the heart of Potiphar thus to distinguish and bless him; to Him, by whose grace alone he had been what he had been, a faithful and dutiful servant; and by whose gracious interposition “all things had worked together for his good.” For such surpassing mercy poured down upon him from heaven, he could not bear the thought of making so base a requital; and exclaimed in the energy of his soul, “How can I do this great wickedness and sin against God?” Resting upon such a principle, the triumph of his virtue was complete; it enabled him to disregard whatever evil consequences might ensue; and to stand against the subtlest wiles of the tempter, and under circumstances of imminent peril, a noble monument of the power of religion; upright in his duty to God and man.

Much edification may the Christian gather from the narrative before us; and happy would it be for the Christian world, if the principle, here so splendidly illustrated, were in fuller operation. It might indeed be thought, that with the superior knowledge we enjoy, of the transcendent mercy and goodness of God, of the extent and bounty of His providence, as well as the riches of his grace; that, with the clear revelation of the divine will, the glorious manifestation of gospel light, to us so abundantly vouchsafed; that, taught as we have been to look upon God as our reconciled Father in Jesus Christ, as the “author and giver of every good gift” in this world, and the spring of all our blissful hopes of an inheritance in the brighter world to come; it might have been thought, under these superior advantages and means of grace, that in all the events of life, in every temptation and trial, our affections would be certainly raised, above every earthly consideration, to the high and holy God; that, when we are pressed with the solicitations of evil, it would immediately occur to our minds and enter into our hearts, how abhorrent the offence must be to that perfect and glorious Being, in whose image we are professedly recreated; how grievous to that Holy Spirit, in whom we ought to live and walk; how disgracefully and basely unworthy of those spiritual privileges, to which we have been restored; of the great mercies we have already received; and the still greater we are yet expecting, from the redemption which hath been wrought for us by the ever blessed Jesus; it might be concluded, that Christians, when tempted to injury and

evil, would immediately refer the matter to the blessed word and will of their divine master, and exclaim, with a pious and grateful feeling, “how can I do this great wickedness and sin against God?”

Yet, is it not notorious, that a great, an overwhelming portion of the inhabitants of this enlightened land, are governed in a very small, if in any degree, by this pure sense of spiritual and religious obligation? Commonly, when they are solicited to sinful gratifications and pursuits, “God is not in all their thoughts:” whether they yield or not, depends partly upon the strength of their natural inclination; partly upon the light in which the sin may be regarded by the world around them; upon the extent to which it may affect their worldly reputation; upon what they may calculate to gain or lose by their conduct. The law of custom has manifestly a greater influence than the law of God; nay, what are called the *rules of honour*, which, in many instances, are flagrantly repugnant and opposite to the divine will, (and might rather be called the rules of *dishonour*;) are appealed to, in a Christian country, as the arbiters of right and wrong; while the “honour that cometh from God only” is totally disregarded and forgotten. And even of those, who are unacquainted with the precise terms of these fallacious rules, what multitudes are there, whose practice and conduct are determined by considerations merely human; who will be guided by a feeling of gratitude to an earthly benefactor, and yet have no sense or remembrance of the favour of an all-merciful God; who will be deterred from evil by the dread of offending an earthly superior, that has power only over the body, and yet possess in their hearts no fear whatever of Him, “who is able to destroy both body and soul in hell.” Where there are no better guides, no higher inducements than these, “to refuse the evil and to choose the good,” we cannot be surprised at the licentiousness and corruption, which so unhappily prevail; nor even at the flagrant and shameless commission of that calamitous sin, which Joseph rejected with such holy disdain. Against the impetuous desires and cravings of the flesh; the assiduous entreaties of wicked companions; and the beguiling charms, which Satan so well knows how to spread over all the ways and works of evil; against all these combining together, it cannot be expected, that any human motives or maxims, any earthly feelings alone, should be able successfully to stand.

Not that such motives or maxims or feelings are to be despised or disregarded; not that any just or lawful consideration, however trivial,

should be overlooked, which may be instrumental, in any degree, to preserve us from evil. Far is it from being the design of the gospel, to supersede the dictates and rules of reason; the workings of conscience; or the influence of natural affection, of hope and joy and gratitude and love; the gospel purifies all these motives, and guides them aright, and directs the exercise of them into the proper channel. But even the best of them, with the sincere Christian, are as nothing when compared with his religious principle, with the faith and fear and love of God: when tempted to sin, he thinks of that Holy Being, with whom he has entered into covenant; of that gracious Redeemer, who hath endured so much for his sake, who hath brought him into the way of salvation, by whose favour he is enjoying “the life that now is, and the promise of that which is to come;” he thinks of the Holy Spirit, “by whom he has been regenerated and made a child of grace;” he would not quench that sacred flame and energy, by which his corrupt nature has been enlightened and purified; from which “all good desires, all good counsels, and all just works do proceed;” by which his soul is animated with the inspiring hope of beholding his God face to face, in perfect righteousness and everlasting glory. He loves to please, he cannot bear the thought of offending, the Lord of majesty and mercy; and looks to Him for strength in the hour of trial. The constant habit of thus lifting up, in the spirit of prayer, the thoughts and affections to God; the full and abiding persuasion of His manifold mercies to the faithful, of His terrible judgments to be executed upon the disobedient and the impenitent sinner, will always be found the surest, the only sure, preservative from sin.

And how can that man, who believes, with all his heart and soul, in the glorious revelation of the Gospel; in the miseries which he may thereby escape, and the happiness which he may attain; in the means ordained for his accomplishment of these momentous purposes; how can he fail or cease to maintain a lively remembrance of the goodness and wisdom and power of God? Will he not “set the Lord alway before him;” and under the countenance and protection of his Saviour, and in the awful presence of his Judge, will he not feel himself powerfully actuated to restrain and resist every guilty inclination, and to decline from the danger and dishonour of every evil way? “How can I do this great wickedness and sin against” my Creator, Redeemer, and Sanctifier—the Almighty God, whose I am, and whom I serve?

This reflection is also calculated to excite our attention to the duties of this holy season, ^[89a] prescribed by the Church for our christian improvement; the duties of self-examination and repentance. Convinced, that every wilful sin renders us unworthy of acceptance with that God, “who is of purer eyes than to behold iniquity,” let us retire into our chamber and take our private hour, and cast a searching eye over our character and life, intent upon discovering every stain and blemish; let us “see if there be any wicked way in us,” and pray fervently to be “led into the way everlasting.” ^[89b] Let the sinfulness of our condition by nature, the sinfulness of our thoughts and words and works, pass in review before us; nor let the soul ever rest content, till we have made our peace with God;—by an humble abasement under the sense of our undeservings; by unfeigned sorrow for the past; by a holy, steady, entire resolution, to watch more carefully, and walk more circumspectly; by laying aside “every weight, and the sin which doth so easily beset us.” ^[90a]

When we duly think of the long-suffering and forbearance of our offended Father; of His great mercy in “sparing us when we deserved punishment;” sparing us to repent of our faults and follies, to advance in holiness and righteousness, to further the everlasting interest of the soul; surely we shall then be penetrated with a deep sense of the divine compassion; and the goodness of God “will answer its blessed purpose and lead us to repentance.” ^[90b] ‘How can I persist in abusing the patience which has borne with me so long? How shall I continue to neglect any duty, which so merciful a God has commanded, for the edification and salvation of my soul? How shall I rebelliously cherish any sinful indulgence, which is opposed to His holy law; and thus forfeit my claim to that heavenly inheritance, which my Saviour has died to procure for the true believer, for the penitent and contrite in heart? How can I do less than abhor the sin, which His blood was shed to expiate and cleanse away; less, than delight and advance in the way of righteousness which He has opened to me;’ even till “I come unto the measure of the stature of the fulness of Christ.”

Reflections, deliberations, resolutions such as these, sincerely formed and cherished, would very effectually, by divine grace, assist us in attaining that disposition of mind and heart, which might lead us habitually to raise our thoughts to God, under every circumstance, and at every time of temptation. There would thus be cast around us a sacred wall of defence; a

perpetual barrier against the inroads of Satan and of sin; and if at times they should, when we are suddenly thrown off our guard, break in upon the heart and lay it waste, they would speedily be expelled, and the breach would be healed without delay. Thus we shall become more jealous over ourselves, more circumspect and watchful; we shall never feel easy, while betraying, into the hands of the enemy, the merciful and glorious work of God. With a love for His goodness, a reverence for His truth, and a fear of His judgments, abiding in the heart, we shall fly from every approach of evil, and dwell in safety beneath the shadow of His wing: “we shall be enabled to withstand in the evil day, and having done all to stand.” [\[92\]](#)

It is our distinguished privilege to be enlightened by the “wisdom which is from above,” to “be strong in the Lord, and in the power of His might:” God forbid that we should return to the “beggarly elements of the world,” and seek to draw our principles and strength from this polluted source. Had we never been blessed with the light of revelation, we must have been content with such means of duty, as our dark state afforded: we must have been governed and guided like the heathen, whom we now pity. But, as we are supremely favoured with the knowledge of the true God, as “our fellowship is with the Father, and with his Son Jesus Christ;” as the Holy Spirit is given to “help our infirmities;” let us, in every temptation, remember our infinite obligations to the great and merciful Jehovah, and trust in the sufficiency of His almighty power.

After thus “walking with God as friends;” having, for the sake of His friendship, struggled with our evil propensities; having despised the vanity and folly, and renounced the love of the world, we shall experience more and more, the value of His favour, and the fulness of His grace; serving Him in humble gratitude, we shall be acknowledged as His own peculiar people, and He will be our God; in all perplexities we shall find Him our guide, in all trouble our comfort and support; amid the crooked paths of vice He will “make our way plain before His face;” the “snare will be broken and we shall be delivered;” He will honour us among men; “such honour have all His saints;” and this will be an earnest of our everlasting honour in His heavenly abode, in perfect friendship and communion with Him, in that blessed place where sin and temptation will be no more, “where nothing that defileth can enter.”

SERMON VI.

ON THE JOURNEY TO EMMAUS.

LUKE xxiv. 32. *And they said one to another, Did not our heart burn within us, while He talked with us by the way, and while He opened to us the Scriptures?*

THIS is a portion of one of those affecting and instructive pieces of history, with which the sacred scriptures every where abound.

After the resurrection of Jesus, on the very same day, two of His disciples were journeying together to a village called Emmaus, a few miles distant from Jerusalem. And as they went, “they talked together of those things which had happened.” And certainly never was there furnished to disciples an occasion of more interesting conversation. They were at no loss for a subject; their feelings were deeply moved, their circumstances most peculiar; they had just been bereaved of their Lord; and were left, as they thought, helpless and hopeless upon the wide world: they had been attending the sad scene of His sufferings; and doubtless had been witnessing his awful crucifixion; abundance of matter therefore, was afforded them for reflection and discourse. But besides this, they had heard the report of their Lord’s resurrection; and as they did not at all understand the purport of it, appeared indeed scarcely to believe an event so extraordinary, they were probably consulting what to expect, or what to do. “And it came to pass, that, while they communed together and reasoned, Jesus Himself drew near, and went with them. But their eyes were holden, that they should not know Him.” ^[96] Either He assumed a different form, or He supernaturally influenced their sight, that they should not at first recognize Him.

Jesus, let us observe, appeared to the disciples, while they were engaged in holy meditation and converse; and thus, though no longer visible in the

world, He may still be expected, at all times, to favour His true disciples in a similar manner. While they are conversing upon the things belonging to His kingdom, upon the wonders of His love, and the riches of His grace, upon their high privileges and expectations, upon the doctrines and precepts of His holy word, upon the duties and experiences of their earthly pilgrimage, upon their walk with God here, and their hope of dwelling together with Him for ever hereafter; while they are musing and discoursing of these things, the blessed Jesus will join company with them, though unknown and unseen; and will shed over their conference a holy and heavenly benediction. A reproach it is to vast numbers of His professing disciples, that they are not more anxious to embrace such opportunities of enjoying the favour and presence of their Lord; that many, even intimate friends and near relations, amid the endless variety of their subjects of conversation, are scarcely ever found to exchange a sentiment or a word, upon the most interesting and important of all topics; the love of their Lord and the edification of their souls. Eagerly do they embrace every opportunity of ministering to the passing amusement, or the temporal welfare, of each other; the only subject, which appears to be forbidden ground, is the subject of an eternal life to come, their spiritual well-being here and hereafter.

But let me not be misunderstood on this point; I am not speaking of the promiscuous intercourse of society; not of religious discussions or allusions amid the ordinary business of life; not of that irreverent and dangerous habit, into which some believers have been incautiously betrayed, of detailing to one another their continual and familiar experiences; I am speaking of the private and sober communing of christian friends, who are dwelling together, or journeying together, as the disciples to Emmaus: and truly, “with the bible in their hands and the Saviour in their hearts,” it is wonderful how they can forbear from spiritual intercourse. If the everlasting truths of the gospel have made a deep impression upon their minds; if, for the promises therein revealed, it is their object to live and to die; if they have one common hope of their calling, “one thing needful” which occupies their affections; if they have the same exalted view of a glorious kingdom in heaven; if they are living together in love, and comforting themselves, that the holy bond shall never be broken, that it shall be renewed in a happier world and last for ever; then it would be

strange if their thoughts and their conversation should never turn upon a subject of such overwhelming interest; upon a topic so abundantly fruitful in materials for mutual edification. The idea of the Lord being present with us in our conferences is an animating and ennobling idea: but we cannot expect His holy presence in the scenes of vanity and frivolity; nor can we expect it at any time, if the thought and desire of Him be altogether excluded. From the cold moralist, or the worldly-minded disciple, from those who have no practical concern for the gospel or for their souls, we need not look for a word of spiritual communication; it is abhorrent to their feelings and inconsistent with their notions; but the sincere Christian should “think on these things.” “The world will love its own,” and follow its own; its own friends and maxims and ways: but “we are not of the world,” and better fruit is expected from us.

But to return to the history before us. Having listened for a time to the earnest discourse of the disciples, Jesus at length, as if a stranger, enquired into the subject, which engrossed their minds and rendered them so sorrowful: “And the one of them whose name was Cleopas, (the same, it is thought, as Alpheus, who was the father of two Apostles and nearly related to our Lord Himself,) answering, said unto Him, art thou only a stranger in Jerusalem, and hast not known the things, which are come to pass there in these days?” “And he said unto them what things?” said it, probably, with a view of giving them an opportunity of declaring their opinions, upon what had taken place, as also upon Himself and the nature of His kingdom: “and they said unto Him, concerning Jesus of Nazareth, which was a prophet mighty in deed and word, before God and all the people: and how the chief priests and our rulers delivered Him to be condemned to death, and have crucified Him. But we trusted, that it had been He who should have redeemed Israel; and beside all this, to-day is the third day since these things were done.” [\[101\]](#) They concluded, that their bright hopes of redemption were extinguished, were all dead and buried with Jesus: even though they had heard of His rising again, according to His own promise, which they had just alluded to, still they had no expectation of holding any further intercourse with Him, of any further display of His power in their behalf.

“Then he said unto them, O fools (O unwise and blinded people) and slow of heart to believe all that the prophets have spoken; ought not Christ (ought

not your Messiah prophesied of old) to have suffered these things and enter into His glory?" ^[102] Is it not clearly foretold by your prophets, by Isaiah especially in his 53d chapter, that the redeemer of Israel should be "despised and rejected of men," should bear "their griefs and carry their sorrows," "should be led as a lamb to the slaughter, should be numbered with the transgressors," should make "His grave with the wicked (should die with malefactors) and with the rich in his death," (should be buried in the sepulchre of the rich,) and after that "prolong His days," and then that "the pleasure of the Lord should prosper in His hand?" According to your own prophecies then, and in order to their fulfilment, has not Jesus done that, as Messiah, which He was required to do? Instead of being offended, and giving up the cause, ye ought to be fully convinced, that He is "the Christ, the son of the living God." ^[103a] Then, "beginning at Moses and all the prophets, He expounded to them in all the sacred scriptures the things concerning Himself." ^[103b] How enlightening and convincing must this discourse have been! But it is not preserved to us: with so complete a body of information and evidence, it did not please the Almighty to favour the world. We are left to gather the instruction by diligent observation and study; and thankful may we be, that there still remain most abundant sources of satisfactory knowledge on this head; that the prophecies and types of the Saviour in the Old Testament, when compared with their fulfilment, are sufficiently clear for the conviction of every honest and well-disposed mind.

After this, the disciples "drew nigh unto the village whither they went; and Jesus made as though He would have gone further. But they constrained Him, saying, Abide with us; for it is toward evening, and the day is far spent. And He went in to tarry with them." ^[104a] And thus He still favours His disciples, and will do as long as the world stands; when they heartily desire His abiding presence, it will never be denied; wherever the place or whatever the occasion, their Lord, if wished for and welcome, will be of their company: in the domestic circle, in the converse of friends, in the sacred hour of solitude; "when thou sittest in thine house, and when thou walkest by the way, and when thou liest down, and when thou risest up." ^[104b] We have only to lift our thoughts to Him; "to set Him always before us; and He will be at our right hand, that we shall not be moved." ^[105a] At all times He will be found "a present help;" but especially when we are

associated or assembled in remembrance of Him. Such is the promise of His word: “where two or three are gathered together in my name, there am I in the midst of them:” [\[105b\]](#) gathered together for consultation, for worship, for any holy purpose.

Jesus, when He had entered into the house with the two disciples, acted in a manner which served to bring Him to their knowledge: “As He sat at meat with them, He took bread and blessed it, and brake and gave to them; (though a supposed stranger, He appeared as the head of the family; blessing and distributing, as His custom had been at their ordinary meals:) And their eyes were opened, and they knew Him: And He vanished out of their sight;” [\[105c\]](#) immediately left them to ponder upon the amazing things which they had heard. “And they said one to another, Did not our heart burn within us, while He talked with us by the way, and while He opened to us the Scriptures?”

Cleopas and his friend were unquestionably favoured beyond the common lot of disciples: to hear the sacred oracles explained by Him, who was at once the subject and fulfilment of them; by Him, through whose spirit the prophets and holy men of old all spake; to hear them perfectly explained and illustrated by the voice of the Son of God, might well make a vivid impression upon their minds, and fill their bosom with fervent and rapturous delight: Yet, though we cannot be so singularly blessed, there may be communicated to us a measure of that knowledge, which these disciples enjoyed; there may be imparted to us no inconsiderable portion of the same holy animation.

Our merciful Lord, on withdrawing His visible presence from this world, sent, according to His promise, another Comforter; a Comforter, who should “guide His people into all truth;” should “give them a right judgment in all things,” and spread a holy influence over their affections and desires. And now, when we are reading His word, when musing upon it with devout meditation, and conversing with one another upon its exalted truths, its heavenly purposes, its abundant promises and blessings; and now, when we hear the word from the lips of those ministers, who, however unworthy in themselves, are commissioned to speak in His great name, our hearts may burn within us, and “our eyes may be opened to behold wondrous things out of His law;” [\[107\]](#) we may still be powerfully impressed, if we have, what we

are taught by our church to pray for, “grace to hear meekly the word, and to receive it with pure affection, and to bring forth the fruits of the Spirit.”

May I not appeal, in justification of these remarks, to some of you here present? Have not your minds, when intent upon the doctrines of the gospel, and taking a view of heavenly things, been sometimes visited with a holy illumination, which has seemed to raise you above the world, and to make you feel more sensibly, that “you have your conversation in heaven?”

^[108] Have not the ties of earth been loosened, while your soul was expatiating on the deep things of God, on His wisdom and power and love, on the dealings of His providence and grace, on the glories of His eternal presence? Have you not, in some such moments, been so impressed, as to return to the world with a degree of reluctance; and, like the disciples at the transfiguration, almost tempted to say, of your spiritual and heavenly visions, “it is good for me to be here?” These are no enthusiastic imaginations; they are the sober and solid effects of the realized presence of our Redeemer; they are the burnings of heart, of which the disciples spake; they are the foretaste of our knowledge and joy and light and life above. Doubtless they are to be encouraged with humility and sobriety; doubtless they may degenerate into enthusiasm; for there is no spiritual good, which may not be abused: but the fear of enthusiasm is not to hinder us in gathering comfort and delight from the study of scriptural truth, from holy and exalted meditation. The world may call it weakness and folly; for it cannot be understood by the world; but the Christian knows for it a better name; and few eminent Christians have there been, who would not readily bear witness to the truth of these things, who have not felt the inspiring, uplifting power of divine contemplation.

And this, like all other exercises of true faith and piety, is of great practical importance; it is fruitful in righteousness to all who “think soberly;” it serves them, when they return to the busy scenes of earth, as an animation to duty; it purifies their affections and renders the world little in their eyes; it arms them for conflict, and reconciles them to trouble: in the midst of trials, of disappointments and bereavements, of struggles and difficulties, of frowns and oppositions, they remember, with thankfulness and comfort, the spiritual joys they have experienced, and expect to be blessed with them again: yes, in their darker hours, they remember, that the Sun of righteousness, has shone brightly upon them, and the beams are still

reflected; though they cannot at present perceive Him so clearly, though He seems, like Jesus with the disciples, to have “vanished out of their sight,” He has left a glory behind, and will again visit them with the fulness of His favour; and they go on their way “not faithless, but believing.”

To those who have been thus in the habit of pious and scriptural meditation; of intently dwelling upon the sublime mysteries, and the gracious promises, and the noble examples, and the striking histories of the word of God; to them it is needless to recommend a continuance of the good work; it is a christian obligation, which they can never think of declining; and besides this, the delight and improvement, which it affords, are its own sufficient recommendation. But upon all, who have unhappily neglected this their great privilege and duty, I would most earnestly press the importance of attending to this point, as a matter of bounden necessity. It is not enough to form an acquaintance with the leading truths of the gospel, as a matter of faith and profession; there is much to be learnt upon a nearer inspection, much indeed that can never be learned without it; much to enlarge and exalt the understanding; to renew the heart and regulate the life. The necessary intercourse, which most of us have with the world, is of a lowering and defiling nature; estranging the heart from a love of holiness and of God: and in order to correct this evil, scriptural study and spiritual consideration, as well as fervent prayer, are indispensable.

Let not any day pass over your heads without some portion of the Bible, some subject of divine revelation, being brought distinctly to your view. The exercise will interfere with none of your earthly duties, but will help you in the performance of them all; will smooth whatever there be of ruggedness in your way; will strengthen you in the hour of temptation, and comfort you in perplexity and trouble. Many an encouraging promise and many an enlivening assurance will recur to your memory; and “a word in season how good is it:” examples of suffering and patience, of striving and perseverance, of warfare and triumph, will kindle in your breast an emulous ardour, and you will say, ‘By the help of the Lord, I will “go and do likewise.”’ Thus will the Bible be a never-failing source of strength and consolation all the day long; as the waters, which flowed from the flinty rock, accompanied and refreshed the Israelites, ever and anon, in their journey through the wilderness, so will your spiritual musings, suggested by

the very hardships or troubles of life, be a perpetual stream of refreshment to your souls, even “in a dry land thirsty land, where no water is.” [\[113a\]](#)

And by this means you will be preparing and training your souls for a happier communion with the Saviour in another world; where all the dealings of His providence, and all the wonders of His grace, will be more fully and gloriously manifested. And if the heart of the Christian now burn within him, at the contemplation of heavenly truth and redeeming love; now, in his frail tenement of clay; how unspeakable will be his delight, when these things are revealed to his pure spirit, in the realms of perfection and bliss. Then will he know more of “the love of Christ which passeth knowledge;” then will he see more of “the length and breadth and depth and height” [\[113b\]](#) of the mystery of mercy; he will see God “face to face” and “know even as he is known.”

SERMON VII.

IF THEY HEAR NOT MOSES AND THE PROPHETS.

LUKE xvi. 31.

If they hear not Moses and the Prophets, neither will they be persuaded, though one rose from the dead.

LET us advert to the occasion on which these words were delivered, to the parable of which they form a part. The case there presented to us by the description of the rich man is unhappily of frequent occurrence in every age. Surrounded by all the luxuries that wealth could furnish, he looked for nothing beyond them: how many fellow mortals there were near his dwelling, deprived of the necessities, while he was revelling in the superfluities of life, was no care, no consideration of his; the selfish enjoyment of this world entirely absorbed his affections, and threw a veil over all expectation of a world to come: satisfied, that he had “goods laid by for many years,” he imagined that he had nothing to do, but to “eat, drink, and be merry.”

But such ignorance and insensibility did not prevent him from being called to account; such forgetfulness of his latter end did not retard the evil day. He died—and was buried, we may conclude, with costly preparation answerable to the splendour in which he had lived. This however, was the last service which his riches were able to render him; and melancholy it was, when contrasted with the state, in which his soul was existing, while his treasures were employed in doing honour to the lifeless body. He found in that state, what he might have discovered before, that riches, if selfishly employed in purposes of vanity and pleasure, are a deadly snare; that earthly indulgences, if pursued with excess, to the neglect of duty towards God and man, instead of being a blessing, are paving the way to misery; he

found, “what an evil and bitter thing it is,” to squander the favours of heaven without remembering “the author and giver of every good gift.”

Perceiving therefore, by sad experience, his own deplorable condition, he is represented as being moved with a feeling of pity for his brethren: his first anxiety, indeed, was naturally for himself—for some alleviation, at least, of the wretchedness of his fate; but when he was informed that such desire was fruitless, that even the assuagement of his pain was impossible, that there was no means of conveying even a drop of water to cool the thirst upon his tongue, that the great gulf was finally and irremoveably fixed, he then hoped that something might be done for his brethren who were still surviving; they had not yet passed the boundary of life and grace; and therefore he entreats that, while the far-spent day was shining upon them, Lazarus might be despatched from his abode of bliss, to warn them of the untimely end to which they were hastening; and induce them effectually to repent before “the night should come, in which no man can work.” [\[117a\]](#)

Abraham’s answer is, “they have Moses and the prophets, let them hear *them*.” A messenger from the court of heaven could tell them nothing new; they are already acquainted with their duty and the consequences of neglecting it: Jehovah has revealed unto them His blessed will, and clearly made known what is required of them, “to do justly, and to love mercy, and to walk humbly with their God.” [\[117b\]](#) His covenant with their fathers, and the promulgation of His law, have been attested by a series of signal miracles, which they do not pretend to dispute; and in every page of their history are recorded God’s promised blessings to the good, and the execution of His vengeance upon the evil; and, therefore, in as far as knowledge is concerned, they have all the intelligence that can be desired.

But the wretched man, in the agony of his own feelings, and the earnest desire to preserve his family from such woe, still pursues his request. “Nay, father Abraham;” but, though they have neglected the ordinary calls of heaven, assuredly, if so astonishing an admonition were granted to them, as that of one risen from the dead, they would be thereby persuaded to repent. Then follows the answer of the text, “If they hear not Moses and the prophets, neither will they be persuaded, though one rose from the dead.” And thus the conference ended.

From this conclusion of the parables two important observations may be drawn *first*, that if men fail to be convinced and converted, to be led to their God and their duty, by those sufficient means of grace which are already vouchsafed to them, they would not be likely to yield to any extraordinary means; and, *secondly*, that no such additional means are to be expected.

1. In all cases of spiritual and practical unbelief, in all cases where the declarations of the Almighty are disregarded, the fault lies not so much in the understanding as in the heart. The revelations of heaven are at variance with those interests and pursuits, which the heart is inclined and resolved to retain; and on this account, and by this means, the mind is prejudiced and set against such revelations, and they are not fully and implicitly believed. They call men to the love and practice of holiness, to which our degenerate nature is averse; the pleasures of sin are preferred, and the voice of God is unheeded: they teach us, that all earthly objects and possessions, in themselves, are vain, and call us to prepare for an everlasting inheritance above; the sensual and worldly-minded think and feel, that “it is good for them to be here,” and are not disposed to place their affections upon the promise of an hereafter. We none of us professedly disbelieve the revelation of heaven, any more than the brethren of the rich man did; and therefore I need not stay to argue the point on that ground. The doctrine before us is this, that men, professing to believe, to have received abundant evidence of the truth, and yet refusing to act upon that belief, would not be induced so to act, by any violent appeal to their senses or natural powers, even though it were the work of a divine interposition in their behalf.

What do we believe? That, after this life, which experience tells us must soon terminate, and which may, at any moment, be unexpectedly and suddenly brought to a close, we shall immediately enter upon another and an eternal state of being; and that our condition, in the endless life to come, will be happy or miserable, according to the manner in which we have passed our short pilgrimage upon earth, whether in a belief of the gospel or in unbelief; in obedience or disobedience; in holiness or sin. Now, if we really and vitally believe these truths, their importance is so striking, that nothing could possibly suggest to the mind a weightier consideration. And if these truths be only superficially credited, it must be owing to some corrupt and perverted affections, which throw a veil over the understanding, and render it proof against all moral means of conviction. Perhaps some

strange and startling occurrence, such as the re-appearance of a friend from the dead, might forcibly affect the imagination for a time; and, filling us with alarm and apprehension, might fill us also with vehement resolutions of amendment: but the imagination is a weak principle to build upon; the impressions it receives are commonly very transient; they gradually wear away on the presentation of fresh images, in our commerce with the world: and if there be not a solid spiritual conviction, in the mind and heart, of the awful realities of an hereafter, if the conviction does not rest upon the divine evidence accorded by the Spirit and the word of God, the effects of sudden surprise or consternation will soon vanish away; the latent dispositions of the soul will break forth again; the old habits, of recklessness and evil, be reassumed; the world again victorious.

For the truth of these things, I appeal, if not to yourselves, (as in many instances, I reasonably may) but if not, to those around you. How many examples have occurred, within the compass of your own experience, of extraordinary visitations having produced but a very short-lived influence upon the heart and character? How often have we seen the careless awakened by an alarming sickness, by an approach of the king of terrors, (which can hardly be supposed less convincing than an angel from heaven, or a spirit from the blest), and yet awakened only to return, on the removal of danger, to the slumbers of insensibility and sin. The solemn promises, which the terrified sinner made to his friends, his minister, and his God, were but the offspring of fear; the creatures of imagination; born only for the moment; soon disappearing, when the crisis was past.

And when the stroke of death has actually fallen upon a relative or friend, we have sometimes seen it overwhelm the soul of a heedless survivor, and bring him to himself, to serious thought and repentance; he began to sit loose to the remaining interests of life; he looked with anxiety to the world unknown, and formed resolutions of devoting his years to a constant provision for futurity; but all to no ultimate purpose; the subject had sued for his attention before, and been rejected. When his affections have had time to cool, he finds that no new importance has really been given to the truth; the evidences of it rest as they did; others have lost friends as well as he; it is the common lot of mortality; and he cannot keep alive the impression for ever; the world must be attended to; and one object after another continues to gain an ascendancy, till his new-born hopes and fears

are extinct; till his principles and conduct and views return to their old level, from which they will in future become the more difficult to be raised.

It is unnecessary for me to insist, that this is no ideal picture, drawn for the mere occasion of placing the subject in a strong light; your own acquaintance with the world may furnish you with living resemblances of it; and it is unhappily the lot of Christian Ministers, who have more frequent opportunity of witnessing such impressions, to observe, in the end, their repeated and lamentable failure; to perceive how far they fall short of lasting conviction and salvation.

Well, therefore, in the affectionate and faithful discharge of our duty, may we call upon our hearers to weigh, in the dispassioned hours of health and tranquillity, the nature and the moment of those divine truths, which the gospel clearly reveals unto man; to judge rightly and truly of their everlasting import; and to embrace them, from the undeniable evidence already presented, with all the heart and all the soul. We call, however, upon our hearers, not as if the vital impression depended upon themselves alone, upon the exercise of their own judgment or the workings of their own conscience. We call upon them to pray for, and be guided by, the mighty operation of the Spirit of God: He is ever ready to enlighten and instruct and quicken and determine them; giving us His grace, “that we may have a good will, and working with us, when we have that good will.” ^[125] Listen to His teaching; obey His godly motions; follow up the convictions which He brings to the mind and heart. Light enough is perpetually given, to guide you into all truth; live in the light; walk in the light.

Thus, indeed, every additional admonition, which a gracious God may be pleased to vouchsafe unto us, will be turned to good account; our faith will be confirmed, our affections purified, our knowledge increased, our resolutions strengthened and settled; “unto him that hath, shall more be given;” the sincere and pious believer will advance, at every call, a step nearer to his Saviour and his God; the still small voice of heavenly warning will be heard, even amidst the ordinary occurrences of life; the wonderful dealings of providence and the manifold means of grace will be turned to godly account; the instructions and examples of the living, and the contemplation of the saints at rest, will alike afford materials for spiritual edification. But if the great call to liberty and life be habitually neglected,

to liberty from sin and shame, and life to holiness and glory, then the mind and heart are not in a condition to take advantage of occasional excitement; it strikes, but it does not overcome; it rouses, but the stupor returns.

2. Proceed we now to the second observation which may be drawn from the text, that when men reject the abundant evidence of truth, and the gracious invitations of heaven already given, when they have resisted the strivings of the Spirit of God, they are not to expect Him to deviate from the ordinary rules of His providence and grace, for the sake of removing their wilful blindness, and overcoming their perverseness and obstinacy.

It is a part of the divine economy, in the salvation of man, that he should of his own free will, by the grace of God preventing and assisting, “refuse the evil and choose the good:” and therefore man is not to expect from the Almighty any such interference in his favour, as might absolutely overrule his will, and compel him to hearken and obey. God’s infinite mercy is sufficiently manifested in His offer and promise to save those rebellious sinners, who listen to the teaching of His Spirit, who are willing to be saved in His own appointed way. To save those who quench the light afforded them, who discover no such willingness, who unthankfully turn away and refuse the inestimable gift presented to them, would be in direct opposition to the whole tenour of the word of God. And experience concurs with Scripture to inform us, that no such extraordinary interposition is generally vouchsafed. The Jews, in our Saviour’s time, had read of the miracles of Moses and the prophets, professed to credit their inspiration, and their mission from on High; they had seen the astonishing miracles of Christ Himself; and might, if they would, have perceived the fulfilment of their prophecies in Him; many of them were eyewitnesses to the signs and wonders attendant upon His crucifixion; to the earthquake, and the supernatural darkness, and the rending of the veil of their temple; nor could they deny His resurrection from the dead. Against all this body of evidence, against all the means of conviction, they persevered in their rejection of Him. And the time came, when no further testimonial was to be granted; they were left “to fill up the measure of their fathers;” they died in their sins.

In addition to all these opportunities and advantages afforded to the Jew, we enjoy, at this day, the fulness of the manifestation of the gospel; the real

nature of the Messiah's kingdom is clearly and completely revealed unto us; the blessings of the gospel are set before us, in the most conspicuous and glorious light; we have all the certainty, which mortals can have, of a world to come; all the knowledge which our imperfect faculties could receive, of the nature of that world; and all the means of grace and hopes of glory. And if by all these mercies we are not convinced and persuaded, we can have no right or reason to look for any preternatural or overpowering interposition, even from the goodness and long-suffering of God. Rather may we fear that judicial infatuation, so frequently alluded to in Scripture, of the closed eye, the dull ear, and the gross obdurate heart. O let the sinner, instead of flattering himself with the delusion, that some extraordinary thing will one day be happening to him, which shall disengage him from earth, and fix his thoughts on heaven and eternity, O let him rather apprehend that the time is approaching, when the measure of his iniquity shall be filled up, and God will be no longer found.

I am not asserting, that such signal interferences have never been vouchsafed; that such loud awakenings have never been successful: I mean, that they are not in the ordinary course of divine providence, and are not to be expected. I mean to say, that where the grace of the gospel is continually resisted in the heart and life, the careless recusant is seldom reclaimed through the medium of any extraordinary visitation; whether of sickness, of accident, or any terrible calamity. The man, who entrusts his soul to the hope and operation of such occurrences, is placing it in imminent jeopardy. Whoever will save his soul alive, let him, without delay, "seek the Lord, while He may be found, and call upon Him while He is near;" [\[130a\]](#) peradventure God may "laugh at his calamity, and mock when his fear cometh." [\[130b\]](#)

And in other ways also does the same evil principle work, the same evil habit of "resisting the grace of God:" many persons, who express themselves thoroughly convinced of the truth of the christian revelation, and the absolute necessity of a spiritual obedience and a holy walking with God, put off their work of righteousness, from year to year, in the hope, not of any great or appalling event, but that some new circumstances may arise, which shall make it more convenient for them to renounce the world, and attend, without let or hindrance, to the salvation of their souls; they will have gained a sufficiency of earthly comforts, or they will be tired of the

world; they will be growing old and feeble, and naturally more inclined to think of heavenly things. But this is only the same temptation as the former, presented in another shape; the “convenient season” is hoped for in vain; Satan never suffers us to be without a hindrance, real or imaginary; our attachment to the world does not wear off; we grow older without growing more religious, without drawing nearer to God; and we never are, it is impossible we should be, *naturally* disposed to “turn and seek after Him:” thus the delusion goes on; and we “will not be persuaded;” and thus, too frequently, the “expectation cometh utterly to an end for evermore.” There is no trusting to anything, but the *present* conviction and determination, but the instant and unreserved “obedience of the heart unto righteousness;” “to-day, if ye will hear His voice, harden not your hearts.”

[\[132\]](#)

In conclusion, I call upon you to think on the condition of the rich man in torment. His anxiety for a special interference in behalf of his brethren is represented as useless to *them*, but it may be salutary to *us*: It may assure us of the wretchedness of that place, to which he was condemned; may incline us, by the inspiration of God’s Holy Spirit, to value and improve His gracious gifts, while they are mercifully bestowed; may determine us, while we have the all-sufficient light of the gospel, to be guided thereby into the way of peace; we may learn from this awful lesson, that if (God forbid that it should be so) but *if* any of us should be similarly doomed, we shall mourn for ourselves, and be anxious, that the companions we have left may be our companions no more; let us take heed for ourselves, and be anxious for one another in time, while the heed and anxiety may be crowned with success; may lead us to seek and find God’s favour and mercy, and so “escape from the wrath to come.”

SERMON VIII.

PERFECT LOVE CASTETH OUT FEAR.

1 JOHN iv. 18.

There is no fear in love, but perfect love casteth out fear: because fear hath torment; he that feareth is not made perfect in love.

OF all the sources of happiness, which the merciful God has opened to us, the most pure and abundant are the feelings of affection and love. I appeal, for the truth of this, not to the understandings, but to the hearts of those that hear me; and they will at once testify, unless corrupted and perverted by selfish or vicious habits, that such, even with regard to earthly happiness, is undoubtedly the fact. Persons indeed of inferior principle, of irregular and irreligious lives, frequently draw from this source the most considerable portion of their pleasure, whatever abatements it may receive from their sin and folly: and when the passions are attempered, and the affections purified and exalted, by the influence of our holy religion, by the refining energy of the spirit of God, the delight naturally and necessarily becomes proportionably greater. “To love one another” is not only our first earthly duty, as enjoined by the Saviour, but also our highest interest and advantage, as contributing to the happiness of all.

If then so much enjoyment is derived by mankind from the exercise of mutual love, how much more from the love of God—the pure, the gracious, the ever blessed God; “who loadeth us with His benefits;” who made us what we are, and gave us what we have; who created us for His glory, who redeemed us from sin and death, who sanctifieth all that trust in Him, that they may be happy for ever: in a word, whose goodness to us knows no bounds, but those which are set by our own perverseness and ingratitude. Almighty and most merciful Father, “whom have I in heaven but Thee? and there is none upon earth that I desire beside Thee.” ^[136] “Graft in our hearts

the love of Thy name;" we cannot love Thee as Thou hast loved us; but give us the grace to love Thee with holy sincerity; with that devout and reverent affection, which shall render all other objects of desire comparatively indifferent to us, and make us satisfied with Thy favour, whatever else we want; which shall calm our apprehensions, when we think of an hereafter; and allay the uneasiness which arises in our breasts, when we reflect upon Thine infinite holiness, and our own degenerate condition.

Perhaps it may be imagined, that this is a state of blessedness attainable by few, if any, upon earth: some may urge the text against us, and say that this blessedness is promised only to perfect love, which mortals can never hope to attain; and that it is inconsistent with those numerous passages of Scripture, which admonish us of the necessity of fear; that in the admirable collect of our Church for this day, ^[137] we are instructed to pray for "a perpetual fear and love of God's holy name." How then can we possess the love which casteth out fear? I will endeavour to reply to these observations; and pray God that we may all derive, from the consideration of this subject, a more true and lively and abiding sense of the nature and necessity of that love towards Him, which, as His adopted children and the inheritors of His kingdom, we are absolutely bound to entertain.

Unquestionably true it is, that the fear of God is, and ever has been, indispensable to all His faithful servants; as well under the mild dispensation of the gospel, as under the severer discipline of the law. "The fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom." ^[138a] "Surely his salvation is nigh them that fear Him." ^[138b] "Unto you that fear my name shall the Sun of Righteousness arise, with healing in His wings." ^[138c] And accordingly the Apostle observes, "In every nation, he that feareth Him, and worketh righteousness, is accepted with Him." ^[138d] "His mercy is on them that fear Him, from generation to generation." ^[138e] But what is the nature of this fear? It is not a slavish principle, not a disturbing and distressful feeling. It consists in an awful sense of God's glorious perfections; of His divine Majesty, unspotted purity, infinite knowledge and power; of His presence pervading every part of the creation, even the very mind of every intellectual being; such a sense, as to fill us with the deepest humility, perceiving ourselves unworthy even to stand in the sight of Him, "who is of purer eyes than to behold iniquity;" such a sense, habitually impressed upon

the heart, as inclines and constrains us to “follow the good” which He loves, and “depart from the evil” which He abhors.

And this principle is plainly and entirely consistent with the sincerest love: our love indeed is powerfully increased by the reflection, that our heavenly Father, of whose attributes we form conceptions so awful and sublime, should condescend to bestow such regard upon His frail and fallen, His disobedient and rebellious children; it may teach us to exclaim with the liveliest emotions of gratitude, as well as with humble adoration and astonishment, “Lord, what is man that Thou art mindful of him, and the son of man that Thou visitest him?” ^[139] Good reason, therefore, had the framers of our Liturgy, for directing us to implore the united influence of a perpetual fear and love of God’s holy name.

But the fear spoken of in the text is of another kind; it relates to uneasy and distressful apprehensions respecting our acceptance with God; to a feeling of doubt and distrust, whether we are, in deed and in truth, partakers of the gracious promises of the gospel; whether we are living in a state of reconciliation with God; whether we have within us that earnest of the Holy Spirit, which is the pledge and seal of our redemption; whether, in a word, we are objects of God’s favour here, and have a well-grounded hope of his mercy hereafter.

That this is the state of mind represented to us by the beloved Apostle, is clear from his own reasoning; “for fear,” says he, “hath torment:” now the fear of God, as above described, has no torment at all; it makes us humble, and fills us with reverential awe, but it tends to comfort and peace. We could not entirely love a Being, whose manifestation inspired us with terror and dismay; and this is the very reason why many, when they come seriously to consider their condition, are filled with confusion and alarm; because they do not love God in sincerity and truth: their affections have been set on the world; and therefore their title to salvation, upon the terms proposed to them in the gospel, is clearly insufficient; they have served other masters, and have reason to tremble for their reward from the great Lord and Master in heaven; they have employed their talents for other purposes, than those for which they were committed, and therefore, when they think of making up their accounts, their lord presents himself as “an austere man,” exacting more than they will be able to render: no man can

heartily love God, without an entire obedience of the heart; this they have never shewn, and therefore have never loved Him: how then can they expect His favour; how can they reflect upon their condition with composure and comfort?

Truly is it said, that such fear hath torment; for of all the uneasiness which the mind can suffer here, the most painful is that, which is produced from an apprehension of “the terrors of the Lord;” better not to have known the greatness of the salvation promised, than to neglect the means of securing it; better not to have heard of an hereafter, than to have a reasonable dread upon the spirits, what that hereafter shall be. They who have greater cause for fear than for hope, must, if they are given to meditate and look forward, find it cast a dismal shade over every scene and prospect of life; they may contrive to drown their serious thoughts, in the midst of worldly pursuits and intemperate pleasures; but this is only for the passing hour; they cannot possibly think, that their condition is thus really improved. But why take so much pains to mitigate or conceal a misery, which it is in our power, by God’s gracious mercy, effectually to prevent? Escape from these torments of the conscience by a sincere devotedness to the service of your Almighty Father, in the gospel of His beloved Son; by cherishing in the heart that “perfect love for Him, which casteth out fear.”

Yet is this possible, it may be said, for weak and imperfect man? Is it not rather a state at which we should aim, than one at which we can ever hope to arrive? Certainly the imperfect creature can never attain to actual perfection in any moral or spiritual duty; but his will and desire may be perfect, though his service is not; and in this sense, the duty of perfect love is equally binding upon all believers. It is a very common persuasion, and dangerous as it is common, that the standard of christian duty is raised much higher in the gospel, than it is necessary for the generality of Christians even to think of reaching; that some of the commands, there given, are intended only for the chosen few, more eminent than the rest of mankind in spiritual attainments; and thus too many professing disciples of our Lord, imagining themselves not bound by such extensive obligations, are content with measures of obedience, infinitely less than those, which are positively required; content with a state of heart and life, far short of that, which the gospel recognises and enjoins. But this is a mere delusion, to suit the wayward fancy and the corrupt inclination of man: where do we read in

the Bible of such limitations and exceptions? Where do we find one set of rules for eminent Christians, and another for Christians in general? Are not all its precepts, and all its principles, and all its instructions, of universal obligation? When the Saviour promised His divine blessings to “the poor in spirit,” to them that “hunger and thirst after righteousness,” to “the pure in heart;” were the conditions intended only for the disciples around Him on the mount? Were they not also designed for His followers in every age? And when the Lord commanded Moses to “speak unto all the congregation of the children of Israel, and say unto them, Be ye holy, for I the Lord your God, am holy,” [\[144\]](#) does the precept concern only the people of old? Is it not equally applicable to Christians? Yea, it is urged upon us all by the mouth of an Apostle. [\[145\]](#) The same is true of every spiritual doctrine, every moral command recorded in the Book of Life: there is no means of grace, no measure of obedience ordained, which a Christian can safely neglect.

Whatever, therefore, be meant in the text by *perfect* love, that love it is the bounden and necessary duty of us all to attain and to cherish. And what is really meant by this expression, may be most readily and fully understood from a precept of the divine law, as confirmed and enforced by our blessed Redeemer; “Thou shalt love the Lord thy God, with all thine heart and with all thy soul and with all thy strength.” This is the love described in the text; perfect in *kind*, as admitting of no rival principle, of no competition with “the world or the things that are in the world,” with any or all of them together; imperfect in *degree*, on account of the infirmity of our faith, of the weakness and corruption of human nature.

We cannot be at a loss to understand this distinction; yet it may be further illustrated by an example from ordinary life. The most affectionate and dutiful child will fail occasionally to please and obey its parent; but there will be a constant desire and endeavour to please: to have excited the parent’s displeasure, will bring uneasiness and sorrow; and therefore the violations of duty will be neither wilful nor habitual. And this sincere affection, for a kind and good parent, never ceases to produce delight; the child indeed, feeling so much respect and reverence, will be afraid of offending, afraid of the unworthiness, afraid of the dishonour; yet the service of obedience is rendered from choice, and not from constraint; with emotions of joy, with a grateful endearment of soul: slavish terror there is none; it is banished by the overpowering principle of love.

The case is similar, with respect to the love of God: whoever, from a sense of the relationship which he is privileged to bear to the almighty and gracious Creator; whoever, from a contemplation of the high and holy perfections of the Godhead; whoever, from a perception of the divine goodness and mercy, does truly love the great and glorious Lord of all, will constantly delight to serve Him; sensible indeed of his manifold weaknesses and deficiencies, and thereby brought to grieve, and rendered the more fearful to offend; but still entertaining no doubt, that his services, imperfect and unworthy as they are, are accepted at the throne of grace, through the merits of his Redeemer, and as the fruit of faith in His prevailing name. For no earthly consideration would he exchange this heavenly joy and satisfaction; and no earthly event or dispensation, however afflicting, can drive him even to distrust, much less to despair. Though nature feels her bereavements and her troubles, his faith is strong; and it assures him, that the very chastisements of the Lord are inflicted in mercy. “Who,” says the Apostle, “shall separate us from the love of Christ? shall tribulation, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness, or peril or sword? Nay, in all these things we are more than conquerors through Him that loved us. For I am persuaded, that neither death, nor life, nor angels, nor principalities, nor powers, nor things present, nor things to come, nor height, nor depth, nor any other creature, shall be able to separate us from the love of God, which is in Christ Jesus our Lord.” ^[148]

In speaking, however, of the holy confidence, with which we are inspired by the sincere love of God, far would I be, as far as possible, from confounding it with that self-sufficient and presumptuous tone into which some persons have been unbecomingly betrayed, when describing their spiritual condition. Humility is the foundation of the Christian’s confidence: he trusts, only because he is “strong in the lord, and in the power of His might;” he is sufficient, only because “all his sufficiency is of God.” And the purer his love, and the higher his attainments, the more humbly and modestly does he speak of them: he talks not of certainty, “as if he had already attained,” but delights himself with “full assurance of faith,” ^[149a] with “full assurance of hope;” ^[149b] his is not an extravagant joy, proceeding from the arrogant assertion of an elective claim, but a holy tranquillity of soul, arising from faith in the Redeemer’s undeserved mercy;

from unfeigned love to the most benevolent and perfect Being; and reposing itself upon the unchangeable promises of Jehovah.

We do not question, my brethren, the claims of Almighty God to our perfect love. Is He not our Creator? and could He have formed us with any other design, than to make us happy? If reason could have doubted this truth, revelation makes it clear. And are we not preserved, every moment of our lives, by His infinite wisdom and mercy and power? And though we are forgetful of His sustaining hand, still He feeds us with the bounties of nature; and invites us to partake of the riches of His grace. What are the greatest blessings, which a human being, which any creature could possibly desire? To be delivered from evil, and to enjoy everlasting good. And did not the adorable Son of God take upon him the infirmities and sufferings of our mortal state, to redeem us from misery, and exalt us even to glory? And does not the Holy Spirit condescend to dwell in our tabernacles of flesh, that He may cleanse us from every sinful defilement, “purify unto Himself a peculiar people zealous of good works,” [\[150a\]](#) and make us “meet to be partakers of the inheritance of the saints in light?” [\[150b\]](#) Could we, even if we had been worthy, have desired, have imagined for ourselves, blessings so great and favours so exalted, as those which the good and gracious God is showering down upon us? Shall we not then be inclined, from every consideration, shall we not be determined, by God’s grace, to love this heavenly benefactor with all our heart—from a principle of gratitude; from an admiration of divine perfection; from the inspiring hope and prospect of our eternal salvation? Yes, let us give unto Him, not that divided affection, which is the vain offering of a degenerate and degraded world; but the full and unreserved energies of the soul. If a portion of our heart be engrossed by any other object, we are not the true people of the Lord; we render Him not a reasonable or acceptable service; our love is embittered with fear; with a fear that has, and will have, torment. Lord, let our affections be altogether devoted unto Thee; pour Thy spirit of love into our hearts, for the sake of Him “who loved us and gave Himself for us;” we cannot love Thee here upon earth as we would do, but be pleased to accept what Thou enablest us to give, the tribute of a sincere heart; and let it be to us a never-failing source of humble confidence and holy comfort; so that we may anticipate the joyful hour, when we shall be removed, from this imperfect state of being, to a purer and happier world; where, with affections exalted

and understandings enlarged, we shall render Thee a more delightful and laudable service; with angels and archangels, and all the company of heaven.

“God is love;” and when the veil of the flesh is laid aside, and we are admitted into His glorious presence, “we shall be like Him, for we shall see Him as He is;” [\[152\]](#) then will our felicity be complete, complete for ever; then, in the fullest sense of the words, we shall be “made perfect in love.” Here then, without a question, our true happiness lies; here is our all: let us pray that we may never lose sight of it; that the desire, now kindled, may never be extinguished; that every “heart may there be fixed, where true joys are to be found, through Jesus Christ our Lord.”

SERMON IX.

HUMBLE YOURSELVES UNDER THE MIGHTY HAND OF GOD.

1 PETER V. 6.

Humble yourselves under the mighty hand of God, that He may exalt you in due time.

THERE is nothing, which more peculiarly marks the character of the faithful Christian, than the manner in which he submits himself to the appointments and dispensations of his God. The worldly and carnal spirit either frets and repines under the visitations of misfortune, or is disconsolate and cast down; or, at the best, bears up with a mere animal fortitude against them: it finds no comfort to flee unto, but such as is afforded by the vain world, in which it has already met with vexation und disappointment; and if the world is unable to secure a continuance in prosperity, still less is it able to provide a refuge in the dismal days of sorrow.

So lamentably indeed has this truth been experienced by many, that they have been driven to the fallacious and fatal expedient of attempting at once to drown their cares in intemperance; they have found nothing in the world sufficient to satisfy their reason, or to soothe their irritated feelings; and therefore have destroyed their faculties, that they might not reflect; and cut short the thread of that life, which they imagined themselves unequal to support: and some indeed have had recourse to a more speedy and awful means of delivering themselves from the burden of mortification and grief; ill prepared as they were, their own hand of violence has hurried them into the presence of their Judge. And even they, who have been preserved from these most miserable extremities, have sufficiently testified by their conduct, that the world has nothing satisfactory to offer, for the healing of a wounded spirit, or the removal of a load of sorrow.

Religion, the religion of the gospel, is the only source from which true comfort or support can possibly be drawn; and we see her triumphs manifested in the most blessed and remarkable manner when the faithful servant of God is overwhelmed with trouble; we perceive his mind in a state of tranquillity, under a conviction, that the Lord “doeth all things well;” and remembereth mercy, no less in chastisement, than in the time of prosperity; his unquiet emotions are subdued into holy subjection to the divine will; his affections are set the more earnestly on things above; the vanities of earth have lost their hold; and there ariseth in the heart that “peace of God, which passeth all understanding.”

They who have been much conversant with scenes of sickness or of sorrow, cannot fail to have observed the truth of these remarks, to have been struck with the vast difference in the behaviour of men, in proportion as they have imbibed the true spirit and principle of the gospel. Some we have seen dismayed, disturbed, and restless; with nothing in their countenance, but vexation or anguish; others, cheerfully bearing up under the evils which have befallen them; and, by their expressions of joyful resignation, delighting and comforting the friends, who were shedding over them the tears of sympathy; the power of the word of God, the “joy of the Holy Ghost” has been visible in their very features. Those persons, who have beheld such an example, have been favoured with an instructive lesson, which they should “grave on the tablet of their heart;” a lesson teaching them, faithfully and forcibly, where to look for aid in the reverses and afflictions of life.

Yet, in order to lead us more effectually to cultivate, and to reap the benefit of, this heavenly frame of mind, let us now consider the bearing of the apostolic charge in the text, “Humble yourselves under the mighty hand of God.” Here we may discover powerful reasons intimated, why we should bring ourselves into a state of entire submission to the divine will, and rest satisfied and resigned under every dispensation. The hand of God is mighty: He is the sovereign Lord of all; has an absolute right to dispose of His creatures, according to His good pleasure; and is alone able both to know and to do, what their several necessities require. They, therefore, who profess themselves His people, are bound, by that very profession, unreservedly to submit to His sovereign disposal: “Shall the clay say to him that fashioneth it, what makest thou? O Lord, Thou art our Father, we are

the clay, and Thou our potter; and we all are the work of Thy hand.” [\[158\]](#) He who created, He who redeemed us, He to whom alone we can look for sanctification and life, should and will maintain the dominion over us: He that gave us our being, must be able, and cannot be unwilling, to “give us all things needful both for our souls and bodies.” We understand not how He formed us from the dust of the earth; so neither can we understand the methods of His providence; but, as “the life is more than meat,” so may we trust His goodness and His power, to preserve, in the best and wisest manner, the being of those, who seek His protection and submit to His government. A wise son yields to an affectionate father, even in points where he cannot comprehend the entire wisdom of his discipline and correction; yields, not only because experience has taught him the benefit of subjection, but also for the sake of obedience to a father, who is entrusted with the guidance of him, and has a right to be obeyed; much more should we, the adopted children of the Most High, bow with meekness and reverence before an Almighty and heavenly Father, though we altogether comprehend not the purpose of the trials, which He bringeth upon us: they are chastisements of mercy, of whatever kind they be, and moreover are ordained by Him, who has the entire undisputed right of dominion over us.

Another consideration here suggested is, that all resistance is vain; “the mighty hand of God” is uncontrollable. Utterly weak and fruitless were all the assembled powers of the universe, combined against His will: what can a frail creature do, child of the dust, akin to the worm? If God strikes, who shall stay or avoid the blow? Whatever visitation He is pleased to send, to a family or to an individual—of sickness, of calamity, of death—there is no keeping it out of the dwelling; it may be softened by resignation, it may be removed, and even blessed, by prayer; but we cannot hinder the accomplishment of God’s will. In the language of the pious Hannah, “The Lord killeth and maketh alive; He bringeth down to the grave and bringeth up—He raiseth up the poor out of the dust, and lifteth up the beggar from the dunghill, to set them among princes, and to make them inherit the throne of glory: for the pillars of the earth are the Lord’s, and He hath set the world upon them. He will keep the feet of His saints, and the wicked shall be silent in darkness; for by strength shall no man prevail.” [\[161a\]](#)

Yes truly; the afflicting hand of God is mighty in operation, both to the wicked and the good; the former are constrained to feel, though they will

not heartily or practically acknowledge, that there is no dependence to be placed on the schemes or exertions of man; no trusting, that “to-morrow will be as this day and much more abundant.” ^[161b] When “riches shall have made themselves wings and have flown away;” ^[161c] when the favourite or the friend have been cut off; when the bodily frame is under the influence of alarming disease; then the sinner, if he be not spiritually humbled, will, at least be made sensible, that there is a power which can lay him low; the conviction is forced on his mind, though he may refuse to act upon it; his conscience is smitten, though he will not obey its emotions; it assures him of the vanity of human devices, of human dependencies and strength, though it fail to incline him to his God.

How blessedly different the effect of the mighty hand of God upon the sincere Christian! Even the heaviest affliction, the most untoward or adverse occurrence, produces, when he comes to reflect, a salutary influence on his mind and heart. Perceiving that it is the natural tendency of a smooth uninterrupted course, to make him rest satisfied with earthly enjoyments, and draw aside his attention from the sublimer delights and the more substantial interest of heavenly things, he acknowledges, not only with acquiescence, but with gratitude, the severer dispensations of providence; he knows, that his faith must be tried and his patience made perfect; it is the very object for which he is placed in this transitory state of existence; he therefore implores his gracious Father, to sanctify to him the crosses and disappointments below, and make them minister to the completion of his happiness above; whatever they are, they are less than his transgressions deserve; whatever they are, they are “of God’s sending,” to lead him to reflection and repentance; and very efficacious are they for the fulfilment of this merciful purpose; perhaps the only means by which he could have been preserved from falling, amidst the snares and temptations that surround him. The Christian is ready to confess, and many we have heard with thankfulness confessing, that of all the mercies received from the hands of God, the most distinguished, because the most effectual for his salvation, are the vicissitudes and troubles of life: how many a sincere believer, by the discomfiture of his earthly prospects, has been led to fix his heart more intently and stedfastly, upon the unchangeable felicity of heaven; how many, at the death of a friend, have sought more earnestly and experienced more abundantly, “the power of the spirit of consolation;” and

have thereby been led to transfer their affections to that blessed world, where christian friends shall meet, and never separate again. How many, by the infirmities of the body, have been admonished and persuaded to make a better provision for the health and well-being of the soul! The hand of God has been mightily laid upon them, to rescue them from the tyranny of sin and Satan, to place them in the enjoyment of “the perfect law of liberty,” manifested in the gospel; to save their souls alive.

Let us not regard the various calamities that befall us, of whatever nature they may be, as the mere result of human design or contingency; for whether they be occasioned by our own imprudence and neglect, or by the instrumentality of an evil world, they are permitted and ordained by a wise and merciful God, to draw us nearer to Himself; to teach us the utter insufficiency of all earthly interests and possessions; and to raise our thoughts to the glory of an eternal kingdom. And if we receive them in a christian spirit, they will never fail to answer their high and holy purpose. Let us therefore watch and pray, that we may duly consider every calamitous day as a sacred opportunity, as a season of grace, as the rod of our Almighty Father to chastise us from sin: let it call us to deep meditation and contrition, to serious examination of heart; for it is only by the religious and spiritual observance of such seasons, that we can ever hope to derive from them improvement and comfort.

Remark and remember the language of the text, “Humble *yourselves* under the mighty hand of God;” it is not enough that we be humbled, in a worldly sense, by the stroke of misfortune; that is a consequence, which may of necessity ensue: the loss of possession may drive us into needy solitude; the loss of health destroy our energy and activity; the loss of reputation bring us to shame; the loss of friends oblige us to mourn, from the very feelings of nature; but all this while, there may be no humility of heart, no self-abasement, no voluntary humiliation under “any of the dispensations of heaven:” the “hand of God hath touched us;” but we may not, nevertheless, be vitally touched ourselves, with a proper sense of the trials, which He has called us to endure: we must fall low before His footstool; we must bend our knees in humble fervent prayer; we must implore the aid of His Holy Spirit, to open our understandings, that we may perceive the graciousness of His dealings with us; and to enlarge our hearts, that we may take the full benefit of His “loving correction;” we must unfeignedly and fully confess,

on our own part, that unworthiness and iniquity, which excited God's displeasure, and required His afflicting visitation; and that mercy, on God's part, which seeketh to reclaim us from error; to "purge our conscience from dead works;" to make us more alive to the "things which belong unto our peace;" to lead us from the vanities of time to the momentous realities of eternity.

If we thus improve the sorrowful events that await us, we shall find a happy deliverance from them all; and it is the only possible means, by which we can be happily delivered: this the text implies; "Humble yourselves under the mighty hand of God, *that He may exalt you*;" that you may thus be rendered meet to partake of His mercy; that He may visit and comfort you in your low estate; and make it instrumental to your spiritual exaltation. If you murmur or complain, or do but naturally mourn; if you manifest only the frettings of a worldly disposition and temper, your case thereby becomes still more grievous and intolerable; the heart is vexed by its vain and rebellious strivings; "the sorrow of the world worketh misery and death." You are thus preventing the benediction of heaven from descending upon you; you are closing up the avenues, through which the grace of God may find its way into the heart; you are neglecting that remedy, by which alone the stricken soul can be healed, by which your trouble may be converted into a blessing. Embrace the proffered means; humble yourself beneath the burden, with "a godly sorrow," for the sin that has brought it; bend yourself beneath the storm of heaven, and the Sun of righteousness will soon shine forth, and cheer you with His brightest beam; "the God of consolation," your Redeemer, your unchangeable friend, "the same yesterday, to-day, and for ever," will turn your darkness into light; your "weeping will endure but for a night, and joy will come in the morning." [\[168\]](#)

Or, if it be not literally so; if deliverance come not so speedily as you desire or expect, it will assuredly come in God's "due time;" He may wait, to try the strength of your patience and your faith; may seem for a season, as though He heareth not your prayer; but rest assured, He does hear, and the answer is preparing: the wise and benevolent author of four blessings knows best when to bestow them; depend upon His mercy, and trust Him for the time: the delay will be nothing, as compared with the comfort when it arrives: the very delay will minister to the fulness of your joy: you will perceive the truth of the divine character, as drawn by the pencil of the

prophet; you may apply the prophetic description to yourself; “For a small moment have I forsaken thee; but with great mercies will I gather thee. In a little wrath I hid my face from thee for a moment; but with everlasting kindness will I have mercy on thee, saith the Lord thy Redeemer.” [\[169\]](#)

God will exalt every humble and faithful servant, in due time, even in this world; not perhaps to earthly greatness and honour; but, what is infinitely more important, to the height of His own blessed favour; to the delight of a peaceful reconciliation with Himself; to the happiness of an approving conscience; to a “hope full of immortality:” and, after death, He will crown that hope with a glorious consummation; will exalt that servant to the skies; far beyond the reach of change, of trouble, or of fear. The Christian, like the Captain of his Salvation, “will be made perfect through sufferings;” like Him, when the combat is over, will receive the crown of glory, and sit down for ever at the right hand of his Father and his God.

He will then more fully see and admire the gracious dealings of his merciful God and Saviour; will see, what reason he had to be thankful for the chastisements of heaven; how they have trained and prepared his soul for the happiness of the blest; how wonderfully they have ministered to the fulness of his joy. Bear then patiently; bear, I ought to say, thankfully, what the Lord layeth upon thee; it is His hand that “worketh all in all,” His hand of might and mercy. Thou canst not always trace His designs and operations; if thou couldst, where would be the exercise of thy faith? But if thou wilt believe and trust Him, if thou wilt bow and submit, He will thus exalt thee in due time, when thou art ready, when thy trial is completed, when thy appointed work is done. This is the seed-time; sow, and thou shalt see it spring up; labour, and wait for the harvest; “they that sow in tears shall reap in joy.” [\[171\]](#)

SERMON X.

THOU ART THE MAN.

2 SAM. xii. 7.

And Nathan said to David, Thou art the man.

THE parable, of which these words are a part, is admired, even for its elegance and simplicity, by every one who is capable of appreciating its merit. It serves also to illustrate, in the clearest manner, the advantage of this mode of instruction; which is intended, in the first place, by a lively representation of the productions of nature, or the incidents of common life, to convey an adequate notion of a truth or doctrine in easy and familiar terms; and to leave a more striking impression of it upon the memory and the heart. The parable has a further advantage: the instruction it affords is not at once unfolded to the mind; the attention and the feelings are first awakened, by the relation of some interesting occurrence, apparently unconnected with the object in view; by which means, an assent is gained over to the side of truth, before the understanding has had time to be prejudiced, by the workings of self-love, or the disinclination to religious admonition.

Such was precisely the case with the parable before us. Had Nathan addressed to David a direct and formal expostulation, it is probable that the king would have considered his interference as intrusive and impertinent; would have either driven him from his presence, or have been prepared, by some plausible excuse, to cast a veil over the hideousness of his crimes. But the royal offender, though he could readily palliate his own atrocity, could not bear to hear of cruelty in another. When it was reported to him, that there were two men in a city, the one rich and the other poor; that the rich man, when there came a traveller unto him, spared to take of the abundance of his own flock, and of his own herd, and took from the poor

man a little ewe lamb, which was all he had in the world; took it from him under the most affecting circumstances; “for he had bought and nourished it up, and it grew up together with him and with his children; it did eat of his own meat, and drank of his own cup, and lay in his bosom, and was unto him as a daughter.” When the king heard all this, his feelings were violently excited, “his anger was greatly kindled against the man; and he said to Nathan, as the Lord liveth, the man that hath done this thing shall surely die.” ^[174] This was the moment for making the application: and judge of David’s shame and confusion of face, on finding that all his pity, and all his anger, and all his condemnation, had in truth been directed against himself: “Thou art the man.” He could not help perceiving, that great as was the cruelty, which he had been reprobating in the case laid before him, he had been guilty of still greater himself: though he had the whole kingdom for the exercise of his legitimate choice, he would rather deprive an humble servant of the only object of his conjugal affection, deprive him, by becoming, in the first instance, accessory to his murder.

We may here observe, how terrible is the infatuation of sin. It might have been thought that David, if he had not immediately perceived the full intention of the prophet in laying this parable before him, would at least, from an instantaneous recollection of his own notorious guilt, have treated, with some degree of lenity or forbearance, the barbarity of which Nathan appeared to be complaining; that he would not so soon have denounced against a delinquent, so much less heinous than himself, the utmost severity of punishment. But, as if his own conscience were clear, he immediately exclaimed against the imagined offender, as a wretch unfit to live; he does not appear to have been awakened to a sense of his own crimes, till he heard the overwhelming application, “Thou art the man.”

Such is generally the fascination of sin; it darkens the understanding, and deadens the conscience, and renders men insensible to their real condition. It is the great object of the enemy of our souls, an object in which he too often fatally succeeds, to make us blind, not only to the heinousness and danger, but also to the very existence of guilt: so that, however acute we may be in perceiving the transgressions of others, and however severe in reprobating and condemning them, we are, in very frequent instances, utterly regardless of our own. Many, it is to be feared, there are, who persist in a course of sin day after day, and year after year, without once

feeling any lively or serious compunction; while they have frequently, in that time, been reproachfully animadverting upon the mote which they have detected in their brother's eye.

Perhaps of all the temporal consequences of sin, the operation of this evil habit is one of the most calamitous; for it not only prevents us from a repentance of the past, but serves as an encouragement to our reckless perseverance in sin; it destroys the very principle of vital religion; removing entirely from our hearts the love and fear of God; and filling us with "envy, hatred, and malice and all uncharitableness." Let David's infatuation be a warning to us, let it induce us to take diligent heed, lest we be irreclaimably "hardened by the deceitfulness of sin;" lest the conscience be at length so entirely seared, as to become callous to the very perception of iniquity; as to make us "call evil good, and good evil; to put darkness for light, and light for darkness; to put bitter for sweet, and sweet for bitter." [\[177\]](#)

Before, however, we further proceed to the practical inferences which may be drawn from this subject, it may be proper to notice some irreverent and reproachful remarks, which have been made on the flagrant crimes of a person so distinguished as David. Is it possible, some have urged, that such guilt, and such hardihood in guilt, could have been found in the "man after God's own heart?" [\[178\]](#) But this honourable appellation, be it observed, was given to David, not on account of his moral or spiritual purity, but on account of the excellence of his character as a king; he was so named in opposition to Saul, who had acted in wilful disobedience to the divine commands, and therefore, in the administration of his government, was not a man after God's own heart; that is, he did not (as David did, in this particular,) perform God's will.

Again, it has been said, could an inspired person possibly fall into such a complication of evil? Miraculous inspiration, we answer, was not given to the sacred pen-men, as a certain preservative from the corruption of sin, but to enable them to reveal the will of God; to guard them, in this respect, from error; and to "guide them into all truth:" their carnal appetites and passions were not supernaturally overruled; they still had their choice between good and evil; though revealing to mankind the holy law of God, they might themselves neglect the duties which it enjoined: many instances are recorded of the abuse of spiritual gifts, many examples of their consisting

with unholiness and transgression. The very chief of the apostles intimates to us the personal care and watchfulness and labour which were necessary, “lest, having preached to others, he himself should be a castaway.” [\[179\]](#)

Not but that David’s guilt was most deplorably inconsistent with his high character and office, and was a dishonour to religion itself; I am only shewing, that it was not incompatible with the appellation which he had received, and the high and holy functions which he was called to discharge. And be it remembered, to David’s honour, that though his sin was aggravated, his confession of it was full and unreserved; that he most humbly and religiously submitted to the penal retribution of his offended God; that his repentance was bitter and sincere: it was “a repentance indeed never afterwards repented of:” continually was his harp attuned to the bewailing of his own depravity; continually was he descending from the lofty strains of thanksgiving and joy, and pouring forth in the abasement of his soul, the doleful notes of mourning and lamentation.

And, in truth, there was abundant cause; for the crimes of David afford one of the most melancholy instances of the violation of conscience, of a departure from the service of the Most High. Let it fill us with humility and fear. If so eminent a servant of God could fall into such abominations, how deeply concerned, how “instant in prayer,” how vigilant and careful should we be, lest our feet be betrayed into evil! We see to what criminal and dangerous excess human nature may be led, if we fail to cherish the grace of God; and are abandoned to the government of our own corrupt desires, and the tyranny of our spiritual adversary. To the lukewarm and the wavering I need scarcely say, that without greater seriousness and circumspection, they will assuredly be overthrown: but let me also admonish the faithful Christian; him, who appears to be safely pursuing the even tenour of his way; who may be led, by the regular and habitual discharge of religious duties, into a state of presumptuous confidence and slumbering security; him I would admonish, from the instance of David, “that the heart is deceitful above all things, and desperately wicked;” [\[181a\]](#) that it may, when most implicitly trusted, most dangerously betray; let David teach “him that thinketh he standeth to take heed lest he fall.” [\[181b\]](#)

Some perverse and worldly-minded persons have made a very different use of the lamentable case before us; it has encouraged them in wilful

transgression; it has served them as a “cloak for their sin.” Surely, say they, if David could so flagrantly transgress, how can we be expected to preserve our integrity? If he was accepted of God, indulgence would readily be extended to the comparatively trifling offences of inferior servants. True; we cannot be perfect; we may hope for pardon; but we are not, on that account, to sin presumptuously; not to offend, because God is merciful: this did not David. Whoever deliberately sins from the hope of God’s mercy, is taking the surest way to deprive himself of that mercy. There is frequently great error in the notion of trifling offences: no offence is trifling in the sight of an infinitely holy God: much less any wilful offence. The magnitude of a fault chiefly depends upon the circumstances under which it is committed; much more readily could we urge an excuse for him, who is heedlessly or suddenly borne away by impetuous passion and carnal desire, than for him, who presumes deliberately to trample upon the law of God, because another has been forgiven. Shall we thus abuse the mercies of redeeming love? “Shall we continue in sin that grace may abound? God forbid. How shall we that are dead to sin, live any longer therein?” [\[183\]](#) Would we find the favour that David did, we must seek it, like him, in the true spirit of penitence and devotion; we must “confess our wickedness, and be sorry for our sin:” we must hate the works and workers of iniquity: we must imitate David, not in his crimes, but in his repentance and reformation.

Let us learn another lesson from the history before us; let it teach us the importance of being always disposed and ready to receive spiritual counsel; of being in the habit of applying to ourselves every opportunity of improvement, with which we may be blessed. Too many, like David, are extremely backward to receive an intimation of their own errors, and to avail themselves of the benefit of reproof. They are sufficiently quick-sighted in discovering the applicability of reproach, to their neighbour; without even suspecting that it may suit their own case and condition. How many have acknowledged the propriety and force of admonitions and rebuke, which they have heard in the house of God, without ever taking them home to their own breasts; and this undoubtedly is one cause, why the voice of public instruction produces, in general, so little effect upon the characters and conduct of men. While they are pleased to imagine, that the representations and censures of the preacher are suited to others rather than to themselves, no wonder that they retain their neglectful, sinful,

unprincipled habits, in defiance of every remonstrance, and every warning. Instead of torturing their ingenuity, to discover to what particular persons in the congregation a discourse may be most fitly and beneficially applied, let them rather be anxious to inquire, how far it may be accommodated to their own case; and to all those, who presume to make a further inquiry, who are looking around for the delinquencies of their neighbour, we would say, restrain thy wandering eye, and look within, “Thou art the man.”

A readiness to take advantage of religious instruction, is one of the surest evidences of a christian spirit, and one of the greatest blessings that a Christian can enjoy. It manifests a christian spirit, inasmuch as it shews an humble sense of our own failings and imperfections, and an anxious desire to recover from them all; to “grow in grace and in the knowledge of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ.” ^[185] It is one of the greatest blessings to the Christian, because there is seldom a day, seldom an hour that passes, from which he may not derive some spiritual benefit. While the reckless and self-conceited, who dwell with complacency upon their state and character, perceive not any counsel adapted to their wants, the humble-minded are gathering edification from every thing around them; from all they hear and all they see: doubtless, it must be so; for how can they, who think themselves whole, discover the need of a physician, how can they apply a remedy?

Suffer me to entreat you, in conclusion, that whenever you are seriously impressed with a conviction of evil, or the neglect of any christian duty, you will carry home the impression, to have its full effect upon the heart. For want of this care and this habit, many a salutary lesson, that strikes for the moment, is afterwards thrown away, unheeded and forgotten: and thus the very means of grace, which are ordained to recover us from sin, and enable us to “work out our salvation,” become the instruments of confirming us in error and guilt. The mind, which is continually accustomed to receive and to neglect religious instruction, may be thereby brought into a heedless and torpid state, from which it is well nigh impossible to be roused. Not that any thing “is impossible with God:” but I appeal to experience, and ask, whether it is not a notorious matter of fact, that many amongst us have for years uniformly persevered, in the same neglect of christian duties, the same worldly principles, the same evil courses, the same habits of intemperance and licentiousness and profaneness; and it will not be denied,

that they have, in these years, frequently heard the voice of expostulation, and perceived the justice, the force, and the importance of it. Then why are they still unreclaimed?—because they have never followed up the conviction of “Thou art the man.”

God grant, that this admonition may have its full effect upon us; that we may go and meditate, and pray; pray daily for the blessing of an humble and a teachable heart; pray for God’s grace, to correct all our sinful follies, and supply all our deficiencies. Probably, my brethren, we have been “leaning too little upon the hope of this heavenly grace;” we have been relying upon our own perception of right and wrong, our own choice and decision, our own feeble resolutions; if so, no wonder that we have failed, in our work of repentance and spiritual change. “Turn Thou us unto Thee, O Lord, and we shall be turned:” [\[188\]](#) here lies our hope and our strength, in the renewing influence of the Spirit of God. As we do desire, so let us fervently pray, that we may, in our course of penitence, imitate the example of the royal psalmist, and let contrition “have its perfect work;” that we may, here below, with heart and soul, join in the pious and repentant strains of David’s harp, and thus may be admitted to sing to other harps hereafter, in the chorus of the Redeemed above.

SERMON XI.

THE WAY OF THE LORD EQUAL.

EZEK. xviii. 25.

Ye say, the way of the Lord is not equal. Hear now, O house of Israel; is not my way equal? are not your ways unequal?

THE main purport of this chapter was, to obviate some objections which had been groundlessly entertained against the dealings of God with His people. They were at that time suffering in a state of captivity; and the calamities attendant upon it had been threatened long before, as a punishment for the sins of their ancestors. The Jews, therefore, assuming that this was the only cause of divine vengeance; imagining, in the blindness and pride of their hearts, that there were no delinquencies of their own to deserve such retribution, presumed to charge the Almighty with injustice, for this visitation of His wrath.

The prophet, in the opening of the chapter, thus remonstrates with them: “What mean ye, that ye use this proverb concerning the land of Israel?” (concerning the evils with which it is afflicted,) that ye say, in the language of accusation and reproach, “the fathers have eaten sour grapes and the children’s teeth are set on edge?”—thereby meaning, that the present generation are unjustly punished for the transgressions of their forefathers. “As I live, saith the Lord, ye shall not have occasion to use this proverb any more in Israel.” I will make so visible a discrimination between the righteous and the wicked, between those who tread in the steps of their wicked progenitors, and those who take warning by their examples, that you shall not have any further occasion to use this proverb amongst you.

The Jews, in this as in many other instances, misunderstood and perverted the dispensations of the Most High. God had declared, that He would “visit

the sins of the fathers upon the children,” and that He “would shew mercy unto thousands of those that loved Him;” from which they inferred, that worldly calamities, in the one case, and prosperity in the other, constituted the sole recompence, which they were severally to expect: they supposed, that when a nation was punished, on account of the general depravity, no respect was had to the different merits of individuals, of which that nation consisted; and that, when a people were prospered and exalted, as the reward of righteousness, they were all, of necessity, the objects of divine favour. Whereas, these temporal rewards and punishments formed but a part of the dispensation, under which they were placed. God had far other means in store, to bless the faithful and to afflict the transgressor. Under every visitation, His unerring eye could discern between the evil and the good; the one, however prosperous in a worldly point of view, He could mortify and humble; and the other, in whatever evil they might be involved, He could favour and bless.

But there was still another consideration, to which the Jews, though they practically disregarded it, were specially directed; a consideration, which might have taught them, how the seeming irregularities, of which they complained, would be completely rectified; it was that of a final judgment, of a world to come. Their prophet Isaiah expressly says of the transgressors, that “their worm shall not die, neither shall their fire be quenched.” ^[192a] And Daniel more particularly intimates the awful difference between the conditions of the righteous and the wicked in a future state; “many of them that sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake: some to everlasting life, and some to shame and everlasting contempt.” ^[192b] But the Israelites “had eyes and saw not, ears and heard not;” ^[193a] they listened only the temporal promises of God, and excluded from their minds the prospect of a final retribution, of a kingdom to come. The prophet awakens them to this consideration in the 4th verse, “Behold, saith the Lord, all souls are Mine:” as they are all equally My creatures, so My dealings with them shall be without prejudice or partiality; “The soul that sinneth, it shall die:” this denunciation could not possibly be understood of temporal death; for that, they knew, must pass equally upon all: it must relate to a final execution of judgment, to future misery and destruction. The Jews were familiar with this form of speech and this application of it: of wisdom it is said, “They that hate me, love *death*.” ^[193b] “There is a way that seemeth right unto a

man, but the end thereof are the ways of *death*.” ^[193c] A similar mode of speech, we may observe, frequently occurs in the New Testament also; in which we continually find expressions and figures borrowed from the Old: “If ye live after the flesh, ye shall die; but if ye, through the spirit, do mortify the deeds of the body, ye shall live.” ^[194a] And, in the book of Revelation, mention is made of the *second death*; ^[194b] a term which was in use among the Jews themselves, though not found in their inspired writings. And in the same sense, we shall perceive, the figure is repeatedly employed in the chapter before us.

The prophet therefore vindicates the justice and equity of God on two substantial grounds: he directs his murmuring and rebellious people to consider, that they were visited with calamity for their own transgressions, as well as for those of their forefathers; and he refers them to the future and final judgment of the Almighty, in which the prosperity of the wicked and the sufferings of the righteous alike terminate; in which both shall receive their just and everlasting recompence. “The son shall not bear the iniquity of the father, neither shall the father bear the iniquity of the son; the righteousness of the righteous shall be upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked shall be upon him.” “Have I any pleasure at all that the wicked should die, saith the Lord God, and not that he should return from his ways and live?” ^[195]

The passages last mentioned may introduce to our notice two considerations, most distinctly and forcibly stated in the latter part of this chapter, in both of which we are very deeply and peculiarly interested; they are these; that if the wicked repent of their evil ways and turn heartily to God, they shall be forgiven and received into His favour; but that if the righteous fall away, they shall be condemned and perish: on the one hand, there is ample encouragement to the sinner to return; on the other, an awful admonition, to the righteous, of the necessity of perseverance unto the end. How gracious the instruction in either point of view! If it were not for the heavenly assurance of the offer of pardon to all, without partiality or exception, many a flagrant transgressor, when brought to a sense of his sin and shame—his conscience pierced with the remembrance of so manifold offences against a just and holy God, his soul over-burdened with the load of guilt—might sit down disconsolate and despairing in the shadow of death: and if it were not for a warning voice, bidding them, as they hope for

salvation, to persevere, the righteous, when assailed by temptation, might at length be induced to yield, under a presumption, that their former obedience, that the good deeds they had already performed, would turn the balance in their favour, and procure for them acceptance at the tribunal of God, though they were ultimately found in the way of evil. Into this error the Jews had actually fallen; and do, as it is affirmed, continue unto this day; and others might “follow their pernicious ways.”

Each of the important doctrines, which we are now considering, is declared by the prophet in the most explicit and unequivocal terms. “If the wicked will turn from all his sins that he hath committed, and keep all My statutes, and do that which is lawful and right, he shall surely live, he shall not die. All his transgressions that he hath committed, they shall not be mentioned unto him: in his righteousness that he hath done, he shall live.” ^[197] None of his former transgressions shall exclude him from the privileges and blessings of God’s people; he shall be freely and fully received, without reproach, into a gracious covenant with his God. This condition of acceptance manifestly implies a vital belief in the sovereignty and mercy of God; for without this, none would be encouraged to turn unto Him with the hope of forgiveness and favour: “He that cometh to God must believe that He is, and that He is the rewarder of them that diligently seek Him.” ^[198a] “The just shall live by his faith;” ^[198b] and the duties which the prophet prescribed to his people, as the means of saving their souls alive, were evidently regarded by him as the fruit of that faith. Thus, therefore, they were left without excuse; no longer able to say, “that the way of the Lord was not equal;” for so far from having decreed to involve them all in the same indiscriminate punishment, He was willing, nay desirous, of admitting into His favour even the most disobedient and abandoned amongst them. Although in a state of miserable bondage, He would either “break their bonds asunder,” and provide them with a place of refuge; or He would make their bodily afflictions minister to the well-being of their souls. If the light of His countenance shone upon them, happy was their lot in the darkest hour of suffering and privation: and if they did not live to enjoy a restoration to the privileges of their own land, still might they rejoice, in the prospect of being restored to their forfeited inheritance in the mansions of eternal peace. Would they but forsake the idols, after which they were gone astray, and turn to “love the Lord their God with all their heart and soul and

strength,” “ceasing to do evil, and learning to do well,” though “their sins were as scarlet, they should be as white as snow; though they were red like crimson, they should be as wool.” ^[199] Surely none but the obstinate and rebellious, none but the hardest and most ungrateful heart, could complain of the dealings of God. Wonderful indeed was the patience which had borne with them so long; adorable the mercy which was still held out for the encouragement and return of a backsliding people.

Under the gospel dispensation, the same gracious doctrine is yet more fully revealed. “If any man sin, we have an Advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous.” ^[200a] “If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins, and to cleanse us from *all* unrighteousness.” ^[200b] “The Lord is long-suffering to us-ward, not willing that any should perish, but that *all* should come to repentance.” ^[200c] Texts indeed there are without number of the same merciful import; and numerous also are the examples, recorded in Holy writ, in which the Saviour vouchsafed His loving kindness and favour to the weary and heavy-laden sinner; “seeking and saving those that were lost;” and thus affording us the most ample assurance of the truth of His own gracious promise, “Him that cometh to me I will in no wise cast out.” ^[200d] Are there any amongst us, my brethren, who have not yet made their peace with God; any, whom Satan hath hitherto held fast in “the gall of bitterness, and the bond of iniquity;” who feel the wretchedness of their condition here, and are alarmed at the expectation of what may come hereafter? May “the goodness of God lead them to repentance!” However deep and dangerous the wounds which sin has made in their hearts, there is “balm in Gilead,” if they will earnestly seek it, and apply it to their souls: their offended Lord is still “waiting to be gracious;” and though they have been prodigally wasting his bounty in riotous living, yet if they be at length pierced to the heart by the misery to which it has brought them, and be truly desirous of returning to their peaceful home, and be ready, with all humility and contrition, to acknowledge their unworthiness, and to seek again the divine favour, from which they have been so unhappily estranged, then they will be received even with welcome; if but one sinner return, there “will be joy in heaven;” and the family of the blest will hail his reception; and his wanderings shall be mentioned no more. “Awake thou that sleepest and rise from the dead, and Christ shall give thee light.” ^[202]

But let not this gracious offer of mercy be abused; let it not act as an encouragement to a continuance in sin, under a notion that transgressions, however multiplied and aggravated, may be, at any future day, repented and forgiven. The grace of repentance, like every other good gift, cometh from God; and the proffered mercy, which is long and obstinately rejected, may be, and often is, withdrawn. If we will not hear, while the Almighty now speaks; if we will not answer, while He is now calling, “the ear may become heavy that it cannot hear,” and we may be left to perish in our sins. One word more; think of the many sudden departures; you are not without awakening and awful examples; your eye may be closed in death, while it is turned away from your God; or if you should be permitted to experience a few days’ alarm, God alone knows what effect it may produce upon the heart. Seek Him “in health and wealth;” the work is of amazing magnitude and everlasting importance; it demands all your vigour, all the unclouded faculties of your soul.

And let those who have embraced the blessed gospel, in sincerity and truth, who are believing in the name of Jesus for salvation, and “are fruitful in every good word and work,” ever bear in mind the absolute necessity of persevering in the good and holy cause. For of what service can it be, to begin the race with animation, and to pursue it, for a season, with ever so great activity, if they loiter before the end, and relinquish their exertions “for the prize of their high calling?” “When the righteous turneth away from his righteousness and committeth iniquity, and doeth according to all the abominations that the wicked man doeth, shall he live? All his righteousness that he hath done shall not be mentioned; in his trespass that he hath trespassed, and in his sin that he hath sinned, in them shall he die.” Here also we must allow, that “the way of God is equal.” ^[204] For surely it argues the most depraved and abandoned state of mind and heart, to depart from our God and our Redeemer, after having been once convinced of the truth and the blessedness of His holy religion; having “tasted how gracious the Lord is,” having experienced the guidance and comfort and support of his all-powerful spirit, having had our “hopes full of immortality,” having enjoyed a foretaste of the happiness of heaven, after all to fall away, and prefer to these exalted objects, the miserable pleasures, the base indulgencies, the perishable possessions of earth! A change so disastrous must reduce the understanding and heart into the worst condition of which

they are capable. It is the evil spirit, which had been once cast out, returning to his abode, with seven other spirits more wicked than himself, and dwelling there, as in a settled home, and the last state of that man is worse than the first. ^[205a] The Apostle represents the matter to us in this light: for so difficult is it for a person, in such a state, to be worked upon by any consideration, that he describes it, in his strong language, as an actual impossibility: “it is impossible, (he says) for those who were once enlightened, and have tasted of the heavenly gift, and were made partakers of the Holy Ghost, and have tasted the good word of God, and the powers of the world to come, if they shall fall away, to renew them again unto repentance;” ^[205b] and then he adds the reason, “seeing they crucify to themselves the Son of God afresh, and put Him to an open shame;” they maintain the horrid principles and character of those who “crucified the Lord of glory;” they deliberately renounce his friendship, and become “enemies to the cross of Christ;” they cast a shameful reproach upon Him, infinitely greater than it is possible for those enemies to do, who were never admitted into the privilege and happiness of His favour. Fain would we hope, that this is a case of rare occurrence; but it is possible, or why should the prophet and Apostle have represented it? “Therefore, let him that thinketh he standeth, take heed lest he fall;” ^[206a] “let him give all diligence to make his calling and election sure.” ^[206b] “The just shall live by his faith: but if *that man*, (however faithful and just he has been) draw back, my soul shall have no pleasure in him;” ^[206c] this is the proper translation of the passage. God Almighty of His infinite mercy grant, that the words which follow this text, addressed by the Apostle to the faithful disciples of old, may be realized by all of us here; “we, (says he,) are not of them who draw back unto perdition; but of them that believe to the saving of the soul.” Pray to God without ceasing for grace to persevere: His Holy Spirit, if sought and cherished and used, will enable us to be faithful and to overcome, will “make us more than conquerors, through Him that loved us.” ^[207a]

In conclusion then, I ask, “is not the way of the Lord equal?” And of those, who presume to arraign it, are not the ways unequal? Equal and merciful do all the ways of God appear, whenever they can be traced; equal and merciful they are, whether they can be traced or not. “O man, who art thou that repliest against God?” ^[207b] “Shall not the judge of all the earth do

right?” ^[207c] Humble thyself, and accept His proffered mercy: Hear His words; “Look unto Me, and be ye saved, all the ends of the earth: for I am God, and there is none else.” ^[207d] Salvation is all that the sinner can desire; and surely he can repose, without doubt or distrust upon the all-wise, all-merciful, omnipotent God. Understanding and experiencing, in so many instances, the divine wisdom and mercy, we can have no difficulty in believing, that God “doeth all things well.” “He that spared not his own Son, but delivered Him up for us all, how shall He not with Him also freely give us all things?” ^[208a] Most unreasonable, most ungrateful would it be to question or complain. No true believer does so: he is thoroughly convinced of the truth of God’s word, and the equity of God’s dealings and dispensations. This is his concern, this the great purpose resting in his soul, to be reconciled to God in His own appointed way; to be made an inheritor of His eternal kingdom. He knows, and it is enough for him to know, that “the grace of God, which bringeth salvation, hath appeared to all men;” ^[208b] he believes, and he acts upon the belief, that “the blood of Jesus Christ cleanseth us from all sin;” ^[208c] he seeks to “wash and be clean,” and faithfully waits for the promised blessing: “Verily there is a reward for the righteous; verily He is a God that judgeth the earth.” ^[208d]

SERMON XII.

THE NEW MAN.

EPH. iv. 24.

That ye put on the new man, which after God is created in righteousness and true holiness.

IN treating of these words, it shall be my first object to explain their real nature and import. St. Paul has been describing, in this chapter, the character of the unregenerate Gentiles, who “walked in the vanity of their mind, having the understanding darkened, being alienated from the life of God through the ignorance that is in them, because of the blindness of their heart.” And this description applies, with almost equal force and truth, to a considerable portion of those who have “named the name of Christ:” though they acknowledge with their lips the truth and obligation of the christian religion, they still “walk in the vanity of their minds.” As to any saving view of the truth, “the understanding is yet darkened:” and though their ignorance be removed, with respect to a revelation of the divine will, they are as far as ever from “the life of God;” though the mind is enlightened with the knowledge of the fact, the blindness of the heart remains.

The Apostle proceeds to say of his Ephesian converts, “but ye have not so learned Christ”—“if so be, that ye have heard Him” (or rather, as the phrase may properly imply, *forasmuch* as ye have heard Him) “and have been taught by Him as the truth is in Jesus.” And what had they heard, as necessary to their salvation by His name, and what is the truth they had been taught?—“that ye put off, concerning the former conversation (the former life and conduct), the old man, which is corrupt, according to the deceitful lusts” (the worldly principles and the sinful habits above described, to which you were addicted before your conversion); and “be renewed (or made new) in the spirit of your mind; and that ye put on the

new man, which after God is created in righteousness and true holiness;" the change thus produced being so great and important as to be compared to a new creation; the inner man being totally different from what he was before. It is said, moreover, that the new man "is created *after God* in righteousness;" this is fully explained by the same Apostle, in his Epistle to the Colossians, where he is treating on the same subject; he there speaks of the converts being renewed "after the image of Him who created them." [\[211\]](#) At the creation of Adam, God is represented as saying, "Let us make man in our image, after our likeness," that is, in perfect innocence and purity. Thus was Adam formed, perfectly upright and holy: by disobedience his nature was changed; he became sinful and unholy; and this change was entailed upon all his posterity. The object, therefore, of the new creation is to restore in us, as far as we are now capable of it, that image of divine righteousness, which man lost by the fall. On considering, then, the holy nature of God, we are at once made acquainted with that change, in the natural man, which the gospel teaches and requires; we are brought to perceive and acknowledge that "true holiness," which as Christians we are bound to desire and attain.

The same truth may be said to have been substantially revealed to the servants of God under the old dispensation: there is no express mention indeed of a new creation of the individual; but the prophets every where assert, what is similar in effect, that no wicked person, without hearty repentance and an entire change of character, must expect the divine favour. To this purpose is the language of Isaiah: "Wash you, make you clean; put away the evil of your doings from before mine eyes; cease to do evil, learn to do well." [\[213a\]](#) The unclean and unrighteous cannot stand before God. "As I live, saith the Lord God, (by the mouth of Ezekiel) I have no pleasure in the death of the wicked, but that the wicked turn from his way and live; turn ye, turn ye from your evil ways; for why will ye die, house of Israel?" [\[213b\]](#) The prophet thereto plainly intimating, that notwithstanding all that goodness and long-suffering of the divine nature, which is expressed in a most compassionate invitation, and is confirmed even by the solemnity of an oath, yet if sinners did not "turn from their evil ways," there was no remedy, but they must die. And the same prophet on another occasion, uses language very similar to that of the text; "I will put a *new* spirit within you, and I will take the stony heart out of their flesh—that they may walk in my

statutes and keep mine ordinances, and do them, and they shall be my people, and I will be their God.” [\[214a\]](#) Agreeably to this, the same people are subsequently exhorted, to “cast away from them all the transgressions whereby they had transgressed, and to make them a new heart and a new spirit.” [\[214b\]](#) However therefore, the New Covenant doth exceed the Old, with regard to the clearness of its manifestations, and its fuller dispensations of grace, yet are there in both of them the same consistent terms of reconciliation and salvation for rebellious man; in both are enjoined the same purity of spirit, and integrity of character; this is the plain, uniform, infallible intimation of both, that “without holiness no man shall see the Lord.” [\[214c\]](#)

That the people of old were but partially awake and alive to the great change required to be wrought in them, from sin to righteousness, from the love of evil to the love of good, from a “bondage unto the elements of the world” to the glorious liberty of the children of God, is too fully proved from the complaints of patriarchs and prophets and holy men of every determination. The sound of the gospel, thank God, has now gone forth into all lands, and brought “life and immortality to light;” it has awakened many nations, who lay fast bound in the slumbers of spiritual death; but whether it has vitally and savingly awakened a greater proportion of those, to whom the glad tidings have been revealed, is a matter of reasonable doubt. At least, if we compare what man is by nature, with what he may be and ought to be by divine grace, it must appear, from the life and conduct of the great majority in the christian world, that they have by no means attained that renovation of spirit and principle and character, which can entitle them to the appellation of new creatures.

Of how many may it be said, (and their own consciences will bear witness to the truth of the accusation,) that their thoughts are ordinarily flowing in much the same channel, their passions yielding to the same excitements, and their pursuits directed to the same end, as they would have been, had the pure doctrines and precepts of Christ never been promulgated. Vast numbers, in the visible Church of Christ, who profess some regard for religion, instead of raising their affections to the standard of the gospel, are seeking to *bring down* the immoveable standard of the gospel to *them*: and greater numbers still, of reckless men, bestow not so much as a thought upon that spiritual change, which is absolutely essential to the christian

character. For what is the religion of thousands amongst us?—merely, if I may so call it, that traditionary acquaintance with divine things, which is acquired in infancy; that outward assent to evangelical truths, which was handed down to them by their forefathers; a cold respect for the shadow, without any concern for the substance: they are content to observe the forms of religion, because they have been accustomed so to do, and their neighbours do the same; and to attend to what are called the decencies of life, because they would otherwise be disreputable; to crimes and to holiness strangers perhaps alike; satisfied to do no worse, than they see the multitudes around them doing; and resting their claim to God’s favour on a few moral pretensions, or even on the absence of scandalous immorality; probably looking for exemption from the penalties of the divine law, because their transgressions have never been such, as to expose them to the scourge of the law of man.

This, however deplorable, is a true description of no inconsiderable portion of our christian land; to none of *us*, we may hope, is the description strictly applicable; but it is too probable, that there are many amongst us, who partake more or less of the character here delineated; who practically regard the christian religion as a system to be accommodated to their dispositions and habits and pursuits of life, and not as demanding a total alteration in their views and tempers and motives of action. Though their thoughts are directed to objects, far above those of “the heathen who know not God” and though their morality, upon the whole, be of a higher order and a purer cast, yet are their affections willingly led captive by the ensnaring vanities and engrossing interests of this lower world: heaven is the object of their settled creed, but it is not the main purpose to which their endeavours are anxiously and daily directed; in balancing between this or that pursuit, their thoughts are intent only upon providing for “the meat that perisheth,” without any enquiry or concern, how they may best provide for “that which endureth unto eternal life.” ^[218] And the morality, on which they so complacently rest, has frequently no connexion whatever with the christian faith; referable rather to philosophy than the gospel, to “the praise of men than the praise of God.” Hence it follows, that their moral obedience is lamentably defective; extending only to the performance of those duties, which least oppose their inclination or their temporal advantage; while even such duties are but imperfectly discharged. Their self-government is

wretchedly defective; the controul of their thoughts, the mastery over their passions, the command over their tongue, are attainments which they seldom bind it upon their conscience to acquire. And though they be turned from idols to worship the living and the true God, the fruit of their service, as well as the irregularity of it, affords but too clear a proof, that they “worship him not in spirit and in truth.” However improved, in their moral character, by their acquaintance with the christian religion, they cannot possibly have imbibed its spirit; nor have arrived at that happy change of the natural man, which can be denominated by a new creation. They are working out, or rather seeking to work out, their salvation on maxims of human expediency, and in accommodation to human interests; not with “fear and trembling,” lest they should lose the inestimable prize; they are not evincing, that it is “God that worketh in them both to will and to do.” [\[220\]](#)

I have thus enlarged, on the presents occasion, upon the enormous deficiencies of christian character, because it is of great importance for us to understand, what is not accordant with the principles of the gospel, as well as what is: it is of vital consequence, that we should be thoroughly aware of the insufficiency of that spirit and view, of those maxims and motives of those habits and observances, which pass current for religion in the world.

We cannot put on the new man, unless we put off the old; and we cannot put off the old, unless we thoroughly understand in what it consists. The work is too commonly supposed much easier and much less comprehensive, than it really is: many vicious habits may be corrected, without any essential or fundamental alteration of character. A man may become weary of the pursuits, disgusted with the follies, worn and sated with the profligacies of life; he may find his circumstances impoverished, his reputation impaired, his worldly interest obstructed: and such considerations as these may generate a purpose of moral reform. Or the sinner may feel himself oppressed with the increasing weight of years; infirmities are coming fast upon him; and his conscience, in many a whisper of fear, tells him that something should be done, some preparation made, for the world to which he is hastening, for the account which he will speedily be called to render. The idea of dying with those depravities, to which he has clinged through life, is awful and insupportable. The more flagrant of them are accordingly corrected; and the rest, which are less startling and disquieting, are undisturbedly retained. In all this there is no change of principle, no vital

alteration: the old man continues; less hideous in features and outward appearance, but the very same in reality. With this partial renovation the mind is satisfied; the conscience is becalmed; the sinner dies.

Through the “deceivableness of unrighteousness,” through the wiles of Satan and the evil propensity of our own hearts, we are always in danger of being too easily content with our spiritual condition; we look too much to the outward and visible form, and too little within; to little to the habitual principle, the constraining motive, the cast of character: and it is in this, that the difference between the old and the new man, in the christian world essentially consists. Suffer me to point out again a few of the broad lines of distinction. The old man, whatever of religion he may profess, lives principally for himself and the world; he may think of religion, and speak of it, and pray for it with the lips, but it has no dwelling place in his heart, is not the business of his life. However observable, in many respects, his moral deportment may be, his character is seldom consistent. From some evil pursuits he abstains, in others he wilfully and constantly indulges; some evil passions are kept in creditable order, others are let loose; some duties he professedly performs, and others he professedly omits. And nothing is done with a true christian motive, or christian view; nothing from a sense of absolute and uncompromising obedience to the will of God. Nor is it surprising, that there should be such deficiencies and inconsistencies in his character; he has no principle or means, by which he can possibly walk uprightly with his God. He does not “believe with the heart unto righteousness;” he does not seek, nor desire, to “live in the spirit and walk in the spirit;” there is no life in his devotion, no sincerity in his prayer: he “asks not faithfully” for repentance and holiness, and they cannot be “effectually received.” He is not disposed to bring his understanding and heart into subjection to the divine will. He studies not that holy word, which ministers the principle of a divine life, and the spirit of obedience to the soul. He lives for earth and not for heaven. He is too proud to be taught the humiliating doctrines of revelation; too full of himself, to bow implicitly to his Redeemer. In a word, nature is his book and not the Bible; the world is his teacher and not the Spirit of God; earthly and not spiritual subjects are the delight of his heart; he walks not “by faith, but by sight.”

The new man is the reverse of all this; he humbles himself, as a sinner, at the foot of the cross, under a deep sense of his own guilt and the divine

mercy; desirous only to be reconciled and saved; he constantly studies the mysteries God's word, with a submissive understanding and an obedient heart; he rests his only hope on the merit of a Redeemer, whose promises and whose law he receives with all his mind and soul and strength; he prays "without ceasing" for the Holy Spirit, is directed by His teaching, supported by His power, and comforted by His heavenly illumination. Doubtless he must live *in* the world, and *by* the world, as well as other people; but he does not live *for* the world; his heart is not there, his delight is not there; he is a redeemed pilgrim, journeying in a far country, returning to his Father's house; and his heart is musing on the "many mansions" there, and full of the inspiring influential hope, that one of them is prepared for him.

Such holy principles are continually manifested by a determination of purpose, a decisiveness of character, a devoted spirit of uniform obedience to the revealed will of God. As the conscience bears witness, so does the life: "the tree is known by its fruit;" all evil affections are resolutely mortified, all sinful pleasures and pursuits utterly abandoned. The sincere Christian, the new man, has an earnest desire and care upon his soul, to be "righteous before God, walking in all the commandments and ordinances of the Lord blameless." [\[226a\]](#) For this blessing he daily prays; in this work he daily advances: "loving the Lord God with all his heart," and "loving his neighbour as himself," he is of all men the most inclined, as he is assuredly the most bound, to "live soberly, righteously and godly in this present world." [\[226b\]](#)

These remarks suggest the necessity of further admonition on this head. Many persons have been led to entertain enthusiastic notions on the subject of the new man, the new creation, the new birth. They have supposed it principally to consist in certain inward experiences or feelings, which they have been enabled to trace to some particular event or period: the Holy Spirit, as they believe, then beginning, for the first time, to work upon their understandings and hearts; and thus leaving an indelible impression, the seal of their redemption, the earnest of their certain acceptance with God. Far are we from denying, that such sudden conversions may and do take place: still farther from denying that, whether sudden or gradual, a change from the old to the new man is attributable to the aid of a divine energy and power. It is, properly speaking, a new creation; the imparting of a new nature: and cannot be effected without the hand of the original Creator:

without the operation of that Spirit, which “moved upon the face of the waters,” which “breathed into the nostrils the breath of life, so that man became a living soul.” ^[227a] Our Liturgy has correctly and fully embodied the testimony of scripture, on this as on other points: we are taught to pray, that God will “*create* in us new and contrite hearts.” This blessing must proceed from that Holy Spirit, who still in His ordinary dispensations, as formerly in His miraculous gifts, “divides unto every man severally as He will;” ^[227b] not as it were capriciously, but according to His own infinite wisdom and goodness, as He judges expedient to the case of each individual. But this divine grace is not communicated for the mere purpose of producing a glowing affection, a familiar experience, an enraptured view of spiritual things: nor can any inward feelings alone prove that such grace has been administered at all: the proof must be manifested, in the way pointed out by the text: the new man “is created, after God, in *righteousness and true holiness*.” A holy character and a righteous life are the proper and indispensable evidences of such a change; a faithful walking with God, a sober self-government, an upright dealing with all mankind.

I counsel you, my brethren, in the language of truth and the spirit of affection, to be content with no other evidence: equally far be you removed from that carnal profession of the gospel, which despises or neglects the mighty change required of every sincere believer; and from those fanciful notions of spiritual experience, which leave the heart and the character arrayed in the spotted garment of sin: both in the one case and the other, you will be “grieving the spirit,” and “quenching the spirit.” In your principles and life, as well as in your views and affections and desires, “let old things pass away, and all things become new;” ^[229a] “put off the old man with the deceitful lusts,” and thus let the new man be put on. “Abhor that which is evil: cleave to that which is good.” ^[229b] This is the method ordained of God, by which we are to “work out our salvation;” this our plain, this our necessary duty. Pray we fervently, strive we diligently, that we may be thus effectually turned from sin to holiness, “from darkness to light, from the power of Satan unto God.” ^[229c]

SERMON XIII.

THE WEDDING GARMENT.

MATT. xxii. 2.

The kingdom of heaven is like unto certain king which made a marriage for his son.

It is my intention, in this discourse, to explain the several particulars of the parable before us; which may be regarded, in the *first* place, as descriptive of the dispensation of the gospel to the people of Israel and the world at large; and, in the *second* place, as instructing us in that peculiar fitness necessary to all, who shall be admitted to enjoy the privileges and happiness of the kingdom of God.

The state of the gospel, our Saviour informs us, may be compared to the conduct of a king at the marriage of his son; or rather, as the meaning is, at the marriage *feast* which he gave on that occasion: the circumstances which might, in that case, be supposed to occur, aptly represent a variety of particulars belonging to the gospel dispensation.

Before, however, we enter upon the parable, it may be remarked, that spiritual blessings are frequently set forth in the holy scriptures, under allusions to feasting and refreshment. Thus Solomon of old: "Wisdom hath builded her house, she hath hewn out her seven pillars: she hath killed her beasts; she hath mingled her wine; she hath also furnished her table. Come, eat of my bread, and drink of the wine which I have mingled. Forsake the foolish, and live; and go in the way of understanding." ^[231] And thus the prophet Isaiah, in describing the state of the gospel: "In this mountain shall the Lord of hosts make unto all people a feast of fat things, a feast of wines on the lees, of fat things full of marrow, of wines on the lees well refined."

^[232a] And thus our blessed Lord Himself: "I appoint unto you a kingdom, as

My Father hath appointed unto Me, that ye may eat and drink at My table in My kingdom.” [\[232b\]](#)

1. Let us now proceed with the parable: “He sent forth his servants to call them that were bidden to the wedding (feast); and they would not come.” This probably alludes to the first period of the promulgation of the gospel; under the preaching of John the Baptist and of the earliest disciples; the former endeavouring to prepare the hearts of men for the kingdom and coming of Christ; and the latter proclaiming His glorious arrival, preaching the truth of His gospel, and confirming the word by a display of miraculous power. But the Jews had been a carnal people, “holding the truth in unrighteousness;” and they refused to give ear to those holy instructions, which called upon them to “lay the axe to the root of all sin,” and to “bring forth fruits meet for repentance.” [\[233a\]](#) This it was that prevented them, not only from a cordial acceptance of the gospel, but even from a fair examination and inquiry; they would not listen to such doctrine; their heart was decided against it: to this it was owing, these carnal habits and views, that when their Messiah came, they were not ready to receive Him in the way which He required. Ready enough were they to admit Him in their own way; agreeably to their own notions and desires, as an earthly conqueror, as the dispenser of temporal blessings and rewards; but not as the abolisher of sin; not as a preacher of righteousness; not as a herald, announcing to them the necessity of holiness in this world, and the inheritance of glory in the world to come. Not all His amazing miracles, not all His fulfilment of their own prophecies, not all the power of His word, could convince their understandings; because they had “an evil heart of unbelief:” [\[233b\]](#) and therefore, notwithstanding His awful warnings, His earnest and affectionate invitations, “they would not come” unto Him, that they might find rest unto their souls.

Here we behold, as in a glass, the real ground of every rejection of the Saviour in every age; it is not because men deny His excellency, or His power, or His mercy, or the greatness of His kingdom: it is because they “love this present evil world,” and the “god of this world hath blinded their minds,” [\[234a\]](#) through the deceitfulness of sin. Even though eternal salvation is offered them, and they do not disbelieve it; still, awful to think! the Saviour is rejected for perishable interests and sensual indulgences. “He feedeth on ashes; a deceived heart hath turned him aside, that he cannot

deliver his soul, nor say, is there not a lie in my right hand?" ^[234b] Men walk on in darkness because they love it; and they "love darkness rather than light, because their deeds are evil." ^[234c]

2. But the Jews were not yet cast off, without further admonition and entreaty. "Again He sent forth other servants, saying, tell them who are bidden, behold I have prepared my dinner; my oxen and my fatlings are killed, and all things are ready; come unto the marriage" feast. But "they made light of it," and offered a variety of groundless excuses. This may chiefly refer to the fuller manifestation of the gospel, after the resurrection and ascension of our blessed Lord; for the parable, as we shall more clearly perceive in the sequel, is partly of a prophetic nature; and intended to represent to the Jews their persevering spirit of obstinacy, and the punishment which would ensue; that some of them at least, when the fulness of the time should come, might be struck with the force of this predictive representation, and be converted to the "truth as it is in Jesus."

Every thing requisite for the sumptuous feast was liberally provided: in the days of the apostles, abundant indeed was the confirmation of the truth and doctrines of the gospel; bright the manifestation of heavenly glory, that was shed abroad upon it. Then were strikingly fulfilled the words of their prophet Joel; "I will pour out My Spirit upon all flesh—also upon the servants and the handmaids in those days will I pour out My Spirit." ^[236] Accordingly the gifts of the Holy Ghost—were openly poured forth, and mighty were the deeds done and the words spoken by His servants, under the operation of His marvellous power: the old dispensation was fully brought to bear upon the new: it was shewn how the character of Jesus corresponded, in His birth and life and death and resurrection and ascension, as well as in His offices of Priest and Mediator and King, with various prophecies and types exhibited in the ancient scriptures. The benefits and blessings of the christian dispensation were more particularly and largely set forth: the feast was fully displayed before them, in all its rich and magnificent abundance. Many were then induced to enter into the guest chamber, and partake of the heavenly repast; but many more, the Jewish nation at large, made light of it, and went their way. And not only so: not only was the invitation unheeded and despised; but the remnant, that is, some who were not content with disobeying the call, "took his servants,

and entreated them spitefully and slew them;" persecuted the disciples even unto death.

3. We now come to a part of the parable, which must of necessity receive a prophetic interpretation: "When the King heard thereof, he was wroth, and he sent forth his armies and destroyed those murderers, and burnt up their city." This plainly points out the Roman armies ravaging Judea, destroying Jerusalem, and putting the inhabitants to the sword; an event, which did not take place till many years after. Neither, in truth, is there mention made, in the gospel history, of the Jews having slain any of the disciples, whilst their Lord was with them. They were murderers of the Son of God, and of many of His apostles and disciples after Him; thus "filling up the measure of their iniquity," and drawing down upon themselves, and their nation at large, the most tremendous visitation of divine wrath, ever inflicted in this world upon a rebellious people.

4. We are next carried forward to another period in the gospel dispensation; a period in which we ourselves are deeply and peculiarly interested; from which we date all the spiritual mercies and advantages, all "the means of grace and hopes of glory," which have been vouchsafed to our souls. "Then saith the king to his servants, the wedding (the wedding feast) is ready, but they which were bidden were not worthy." The Israelites who were honoured, as the people of God, with the first invitation and call to the gospel, shewed themselves unworthy of it, by their ungrateful and obstinate rejection. "Go ye therefore into the highways, and as many as ye shall find, bid to the marriage" feast: go ye, as we may interpret the words of our Lord, go ye, My ministers and messengers, into the world at large, and carry My invitation to the Gentiles; to as many as ye shall find; and proclaim to them that My table is spread for all: since the people, who were first bidden, have "not heard when I spake, nor answered, when I called," the "kingdom of heaven is now thrown open to all believers," so that "whosoever shall call upon the name of the Lord shall be saved:" My kingdom shall no longer be confined to one peculiar race; the time is come, when the blessedness of it shall be diffused abroad as "the waters cover the sea:" I am ready to "make a covenant with all flesh"—a covenant of peace—of benefits and mercies, such as their "eyes have never seen, nor ears heard;" the universal banquet is spread; bid them all to come. "So those servants went out into the highways, and gathered together all as many as they found, both bad and

good: and the wedding (table) was furnished with guests:" for it was not unusual, we must observe, in those countries, for men of the highest rank and distinction to admit to their tables, on remarkable occasions, persons of the lowest condition.

And this part of the parable also was representative of a future period; for though Christ had received homage from some in the Gentile world, and had signified His favour to others as well as the Jews, it could not be said, that the blessings of His gospel were at that time distinctly offered to the world at large. By St. Peter, in the first instance, in the case of Cornelius, and afterwards more fully by St. Paul, the Apostle of the Gentiles, were the good tidings universally announced and spread. This accords with the invitation in the parable, where we find that no exceptions were to be made: the "servants gathered together all, both bad and good;" thus, to men of all characters and descriptions the gospel was indiscriminately preached: the best greatly needed it; and even to the worst the door of grace and repentance was opened.

Doubtless, there are vast differences in the characters of unregenerate men, of the very heathen "who know not God." Some will use, more faithfully than others, the feebleness of natural religion; and thus arrive at a higher state of moral rectitude and respectability. But whatever comparative excellence any one may attain, in such a state, he is at best a polluted sinner: fallen from the favour and family of God; without the power to rise and return; the inheritor of sin and death, without the means of salvation. God must be reconciled, and the gate of mercy thrown open; or the sinner must perish. And it is for the offended God alone, to appoint the means of reconciliation; and proclaim the conditions of pardon and mercy. Jesus Christ, the eternal Son of God, is the only means of deliverance; by His incarnation and sacrifice has atonement been made for man; "there is no other name under heaven given among men, whereby we must be saved;" ^[242a] "other foundation can no man lay." ^[242b] The moralist must lay aside his vain pretensions, and humble himself at the foot of the cross; must come to the Saviour and learn of Him; come and be "baptised for the remission of sins;" come, that his character may be essentially changed by the Spirit and the word of God; that he may have new desires, new affections, new principles, new prospects: and many of "the children of this world," amiable in their disposition and reputable in their conduct, deceive

themselves in this matter; perceive not their need of a Saviour, “trusting in themselves that they are righteous;” good in their own eyes, good in the estimation of their neighbours, they undervalue and neglect the gospel; and therefore still continue “dead in trespasses and sins.”

But the bad as well as the good were gathered together; not only to those, whose conduct had been honourable among men, and whose characters were fair; but to notorious delinquent, yea, even to the worst of sinners, the door of the guest-chamber is open; all are invited; all, if they will comply with the conditions and rules of the feast, shall be fed; publicans and sinners, extortioners and unjust, disobedient and reprobate, all are the objects of the Saviour’s mercy; “Come unto me, all ye that are weary and heavy laden, and I will give you rest.” The invitation is free and universal; none who rightly seek admission, shall be excluded. This exactly agrees with the language of the evangelical prophet: “Ho, every one that thirsteth, come ye to the waters, and he that hath no money; come ye, buy and eat.” “Let the wicked forsake his way, and the unrighteous man his thoughts: and let him return unto the Lord, and He will have mercy upon him; and to our God, for He will abundantly pardon.” ^[243a] “The fountain is opened for sin and for cleanness;” ^[243b] “wash you, make you clean;” laden as ye are with iniquity come but to your Saviour, in sincerity and truth, with a contrite and repentant heart; come, as He has invited you; look to the all-sufficiency of His sacrifice; believe in Him for justification and life; be ready to learn of His example and to receive His spirit and His law into your heart, and you shall be admitted to His holy banquet, and be made welcome at His table; you shall find comfort in the presence of your Lord, and in them “that sit at meat with you.”

5. We are now led to the last and most striking part of this parable: the king came in to see the guests; to see whether they conducted themselves worthily of his entertainment, and appeared in the dress which he had provided, for such as were unable to furnish themselves. And thus, with regard to the heavenly feast, the guests are strictly and constantly accountable for their behaviour. Our blessed Lord watches the demeanour of all who profess to accept His invitation in the gospel; observes, how every one, who is “admitted into the fellowship of His religion,” fulfils the conditions required of him. Nor is it the external demeanour alone, which engages His notice and inspection; He sees through the innermost windings

of every heart, and will infallibly “judge righteous judgment.” No violation of His will, in thought, or word, or deed; no insincerity or deceitful appearance can possibly remain undetected.

“When the king came in—he saw there a man who had not on a wedding garment. And he said unto him, friend, how earnest thou in hither, not having a wedding garment?” The man could not pretend to offer an excuse: he knew the rules of the feast, and had wantonly neglected them; he was, like many other ungrateful people, regaling himself upon a benefactor’s bounty, but shewed him no respect or regard: being therefore self-condemned, “he was speechless.” Thus will it be with every negligent and disobedient Christian, when the Lord comes to make enquiry into his character: to justify himself, he will feel to be impossible; thoroughly has he known his Lord’s will, and full often has his conscience reproved him for not performing it: there will be nothing left for him, but unavailing sorrow and speechless remorse.

“Then said the king to the servants, bind him hand and foot; and take him away, and cast him into outer darkness, there shall be weeping and gnashing of teeth.” Cast him, from the lighted chamber, to the darkness of the night without, where he shall bitterly regret the pleasures he has so foolishly lost. Sad emblem of that state, whose sadness can be known, here upon earth, only by emblematical representation, only by such figures as “outer darkness,” as the “worm that never dies,” and “the fire that never shall be quenched;” a darkness of mind, in the utter regions of despair, without a ray from heaven to cheer it; the worm of anguish preying upon the soul; and a fire burning, whether without or within, or both; raging yet not consuming. God grant, that we may hear only of this wretched state “by, the hearing of the ear;” that our eyes may never behold it; that none of us may be consigned to this abode of unredeemed and unredeemable misery: and, that we never may, let us “walk worthy of our vocation;” of the Lord of that heavenly feast, of which we are professing to partake. Put on, my brethren, the wedding garment of the gospel; put it on, or intrude not into the presence-chamber of your Lord; dread the doom of the hypocrite and the despiser; pretend not to partake of the heavenly feast, to expect any of the blessings of the gospel, unless ye consent and seek to be clothed with the raiment provided by your King; with all those christian graces and virtues, which He will enable you to obtain.

If indeed it depended upon ourselves, “miserable and poor and naked” as we are, to provide a suitable covering; if the sinner were required to produce, from his own store, the raiment of holiness and righteousness, and thus make himself acceptable to his Saviour and his God; then would he have much reason to urge for his unworthiness and deficiency: for he has no means of making any such provision; he has not “wherewith he shall come before the Lord:” his heart is corrupt; his character is unholy; and he has no power to change them. But the provision does not depend upon ourselves; what the Lord commands us to be clothed with, He has mercifully prepared: He gives His Holy Spirit, to change the heart and reform the character; to enable us to “put off the old man with the deceitful lusts, and to put on the new man, which after God is created in righteousness and true holiness.” This spiritual clothing the Lord offers to all His followers; and woe be to those, who refuse or slight it: for this is a contempt of His divine mercy; a defiance of His authority and command: the expectation of His favour, on such terms, is adding insult to presumption. If we do make a profession of belonging to Him, let us not thus foolishly cast away our hope; let us not deceive ourselves by imagining, that we can possibly maintain a title to the privileges and blessings of the gospel, whilst we are living in the neglect of those ordinances and laws, which the Lord has graciously appointed as the means of our acceptance with Him. They who neglect the means, will assuredly lose the end; will be numbered among the despisers of their Saviour’s mercy.

And in order to keep alive in our minds that deep concern, which so momentous a subject demands, frequently let us be meditating upon that awful hour, when the King shall come in to visit and inspect His guests: His eye shall be upon every one, and every one’s eye upon Him; imagine yourself then in the guest-chamber without a wedding garment; ready and desirous to sink into the earth; but there will be nothing to cover your guilt and shame: though you have entered in with the other guests, and taken your station at the feast, you will be called out from among them, and everlastingly separated from the goodly company. A garment you would then, no doubt, most willingly accept; but it will be too late; it should have been accepted when offered; the season of grace will be past; the time for judgment will be come.

My brethren, you have professedly accepted the invitation of your Lord; you have entered into the guest-chamber; and if you be not already clothed with the spiritual apparel, provided by His grace and mercy, delay not an instant to apply for it: the King may come sooner than you expect; I pray that He come not, before you are ready to meet Him. And where is this garment to be found? Seek His Holy Spirit; search His Holy word: you will then not fail to find it, and He will dispose you to put it on. Repent and believe; love and obey: “cease to do evil, learn to do well;” thus “adorn the doctrine of God your Saviour in all things.” And then you will finally be admitted to the heavenly feast; to the marriage supper of the Lamb; to the company of angels; in the courts of uncreated light—“for the glory of God doth lighten them, and the Lamb is the light thereof;” [\[251a\]](#) “In whose presence is fulness of joy, and at whose right hand there are pleasures for evermore.” [\[251b\]](#)

SERMON XIV.
WALK WORTHY OF THE LORD, BE FRUITFUL, AND
INCREASING.

COL. i. 10.

That ye might walk worthy of the Lord unto all pleasing, being fruitful in every good work, and increasing in the knowledge of God.

ONE of the great objects of St. Paul, in writing his epistles, appears to be considerably overlooked by the christian world at large: it was, to lead those churches and communities, in which the true foundation of Christianity had been laid, to build upon it a corresponding character and life. Certainly, a great portion of the epistles is occupied in the assertion and explanation of christian doctrine; and this, principally, with a view to remove certain errors and prejudices, which the members of some churches had entertained; and upon which they had requested the apostle's decision. But well knowing how apt the human mind is to rest satisfied with speculative views and persuasions, he never omits to remind his converts, that much more was necessary than the profession of a true faith; that in vain would their opinions be rectified, unless their heart was also changed; that though they had "all faith and all knowledge," it would "profit them nothing," unless the graces and virtues of their holy religion were signally manifest in their lives.

There is scarcely an epistle, in which the apostle does not labour, with the most intense desire, with the most full and repeated and peremptory injunctions, to press upon them this momentous consideration: there is not, in the word of God, a more complete digest and code of christian duty, than in the writings of St. Paul; and yet they are, by many, almost exclusively regarded as an exposition of deep and mysterious doctrines; as if this were

the sole end and purpose for which they were composed. Well would it have been for the christian world, if as much attention had been paid to the practical, as to the theoretical subjects in these divine oracles: we should not then have witnessed so many disputations, in which charity has been lost sight of, nor so much of the “form of godliness without the power;” so many religious terms and denominations, of which the ignorant have understood little but the name: we should have had less of sect, of party, of invidious distinctions of any kind; and more of vital religion amongst us. But it is now, as it ever was, with fallen and degenerate man; he is fonder of exhibiting the powers of his understanding, of exciting his feelings, and of displaying the pride of spiritual knowledge, than of reforming his principles and regulating his conduct: he has therefore directed his view to the mystery of the foundation, and overlooked the directions for raising and completing the superstructure.

Not that the various revelations of doctrine, in the writings of St. Paul, are by any means to be lightly regarded; nor that they do not demand the most reverential attention and profound enquiry: it is of high importance for us to attain a “right judgment in all things:” yet doubtless it would tend more to the edification of Christians in general, if they took greater heed to the rules and precepts of the divine law, to the evidence and fruit of their faith; and to all that neglect them, we would say, “these things ought ye to have done, and not to leave the others undone.”

The passage of scripture, from which we are now discoursing, will exemplify these remarks. St. Paul, in the very opening of his epistle, assures the Colossians, that since the day he heard of their conversion, he did “not cease to pray for them and to desire that they might be filled with the knowledge of the will of God, in all wisdom and spiritual understanding; that they might walk worthy of the Lord unto all pleasing, being fruitful in every good work, and increasing in the knowledge of God.”

1. “That ye might walk worthy of the Lord.” It is scarcely possible for the most cursory observer not to perceive, that the faith of the gospel cannot be truly embraced with indifference; that the christian name is not a mere honorary or professional title, independent of obligations and of consequences. As the Bible is rich in promises, so is it also clear and

necessitating, in the conditions upon which those promises are made: as the Redeemer has freely offered unto us the benefits of His cross, so has He as plainly enjoined upon us the indispensable duty of “taking up our own cross daily,” and “following the blessed steps of His most holy life;” as He has reconciled us unto the Father, and again adopted us into the blessed family above, so are we required, if we have any part or lot in this matter, to behave as children, who have recovered the forfeited privileges of their glorious inheritance, and “have their conversation in heaven.” As we have been “bought at so great a price,” we must continue the subjects and the property of the “Lord that bought us.”

No man, whose nature, whose principles, whose affections, whose life, remain unchanged; no man, enthralled by the pleasures and devoted to the pursuits of a thoughtless and corrupt world, can justly consider himself as an actual partaker of the covenanted mercies of God. He may have been admitted by baptism into Christ’s visible church; he may hope to render, at some future day, his baptismal privilege available to salvation; but every page of God’s revealed word would forbid him to regard himself as an accepted “inheritor of the kingdom of heaven,” while his life is palpably at variance with the conditions upon which that inheritance is vouchsafed; while it is contradictory to the laws, and totally inconsistent with the blessings, which the Saviour has proclaimed to mankind. Every man must not only perceive from the gospel, but be assured by his own reason and conscience, that such divine mercies absolutely require and imply some degree of worthiness; some correspondence in his views, his temper, and his conduct.

Worthy indeed, in the fullest sense of the word, of such transcendent love and favour, of life and immortality, of everlasting honour in the presence of the pure and perfect Creator, the degenerate creature can never be; he has sinned; and “the wages of sin is death.” But there is a fitness, which the Christian, by divine help, must attain; a humility and contrition of heart; a sincere belief in God’s mercy through Christ; a grateful sense of God’s undeserved goodness; a desire of recovery from the ruin of his fallen nature; and withal, a true spirit of acquiescence in those means of grace, and that revealed law, ordained to bring the sinner to his Maker; and this conformity, in the character of man, is frequently represented in scripture by the name of *worthiness*: he becomes worthy in this respect, inasmuch as he

fulfils the conditions of the gospel covenant, and is thereby rendered a fit object of God's free mercy: without this character he would be unworthy, inasmuch as he would shew himself unmoved by the marvellous loving-kindness of his Saviour; would shew, that he had no real value for the blessings, which the gospel places within his reach; no regard for the revelation and ordinances of God. It is an observation as true as it is common, that the holy gospel designs not to save us *in* our sins, but *from* them; we must therefore be made willing and desirous and careful, to subdue the prevalence of sin, or we cannot attain unto salvation; and if the dominion of evil be subdued, there will grow up, in our hearts and lives, the manifold fruits of righteousness.

Such was the worthiness, which the apostle prayed and laboured to produce in the early disciples; and if, without this, we are hoping to be accepted of the Lord, "we are deceiving ourselves, and the truth is not in us." The meetness indeed, of which we are speaking, is not exclusively our own; it must "be wrought in us of God;" still it is to be sought by prayer, and improved with diligence: "We are not sufficient of ourselves to think any thing, as of ourselves; but our sufficiency is of God;" ^[260] yet God will not fail to supply us with the means, if we pray for them and use them faithfully.

To this statement I request your especial attention; because there are professing Christians, who take an improper view of this important matter. Conscious of their own unworthiness in point of *merit*, they are apt to overlook that worthy *fitness*, of heart and character and life, which is necessary for every sincere follower, of Christ. The proclamations of their own undeservings, and their Saviour's free love, are sometimes so loud and frequent, as to lower in their minds the sense of moral and spiritual obligation, as to make them relax in their duty to God and man; as if they were privileged to offend, because they extolled the Saviour, and debased themselves. This is a vain and a fanatical spirit: Christ alone is worthy to save; but we must endeavour, by His sanctifying aid, in all things to be made more and more worthy of the exceeding "riches of His grace."

2. And, in order to encourage us in the goodly work, the Almighty, whose happiness is infinite and incapable of increase, graciously represents Himself as *pleased*, even with our imperfect services: "That ye might walk

worthy of the Lord unto all pleasing.” “Though the heavens are not pure in His sight,” yet does He condescend to “visit man” with His favour, and “to regard the son of man,” who serveth Him, with an approving eye: He is pleased, because it is the fruit of the sinner’s reconciliation, by the death and sufferings of His beloved Son: for His sake, even the feeble struggles of the Christian, in the way of duty, if they be resolute and determined, are an acceptable service; even the spark of goodness, if it glow with sincerity in the bosom, is honoured and rewarded.

This is an animating consideration: we observe the effect naturally produced in the mind of man, even by the approbation of a fellow-creature, whom he regards as his superior; what holy satisfaction then, and complacency and delight, may we not derive from the persuasion, that our humble services are favourably viewed by the all-wise and almighty God, who recompenses every one according to his work: if God be pleased, whose displeasure shall we fear? If “God be for us, who shall be against us?” And O, that we may never forget, that it is one of the great purposes of the gospel, to render us, infirm and imperfect as we are, pleasing unto Him, through the merits and intercession of our Redeemer; by “walking worthy of the vocation wherewith we are called.” [\[262\]](#)

3. The apostle proceeds, in the text, to open and extend his view of evangelical righteousness. It consists not in that partial cultivation of spiritual affections, in that modified selection of particular duties, with which the christian world is so prone to be content: it obliges the believer to “be fruitful unto every good work.” This is a point, in which vast multitudes, in the christian church, lamentably and notoriously fail; in which many fail, who make a considerable profession of their zeal for religion; and comply, to a certain degree, with most of its obligations. There are some pleasures or pursuits, which, though they do not pretend to reconcile them with the law of God, they still perseveringly retain. Upon the whole, they professedly adopt the ordinances and requisitions of the gospel: but there are some more unpalatable than others; some to which they feel an unconquered repugnance: and these they leave out of their religious system altogether; to these they never so much as resolve to conform. And thus, they fail to manifest, (what is confessedly the most difficult, yet the most important of all christian attainments,) a surrender of the heart to God. Their own inclination, their own judgment, and not the

divine will, is the rule and standard of their conduct; and no doubt, if they felt this strong reluctance to the duties which they do perform, these also would be equally neglected: in other words, no part of their obedience rests upon a true foundation: it proceeds not from a sincere belief in the truth and authority of God's word. All the injunctions, all the precepts of the gospel are obligatory alike; all equally declarative of the divine will, and equally necessary to the spiritual renovation of man. And those injunctions and precepts, with which we are the least disposed to comply, do in fact require our peculiar attention and observance; because they point out to us the natural blemishes, which stand most in need of repair; because they shew where the greatest danger lies, of our being deficient in that complete change, of principle and affection and character, which the infallible word of truth has declared to be indispensable.

St. James assures us, that "whosoever shall keep the whole law, and yet offend in one point, he is guilty of all:" ^[265] he who reserves to himself any particular indulgence or pursuit, which is clearly at variance with the will and word of God, obeys not, in any thing, from a real christian motive; and shews himself ready, if a sufficient temptation were offered, to disobey in any and every point. It is true, that there is no "good work," which the Christian performs with uniform unvarying obedience; but neither is there any, in which he does not sincerely desire and endeavour "to be fruitful;" there is no act of righteousness, to which he is a stranger; no "besetting sin," which he is unwilling or unmindful to cast away: though the good fruit, to his sorrow, does too frequently fail, after all his unqualified labour; yet the unprofitable branch is pruned again, and watered by the tears of repentance, and fructified with the dews of heaven, and bears another day. He believes, and fears, and "loves the Lord his God with all his heart and all his soul and all his strength;" and therefore, though there are many imperfections, there is no reserve in his obedience.

4. The latter clause of the text directs us to a very distinguishing feature in the christian character: "Increasing in the knowledge of God." Knowledge must evidently here be taken, in a larger sense, to signify a lively comprehension of religious doctrines and duties, a practical understanding of the will and ways of God. In this knowledge it is absolutely essential that the true believer should be continually advancing: the objects of his faith are of such deep and overwhelming interest, that the longer they are

studied and pursued, the more they will, of necessity, captivate his thoughts and strike root into his heart: the more he seeks for the treasures in God's word, the more he will find: the more he knows of God, the more he will desire and delight to know: feeling the comfort and happiness of a reconciliation with his Maker, he is ever anxious to obtain a nearer and holier communion with Him; sensible of his absolute and entire dependence upon the Redeemer's mercy, he is ever leaning upon Him with new satisfaction, with a growing spirit of confidence and complacency; the more he thinks of heaven, the more "his affections are set on things above;" the more he thinks of the wretchedness of the rejected, the further he flies, in terror, from their dreadful abode. The consequence of all this must be, a progressive "victory over the world, the flesh, and the devil;" a daily improvement "in all virtue and godliness of living."

And there is yet another consideration; as we value and use the gracious gifts of God, they are increased and multiplied unto us; "whosoever hath, to him shall be given, and he shall have more abundance;" ^[267] the lamp shines brighter, that is to guide his feet; and his heart is ever quickened with fresh energy and zeal, by the influence of the Holy Spirit; thus he goeth on from grace to grace, from strength to strength, "from glory to glory."

The apostle, therefore, in praying that the converts might be increasing in the knowledge of God, is praying that they might have the invariable mark and earnest of a sincere and genuine faith. How little does this point seem to be considered! How many content themselves without any regular advancement, without any advancement at all; they cannot, after all the flattery with which they contrive to deceive themselves, be persuaded in their minds, that they grow decidedly better as they grow older: a year, perhaps many years ago, they were as religious, as fruitful in piety and good works, as they are now: no increase of spiritual knowledge, no new grace, no fresh habit of obedience, no additional exertions to mark the lapse of time; no passion subdued, no unholy pursuit abandoned, no vice mortified and forsaken. Wherever this is the case, the gospel has not been sincerely received into the heart; it has not been felt as the "power of God unto salvation;" it has not been, as it is designed to be, an effectual instrument of righteousness to the soul. To those, who remain in so careless and indifferent and unimproving a condition, we must say, that "our preaching has been vain, and their faith is also vain."

Possibly there may be some amongst us, who never yet bestowed an adequate attention on this important point; if any such there be, I would urgently exhort them, as they tender the salvation of their souls, to neglect this point no longer; deeply to enquire without delay, whether they “are growing in grace, and in the knowledge of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ.” ^[269] Let them enter with earnestness upon this necessary consideration; let it be frequently repeated: Is my faith increased and strengthened? Is my character more holy, my conduct more upright? Does my temper improve? Are my passions better regulated; my thoughts more spiritual; my devotions more pure and fervent; my affections more detached from the world, more fixed on God and heaven? My life and conversation, are they more accordant with the precepts and the example of my Saviour?

But the topics of enquiry are too numerous to be mentioned; I will only add, that the sincere believer sets the “prize of his high calling” continually before him; and advances to it, in holiness and righteousness, every day; keeps advancing till his race is run; and thus, when his toil is over, receives the crown of victory, and “enters into the joy of his Lord.”

SERMON XV.

THE WORD OF THE LORD PRECIOUS.

1 SAM. iii. 1.

The word of the Lord was precious in those days; there was no open vision.

FROM Moses to Samuel, a period of several hundred years, there was no prophet regularly appointed; particular revelations were made to individuals, and occasional messages from heaven were publicly delivered to the people; but there was no acknowledged prophet, to whom they might at all times resort, to know the mind and will of God; or, as it is described in the text, “there was no open vision.” The natural consequence was, that such intimations of the divine will, as were then given, made a deeper impression; they were more highly valued and more eagerly sought for, than when the gift of prophecy, in after ages, became more common. When the word of God abounded, it was received with indifference; when rarely vouchsafed, it was intently desired.

Such is perpetually, and on all occasions, the perverseness of man: blessings of every description are estimated, not according to their excellence, but their rarity; not according to the ease, but the difficulty, with which they are to be obtained. And further, when in possession of a blessing, we are often utterly insensible of its value; we abuse it in thoughtless excess, and are ready to squander it away; but the moment it is departed, we discover our blindness and folly; and would give, perhaps, all we have, to bring the treasure back again. Meat and drink and raiment, the air we breathe, the sun and the shower, excite no spirit of gratitude, and by many are scarcely received and remembered as blessings; but in the days of famine and of pestilence, amidst the warfare and desolation of raging elements, these benefits and mercies are painfully acknowledged, and ardently desired.

Again: the advantages of civil and religious liberty make little impression upon the hearts of those, by whom they are fully and uninterruptedly enjoyed: it is under the iron arm of intolerance and oppression; it is in the dungeon and the mine, that the excellency of these privileges is learned. And thus it is of domestic happiness and comfort: the value of home is frequently not appreciated, until it is forsaken and lost; the worth of a friend, even of the nearest relative, is sometimes but lightly considered, till he “goes hence and is no more seen.”

These observations are also illustrative of the feelings and conduct of men, in regard to their spiritual privileges and blessings. While the light of divine revelation is shining upon their dwellings, pointing out to them the way of salvation, and opening the prospect of a glorious immortality, they shut their eyes, and turn away into the fatal paths of sin and misery, to the darkness of eternal death; but when their opportunities are lost, when “the evil days are come upon them,” and there is no instructor or counsellor or comforter to be found, they perceive the preciousness of the time and the talents, which have been heedlessly thrown away; and would give the world, if they possessed it, for what they were once unwilling to make the smallest sacrifice.

We are apt to express a wonder at the obstinate indifference of the people of Israel to their religious advantages and instructions; we are astonished, that they could forget their miraculous deliverances by the hand of Moses, and the manifold revelations vouchsafed through him for their knowledge and guidance; and that almost every divine communication to them, in after ages, should have been but the forerunner of guilt and apostacy: yet in truth, the history of Israel is but too faithful a picture of the people of God in other times and other countries; by no means excluding our own. The word of God has not been accounted precious, in proportion to the extent to which it has been diffused; the Bible has not been, in too many instances, the most highly prized, where it has been most widely circulated; nor have the ministers of the gospel been always most attentively and devoutly heard, where they have increased and multiplied. Before the age of printing, when the copies of the sacred word were comparatively few, the Christian, who was so happy as to possess one, commonly regarded it as a treasure; or if he could obtain a part only, by the labours of the pen, even a gospel or an epistle, it was considered as a “pearl of great price.” And

afterwards, in the days of ignorance and persecution, when the sacred scriptures were withheld from the people by a blind and bigotted priesthood, the thirst for divine knowledge, for these streams of life and salvation, was inconceivably great; men sought them and treasured them at the peril of their lives. In these dark days, and long after, the public preachers of the word were few; and people flocked from distant quarters to hear the good tidings proclaimed. Having no regular supply of spiritual food, they sought it out with earnestness where they might; “the word of the Lord was precious in those days;” and “beautiful upon the mountains were the feet of Him,” who came to “lighten their darkness,” and to deliver the message of salvation to their souls.

How widely different from this is the case in our day. Copies of the Holy Scriptures are multiplied beyond all calculation: not a village, scarcely a dwelling, where they are not, or may not be procured: and, instead of any persecuting power, forbidding the use of them, every possible encouragement is afforded, and every means devised by which they may be adequately understood. And such, under the divine blessing, has been the success of those means, that the greater portion, even of the poorest in this favoured land, are able to discover for themselves the light of life; to apply it for their guidance and comfort and eternal salvation.

And with respect to the preaching of the gospel, though it is not yet sufficient for the demand of our extended population, still it may be truly described as general throughout the land. Although, for “the plenteous harvest, the labourers are too few,” still are they every where abroad. And if it be objected, that “the word of truth is not always rightly divided,” yet are there portions of it uniformly read, in every christian assembly, on the Lord’s day; and in our own incomparable Liturgy, no inconsiderable part of the divine word, of its saving doctrines and duties, is actually embodied.

So much for our holy congratulation, for the honour and glory of our land, for the rich abundance of spiritual privileges and blessings, which, under the favour of almighty goodness, we have the happiness to enjoy. It were well, if the sequel of our subject afforded equal ground for rejoicing; that it equally redounded to our honour. But here there is a dark cloud resting, which casts over the scene a melancholy gloom. The value set upon the word of God, its preciousness in the heart of man, is not proportioned to the

frequency and the fulness of its communication. It is in almost every dwelling, but not in every dwelling esteemed and loved; not devoutly treasured, not eagerly and diligently read, as it used to be in the days of scarcity. How many who possess it, perhaps superbly ornamented, in a variety of forms, and with goodly interpretations, seldom open it; seldom in comparison with its high and everlasting importance, for their enlightenment and edification: possibly it may be read on the Lord's day as a cold customary exercise, and by vast numbers not even on the Lord's day; they are positively unmindful of the sacred treasure, unconscious that it is so much as in their possession. No change of heart, no lively faith, no spiritual strength is derived from its exalted doctrines; no purification of the affections from its means of grace; no regulation of the life and character from its perfect law of righteousness. How should there be, when it is laid by, idly, carelessly, and contemptuously.

The Bible is grievously neglected both by rich and poor. The rich too seldom spare any of their abundant leisure, in storing their minds with the riches of heavenly wisdom; other books, of worldly interest or amusement, absorb almost their whole attention; an unimproving, nay injurious publication, the foolish dream of fiction, will be seized and read with avidity, whilst the oracles of eternal truth are treated with an indifference, that borders on disdain. The poor, it is true, have but little leisure; sufficient however, if that little were diligently used, to enable them to acquire a considerable knowledge of their Bible; but the great multitude of them seek their refreshment from other sources; from the pollutions of earthly pleasure. We might have expected better things: having fewer worldly possessions and comforts, it might be thought, that the poor would gladly supply such deficiency by the attainment of spiritual blessings; by raising their hopes and affections to the imperishable treasures of a brighter world to come: but it is too often found otherwise: the enjoyments of earth, however unsatisfactory and even debasing, are preferred to the abundant consolations and happiness of the gospel.

Thank God, there are many bright exceptions to these remarks, both amongst the rich and the poor; the number is great, and we hope increasing, of those to whom "the word of the Lord has been precious;" who have "received it with gladness;" who have "believed with the heart unto righteousness;" who "have seen the salvation of their God." But still, when

we cast our eyes upon the vast and reckless multitude, we are ready to weep over it and to say, O that ye would know, even ye in this your day, the things that belong unto your peace; before they be hid for ever from your eyes.

From this lamentable neglect of the word of God, we may readily account for the want of religious principle, for the decay of religious character, for the overspreading of corruption and vice, so notorious in the christian world. The astonishing circulation of the Bible through this country, of late years, might have reasonably led us to hope for a signal diminution of irreligion and crime. And God forbid, we should be of the number of those who maintain, that *no* such advantage has been derived from this dissemination of the word of life. But even the most sanguine person will not contend, that this holy exertion, this spiritual culture has produced a corresponding fruit: thousands of those, who have free access to the Bible, are lying, if not in utter darkness, at least in the shadow of death. And what is the cause? The scriptures are not valued in proportion to their extended circulation; they are not read with humble reverential attention, as the holy word of God; not understood or desired, as the fountain of light and life; not sought as a means of spiritual reformation and righteousness: and therefore, we may expect a greater prevalence of iniquity; as a judgment of the just and offended God, for so flagrant an abuse of the knowledge of salvation.

And thus with regard to the preaching of His word: where is that vehement desire, that deep interest, that holy concern to profit withal, which was observable in the days when preachers were few? We do not say, that it is utterly extinguished; but certainly not proportioned to the opportunities vouchsafed. How many in this our place and neighbourhood, refuse to travel, even the shortest distance, to hear the gospel; and of those who professedly go to hear it, not a few are led by mere curiosity or custom. How do we stand condemned by many a less favoured people! There are indeed lands, at this day, still thirsting for the knowledge of their God and Saviour; lands, to which it has but just been carried, where it is only beginning to be understood; and *there* the people will instantly repair at the very sound of the good tidings, and wait with eagerness upon the footsteps of the missionary, who bears in his hand the sacred treasure; but *here*, where the messengers are in every place, where the ministers of reconciliation abound, here are awful numbers, who never enter the house of God, for the

single purpose of hearing His word: the gift is continually offered, without trouble or risk, “without money or price;” and, therefore, it would seem, perversely despised.

Similar remarks may be made, concerning all those divine ordinances and means of grace, with which this privileged land has been so richly provided. The public worship of Almighty God, the holy sacraments of our Church, the instruction afforded to her children, the means of private devotion and godly advancement, all these are pressed upon the notice and acceptance of all; it is not enough to say, that we are invited; we are *urged* to the participation of these abundant blessings; yet how often are we urged in vain. At this moment, in some of our countries or dependencies abroad, where Churches are sparingly scattered, and the visits of ministers are few and long between, these divine ordinances are coveted with a painful anxiety, and no opportunity is ever lost: here, in the mother country, is the fountain of blessings, and the “streams are ever flowing withal;” but thousands esteem not these waters of life, and many never care to taste them.

It is impossible, that the truth of these observations can be denied; and to every sincere and serious Christian the subject must afford a painful reflection. And well does it become us all, each in our several vocations, to exert our utmost power for the abatement of so crying and alarming an evil. Many of us, I trust, are gratefully sensible of the goodness and love of God, in having so liberally bestowed upon our land the blessings of the word of life; grateful from the experience of its inestimable benefit to our own souls: let each then in his station, and according to his influence and ability, recommend the word to those around him; and assist in waking a slumbering people to a sense of the glorious opportunities awaiting them. Many, from their education and rank, have it in their power to contribute largely to the success of this glorious cause, to become instruments of righteousness and salvation to their lost fellow-creatures: and the poorest may do much in this blessed work; they may train their families in the study of the Bible, may lead them to adore the God of mercy and of truth, and to save their souls alive; considerable also is the impression, which, by prudence and friendly care, they might make upon their poor neighbours; bringing them to join together in happy union, for the perusal of that word, which is their common interest and hope; which would elevate them above

the troubles of a stormy world, would lead them to “lighten one another’s burdens,” and to “go on their way together rejoicing.” And, to say the least, every one has the power to recommend the holy scriptures by the light of his own example; by shewing, on all occasions, his love for the Saviour’s marvellous goodness; by duly reverencing and reading the word of truth; and manifesting the blessedness thereof, in the decided change of his own heart and temper, in his own character and life. And all such recommendations, let me add, the Lord is demanding at our hands, in return for His unspeakable mercy.

My brethren, let us suppose, that it should please God, for the heedlessness of this nation, to deprive us of the privilege and blessing of the Bible; and to declare, that the neglected ministry of His word should be continued no longer: we should undoubtedly regard this as the direst calamity, which could possibly befall us; we should immediately and cheerfully consent to any sacrifice, by which so dreadful a token of divine wrath might be averted. Then let us be consistent; and whilst we do enjoy this invaluable favour of heaven, let it be cherished and improved. Let the gospel, instead of being less precious to us, on account of its universal publication, and its facility of attainment, be therefore prized the more; and while we adore the Lord of mercy for diffusing this heavenly benefit through our dear and native land, let the treasure be laid up in our own bosom: what is intended for the good of all, is intended for the good of each: to bless God for giving the gospel to our country, and to undervalue or neglect it ourselves, is folly and hypocrisy; but too many individuals, amounting indeed to a large portion of our christian community, are guilty of this folly, and thus exposing the land to judgment, thus endangering “the ark of God.”

All of *us*, my brethren, do I trust feel thankful to our God and Saviour, who hath honoured us, unworthy as we are, with the revelation of His word, and hath “brought life and immortality to light:” whatever others then may do, let our sense of the gracious gift be undeniably and duly shewn: let us daily have recourse to this holy word, as “the lamp of our feet and the light of our paths:” be it our constant prayer for the spirit of God to open our eyes that we may understand, and our hearts that we may reverence, the wonders of His holy law; that it may be the object and study of our lives, to walk in all those means of grace, which it holds forth for our redemption from sin and death; for our safe passage through this transitory world of trial, to an

eternal world of happiness and glory beyond the grave. If we hear and read and mark and learn, in the spirit of devotion and prayer, we shall continually find new treasures of mercy opening to our view; new and unlooked-for stores of knowledge; new affections and dispositions; new hopes and prospects, in the promises of the blessed Jesus: the word will be a blessing to us through life and even to our journey's end; a sure guide amid the dangers of prosperity, a powerful support in the day of trouble, an inconceivable comfort when we die. But if we prize it not in life, how can we expect consolation from it in death? On the contrary, our spirits will be weighed down by the grievous remembrance of inexcusable neglect. Be wise in time; lay up in store the good foundation: the word, having been all along precious, will be increasing in value to the last; even until it leads us to the "open vision" of eternal day.

SERMON XVI.

DISTINCTIONS TO BE MADE ON THE DAY OF JUDGMENT.

MATT. xxiv. 40.

The one shall be taken and the other left.

IN the chapter before us, our blessed Lord is describing to His disciples various circumstances, which should attend the destruction of Jerusalem; an event, which has been generally regarded by the christian Church, as representative of the proceedings of that more awful day, when Christ shall appear at last to judge the universal world, “in righteousness and truth;” and “render unto every man according unto his works.”

Many false teachers had arisen, even in those early days of the gospel, pretending to set forth the signs of Christ’s coming to take vengeance on His enemies; and therefore the disciples had requested of their Master some certain information on this momentous topic: they “came unto Him privately, saying, Tell us, when shall these things be? and what shall be the sign of Thy coming and of the end of the world? And Jesus answered and said unto them, Take heed that no man deceive you: For many shall come in My name, saying, I am Christ, and shall deceive many. And ye shall hear of wars, and rumours of wars: see that ye be not troubled: for all these things must come to pass, but the end is not yet. For nation shall rise against nation, and kingdom against kingdom: and there shall be famines and pestilences, and earthquakes, in divers places. All these are the beginning of sorrows.” ^[291]

Our Lord proceeds to detail a great variety of other circumstances which should occur, some of them belonging to the desolations of Judea, some to the future judgment alone, and some to both these events; of which latter kind is the description connected with the text: “There shall be two in the

field; the one shall be taken and the other left. Two women shall be grinding at the mill; the one shall be taken and the other left:" that is, though destruction shall fall upon the Jewish nation at large, for their rebellion against God, their resistance to the clear evidence of the gospel, their shedding of the blood of His beloved Son, yet shall not all be equally involved in the same calamity and perdition. Divine providence will then make a distinction between those, who have obstinately rejected and maliciously persecuted the Saviour and His holy religion, and those, whose hearts have been opened to the reception "of the truth as it is in Jesus;" who, being convinced and converted, have become His faithful followers.

And though the whole race be so intermingled, one amongst another, by the various offices and duties and relations of life, that to the eye of man there may be no distinguishable difference amongst them; yet the all-seeing God, who "is a discernor of the thoughts of the heart," will not be misguided by any outward appearances; will perceive a very manifest difference in characters seemingly alike: will infallibly know whom to punish and whom to spare. As in the overthrow of Sodom and Gomorrah, He singled out, and selected for preservation, one righteous person, (and for his sake, a portion of his family also,) so, in the storm of vengeance about to fall upon the devoted city of Jerusalem, He would, in many signal instances, make the same merciful distinction. And the declaration, thus made, was calculated at once to comfort and encourage the faithful, and to alarm the conscience and check the presumption of the wicked.

The intimation here afforded of the perfect knowledge and the just discrimination of the Almighty, in regard to His judgments upon the Jewish people, applies with peculiar force and truth to His perfect dealings with all mankind, at the last great day. Although, when Jerusalem was destroyed, it is undoubtedly true, that the faithful disciples of Jesus were generally delivered, yet it cannot be supposed that, in so extensive an overthrow, all the Christians, and all their innocent children, without any exception escaped. But when Christ shall sit upon His throne of judgment, not one undeserved victim shall there be; and not one, who "has sinned against the light," shall escape with impunity. All those inequalities, which are unavoidable in the present constitution of things, shall then be made right and recompensed. The murdered innocent shall be requited with a robe of glory; and the prosperous sinner be abased with scorn and infamy.

How necessary, how indispensable, for the assertion and execution of divine justice, is the appointment of such a tribunal! How unequally are deserts distributed in this probationary world!—very often in cases, of which we ourselves may form an adequate opinion. Not unfrequently do we observe the righteous, doomed to extreme poverty and affliction and suffering; and though they be most graciously comforted and supported under their several burdens, we can hardly imagine, that such alleviation is all the requital they are to receive: and in truth, what is the principal source of their comfort and support? Is it not the hope of a happy termination? Is it not the prospect of entering into an everlasting rest, of being for ever delivered from sorrow and pain, in the presence of their Saviour and their God? And can we believe, that this blessed expectation, vouchsafed as the solace of their woes, will end in disappointment and nothingness? Does it not point to a day, in which their bright hopes will be more than realized in the merciful sentence of their Judge; in their reception, at His hands and through His merits, of “an eternal recompense of reward?”

And thus, on the contrary, frequently do we see the unprincipled and the profligate enjoying the favour of the world, and rising to no inconsiderable eminence of earthly prosperity: their crosses and vexations and troubles no doubt they have, as the natural fruit of irreligion and vice; as the retributive chastisement of an offended God; “sowing in corruption,” they do certainly more or less reap in sorrow; but still, if there were no other state, their lot would be, comparatively at least, much happier than they deserve; and therefore *their* condition also leads us to expect, and fearfully does it betoken, a day of fuller retribution; when the infinite justice and truth of God will be finally and perfectly vindicated.

Many cases, like these, of suffering virtue and prosperous vice, we are able clearly to discern: so broad are the lines, so prominent the features, that we can scarcely be mistaken: but perhaps there are many more cases, of which we can form no adequate opinion at all; neither in any instance, could we pretend to award or ascertain the exact degree of merit due to any individual. When we speak of merit, we do not mean to intimate that any action, in itself, is deserving of reward; we regard works of righteousness, only as the fruit of faith in a crucified Redeemer. But this fruit is much more abundant, and much more excellent, in some than others; and sometimes, when it makes the fairest shew, the quality is inferior. By merit

then, we here mean the faith and behaviour of a Christian; or, that behaviour by which the faith is manifested; that, to which God has freely promised a reward, for the sake of our great Redeemer. According to the faith, will the fruit be, both in quality and abundance; and according to the fruit will be the gracious reward; which reward He alone can determine and bestow, who discovers the secret springs of the character and conduct of every man living.

The value of an action depends upon the spirit and principle, with which it is performed; and of these things no one can perfectly judge, but the searcher of the heart. Even in the christian community, many words and deeds there are, obtaining applause from men, which will be condemned by the omniscient God, as having proceeded from unworthy motives, and being but the garb of hypocrisy; many persons there are, in whose respective demeanour we may be able to trace no very marked lines of difference, who yet differ most essentially, when measured by the scale of infinite truth and justice: all these secret distinctions will be clearly brought to light at the great inquiry on the judgment-day; every one will then appear in his true character; the veil of deception will be for ever torn aside; and of those, who seem alike to us in the present life, we shall find that one will be taken and another left; one taken to glory, and another left to shame and wretchedness and ruin.

It may be useful to mention a few instances, in which we may be deceived in our comparative estimate of men. Even with regard to the fundamental principles of religion, to a real belief in the truths of the Bible, to the essentials of a christian character, it is possible that we may form very mistaken opinions concerning many around us. It is true, that insincerity and deceit are commonly, sooner or later, in some degree detected; it is difficult to be always dissimulating, and acting a part; some evil fruit, some inconsistency does generally betray the hollowness of hypocritical pretensions: still however, it is not always so; and doubtless there are some,—out of the number of those persons, whom we are in the habit of considering as equally resting their hopes upon the true foundation, equally believing in Jesus Christ for pardon and salvation, equally zealous in the maintenance of His holy religion and attentive to the ordinances,—some there are, who differ materially from others, in the unerring judgment of God. They may repair to the same place of worship, perhaps with the same

degree of regularity, but with very different views and impressions: we can judge only of the outward appearance, of the posture of the body or the moving of the lips; it is for the Lord to look upon the posture of the soul and the offering of the heart. Many, no question, come to the House of God from very unworthy motives and for very unworthy purposes; and frequently they do not escape the observance of *man*; but *man* cannot penetrate into the case of every individual; to the eye of Jehovah alone are “all things naked and open;” He sees and judges, *who* come unto Him in humble faith; *who* approach His tabernacle is a pious frame and temper, with holy affections, with integrity of heart; *who* “worship Him in spirit and in truth.” My brethren, it is an awful consideration: but from the same Church, the same christian society, the same assembly of worshippers, “one shall be taken and another left.”

Again, with respect to a discharge of the ordinary duties of life, there may be much real, though little seeming difference, in the characters of many, with whom we are daily acquainted. Punctuality and diligence, though always commendable and useful for the public good, may be, in as far as the person himself is concerned, of little value in the sight of God; our acceptableness with God, in this matter, depends upon the principle and the view and the spirit, with which the business of life is conducted: it may be carried on merely for the sake of self-interest; of gain, reputation, and pleasure; without any religious feeling or purpose whatever, without a single prayer offered up for heavenly assistance and blessing, without a word of thanksgiving or acknowledgment: or, on the other hand, we may proceed to our daily employments and pursuits, “strong in the Lord and in the power of His might;” imploring and depending upon His grace; “doing whatever we do for His glory;” active and diligent and faithful, from a sense of love and duty to Him, for the sake of obeying the law of our blessed Redeemer, and thus bringing forth the fruit of faith unto perfection; “living soberly, righteously and godly in this *present* world,” [\[302a\]](#) with the continual hope and expectation of a glorious world to come. Now, whether industry be the work of religious principle, or whether it arise merely from selfish and earthly views, we are often unable to decide: but God knoweth all the thoughts of man; and therefore can assign, to every action and habit and pursuit, its true origin and its due reward; and many persons, it will be found at last, who have gone forth together unto their labour, who have

been engaged in the same occupations, have toiled together as companions in life, will be separated when the day of full inquiry comes; the one, having “sown unto the spirit,” shall be *taken* to enjoy the fruit of life everlasting; the other, having “sown unto the flesh,” shall be *left* to “reap corruption.” [\[302b\]](#)

Similar observations will of course hold good, with regard to the practice of particular virtues. They, “who give alms only to be seen of men;” who dispense their bounty from any other principle, than that of love to their Saviour; for any other purpose, than to serve God and to benefit their fellow-creatures; they “*have* their reward” already—the only reward, which they are caring to seek—the applause, the good will, or the esteem of mankind: and they must not expect, on the latter day, the reward which they seek not; the approval of their sovereign Lord; the praises and blessings of christian charity. Again, they who exercise the virtues of honesty or sobriety, merely for the sake of worldly expedience or reputation, will likewise “have their reward” all the reward they are to expect, in this life. Christian faith and christian principle are the only foundations, upon which a Christian can surely and successfully build; they, who build upon them, will be taken to see the goodly fabric perfected in heaven; whilst every work, which is raised upon “other foundation,” will be left to desolation and devouring fire.

And even they, who have communed together, through their earthly pilgrimage, in the bonds of familiar intimacy; who have been united all their lives long, by the nearest and dearest ties of kindred; even they will be subject to the same discriminating judgment at the last. If they have been bound together in the holy bonds of the gospel, as well as of family affection; if they have been faithful brethren in the Lord, as well as in the flesh, “walking with God as friends,” it will be well; then, as they “were lovely and pleasant in their lives, in their deaths they shall not be divided:” [\[304\]](#) together shall they go to heaven, and be admitted to enjoy a more delightful communion with each other, in the happy paradise above. But if it be otherwise, if such friends be of opposite characters; the one “carnally” the other “spiritually minded;” then, their ends must be opposite also; “death” is the portion of one, “life and peace” [\[305a\]](#) of the other: their union therefore must be dissolved. The world may regard all the members of a family, as nearly alike in character; but the difference may nevertheless be

great; and the distinction, in another world, will be great also. The wicked parent shall see its innocent offspring no more; the pious father shall not deliver the undutiful child, nor the obedient child its rebellious father; ^[305b] each can save but his own soul. How feelingly and powerfully does this consideration appeal to christian families; admonishing them, to regard not the present only, but the everlasting welfare of each other; to “edify one another” in holiness and godly love; lest, after they have been so intimately connected together upon earth, while the one is taken to felicity and glory, the other be left to “mourning, lamentation and woe.”

How are christian parents bound, to watch over the offspring they so tenderly love! Watch they do, with continual anxiety, for the temporal benefit of their children, for all that can minister to their comfort and honour and advancement in life: they rejoice in the joy of their children, and weep when their children weep: but O how infinitely more important is the provision for eternity: earthly ties will soon be broken; how important, that we should provide for a happy renewal of intercourse and love hereafter! Parting now, to meet no more, were enough to break the heart; but the bright prospect of a re-union in paradise consoles and reconciles; forbidding us “to sorrow as those who have no hope.” See then, ye christian parents, to the nurture and training of the “olive branches round about your table;” bestow, upon their spiritual well-being, an especial and exceeding care; that ye may behold them “flourishing in the house of the Lord” above: that, whether ye be taken from them, or they from you, there may be comfort in the parting. See, all christian relatives and friends, by whatever name ye are endeared; see that ye live not in worldly, but heavenly affection: instructing, admonishing, animating one another in the profession of the true faith and the exercise of all godliness; that so your converse and communion may never be embittered by the fear of eternal separation.

Lastly, let the truth, here declared by the infallible word of God, check the presumption of the careless and the wicked; and give comfort and encouragement to the faithful. The worldling may fancy, because no great distinction, between him and others, is made upon earth; because he perhaps can see no great reason for such distinction; that, therefore, he shall escape in the end; but in the day when “God will judge the secrets of men by Jesus Christ,” ^[307] when “every one shall receive the things done in his

body, according to that he hath done, whether it be good or bad,” ^[308] he will find, that an immeasurable distinction will be made between him “that hath served God, and him that hath served him not;” between him, whose heart has been given to his Creator and Redeemer, and sanctified by the Spirit of grace, and him, who has only made it his object to maintain a decent appearance in the world. If we do believe in the final judgment, if we believe in the perfect truth and justice of the Almighty, we must conclude, that this fearful difference will be made. And if it were so dreadful a calamity, to be left to fall in the tremendous overthrow of Jerusalem, what will it be, to be left an everlasting-prey to the tortures of Satan and of sin?

But let the true believer, the righteous servant of God in Jesus Christ, take encouragement and comfort: there is no exercise of faith, no holy meditation, no fervent prayer, no religious deed, no pious intention or design, however secret from the eyes of men, which can escape the notice of their heavenly Father: though justice is not, cannot be, done to their characters here; though sometimes the greatest injustice and injury and wrong; yet shall they be triumphantly and gloriously vindicated at the last: though they be on earth forsaken or oppressed, though they bear the burden of private affliction or public scorn, in a “world which is not worthy of them,” they shall be visited and acknowledged and received at the last; shall lift up their heads with honour and with joy, and be admitted into a kingdom, which is more than worthy of all their faith and all their constancy; the Redeemer has marked them for His own; He will single them out, on the last day, from the crowd of countless multitudes, as objects of his compassion and favour; will take them into the arms of His mercy, and so “they shall be forever with the Lord.” ^[309]

SERMON XVII.
GOD MADE MAN UPRIGHT; MAN MAKES HIMSELF
MISERABLE.

ECCLES. vii. 29.

Lo, this only have I found, that God hath made man upright, but they have sought out many inventions.

IN this remarkable book, Solomon discusses the various earthly means employed by the human race, for the attainment of happiness; and he decides upon the utter insufficiency of them all. Nor is he to be regarded as making the enquiry from mere matter of speculation, but as declaring to the world the result of his own experience, as well as the counsels of the Most High. Exalted to the very summit of worldly prosperity and greatness, and learned in all the arts and sciences, he possessed advantages, in the pursuit of happiness, far beyond the common lot of mortality; if it were to be found upon earth, he would have been sure, in himself or some of his favoured dependents, to have made the discovery. But he declares, by many remarkable repetitions, his utter inability so to do; he gives up the matter as hopeless and impossible; “all, (even the fairest and the best of human schemes,) is vanity and vexation of spirit;” “that which is crooked cannot be made straight, and that which is wanting cannot be numbered.” ^[311]

And this conclusion corresponds with the experience of mankind in every age: happiness has always been their object; philosophers have laid down rules for its acquirement, and every variety of expedient has been tried; but all in vain; there is no permanent pleasure or satisfaction upon earth: independently of the crosses and vexations from without, by which it is so continually disturbed, there is something in the constitution of man, in the

present state of his mind and heart and affections, by which the attainment of happiness, from temporal means alone, is positively forbidden.

The royal preacher, thus convinced of this truth, turns his thoughts to a solution of the case, and sums up his observations, on the conduct and condition of man, in the words of the text. Instead of arraigning, like some bold and impious cavillers of our day, the wisdom or goodness of the Creator in the introduction of evil into the world, he gives the true account of the matter; and lays the blame where alone it is due, upon the disobedience and degeneracy of man. And in so doing, he bears testimony to the truth of one of the most important communications made to us in the revealed word of God—the original innocence and the fall of our first parents. This fact has been daringly called in question by certain professed believers of divine revelation, by some who boast themselves peculiarly entitled to the christian name. Anxious to exalt the moral excellency of human nature, and to disprove the doctrine and necessity of the atonement, through the prevailing efficacy of the Saviour's incarnation and sufferings, such vain disputers absolutely deny, in the very face of God's word, that any such total and dreadful change has ever taken place in the state of mankind; they contend, that our understandings and affections are now the same, as when we came originally from the hands of our Creator. It appears, however, that the *wisest* of men took a different view of this momentous subject; that he received the Mosaic account, recorded in the opening of the book of Genesis, according to its plain and natural interpretation; and he has delivered to us his judgment, by the inspiration of that Holy Spirit, under whose guidance it was impossible for him to err.

Solomon introduces his declaration upon this point in a very awakening manner; in a manner frequent with the inspired writers, when about to deliver a sentence of peculiar weight and importance; “Lo, this only have I found;” behold, attend to this truth; this is the result of my observations, this the “conclusion of the whole matter,” this the explanation of all the evil and unhappiness in the world, that “God hath made man upright, but they have sought out many inventions;” that man was created innocent by the wise and merciful Author of his being; formed for pure unalloyed enjoyment; and the marring and misery, which he experiences, are solely attributable to the change induced by his own apostacy and rebellion; to his seeking out ways and means of happiness, contrary to the will and appointment of his

Creator. “God saw every thing that He had made, and behold, it was very good;” ^[314] and man, the lord of creation, was not less fitted than the objects around him, to answer the good and gracious purposes of heaven. So God “created man in His own image; in the image of God created He him; male and female created He them;” ^[315] in the image of holiness, and therefore happy.

How far man has fallen from this state of uprightness, is a question which has caused much difference and contention in the christian world; some persons, from a desire of exalting the free grace of God, declare that the divine image in man was totally corrupted and lost by the fall; that there remains, in his unregenerate nature, no spirit or particle of excellency, no perception of what is good; that his nature is a mere chaos of disorder, a mass of decay, which is altogether incapable of producing any thing but “confusion and every evil work.” On the other hand, it is contended, that the wreck of man’s nature was but partial; that there remains a considerable disposition to practice, as well as approve, “whatsoever things are pure and honest and lovely and of good report;” that man is still able, by his own judgment and strength, in many things to please God and to serve Him. It does not fall within our purpose, on the present occasion, to attempt any accurate adjustment of this difference; but we may observe, that it is dangerous to insist upon either extreme. A belief, that man can will or do nothing, is apt to lead to a persuasion that he has nothing to will or do; that his salvation is a work totally independent of himself; a measure of grace absolutely forced upon him: and a belief, is that man able of himself to “refuse the evil and to choose the good,” that he “knows how to walk and to please God,” creates a spirit of self-righteousness, at once destructive of the sinner’s hope; preventing his dependence upon the all-sufficiency of God, and subversive of the truth of the gospel.

A faculty of discernment between good and evil, for the moral government of man, is evidently vouchsafed to his unrenewed nature; and a power, in dependence upon the divine teaching, to accept or reject the proposals of mercy and grace, does surely remain to us, or else the numberless exhortations of God to the sinner appear to be of no benefit and no meaning: and who can reasonably suppose, that sinners would have been so frequently and severely condemned, for refusing that grace, which they were positively incapable of accepting. The language of our ninth Article

on this point appears to be most temperate and unobjectionable: “Man is very *far gone* from original righteousness, and is of his own nature inclined to evil, so that the flesh lusteth always contrary to the spirit.” With this statement we may rest content.

One of the many bitter fruits of the fall is, that man no longer seeks his happiness in God, where alone it can be found, but in ways of his own devising, in the crooked ways opened to his view and imagination by the destructive enemy of his soul; no longer in innocence and holiness and obedience, but in vicious inclinations and pursuits, “in the lust of the flesh and the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life;” [\[317\]](#) in those very principles and means, which brought “death into the world and all our woe:” it is no wonder, therefore, that happiness, from a search like this, should not be found. They, who search in this manner, are like the wicked spirit, “walking through dry places, seeking rest and finding none;” like the dove of Noah, in the overwhelming of the waters, roving about on weary wing, and finding no resting place for the sole of her foot. Nor is it possible for man to be blessed again with perfect peace, peace without any interruption or alloy, until he be altogether restored to “the image of Him that created him:” the nearer he approaches to that restoration, the more he will assuredly possess of true satisfaction and delight; but the blessing can never be complete, till the original defilement be utterly purged away, till his understanding is enlarged for a full knowledge of the good and great and glorious Creator; till he can be brought to love and serve Him without any mixture of infirmity; till he returns not only to His favour, but into His immediate presence, in the second Eden, of eternal bliss.

Still may man enjoy, even upon earth, no inconsiderable degree of peace and happiness. The promises and blessings of the gospel impart a “joy and gladness” to the believer, and fill him with comfort, which the world can neither give nor take away: the avoiding and abhorring of evil will prevent those painful reflections, which inhabit the mind of the reckless sinner: the life of faith in a merciful Saviour, the worship and service of God, the works of piety and love, the walk of uprightness and integrity, though accompanied with imperfections, and, therefore, with abatements of comfort, yet do infallibly produce a great tranquillity of soul, and unspeakable emotions of holy joy; the sincere Christian contemplates his present condition with happy, though humble persuasion of acceptance with

his God; and looks forward with an animated exulting hope of the perfect consummation of his felicity, in another and a better world. The trials and troubles of this life do indeed still continue; yet they have no power to harm, and therefore none to distress him; he “casts his burden upon the Lord.” But in the natural, unrenewed, unconverted world, there is no such redeeming principle, no qualification of evil, no pure sources of delight: let the votaries of earthly enjoyment seek it with what ardour and devotedness they may, it is a phantom which is ever eluding their grasp; flitting before their eyes in the shape of promises and visions, but never in substantial possession.

It is indeed sadly instructive, to consider the numberless devices to which men are driven, in their search after happiness, when once they have forsaken the faith and fear of God; how busy they are in the invention of new scenes and pursuits; quitting one after another, as each deceives and fails; how they are wearing and wasting away the little span of life, in vain experiment and profitless enquiry. How are the opulent contriving their multiplied means and opportunities of enjoyment, with all their splendour of establishment, and a train of dependents obedient to their will! And if we could form a judgment by outward appearances, we might be inclined to pronounce them happy: but under this beautiful veil, with all this pomp of circumstance, many a corroding care, many a mortified desire, many a bitter disappointment, lie constantly concealed.

To envy the rich, as if they were the certain possessors of comfort and ease, is one of the greatest of all mistakes and follies; happiness must dwell in the mind and the heart; it must depend altogether upon the state of mind and heart; it is not to be purchased with money; money, we must grant, may be made to minister to it, but this must entirely depend upon the disposition, the spirit, the manner, in which it is used: the smallest pittance upon earth, possessed in the faith of the gospel, in the fear and love of God, produces infinitely more enjoyment, than the countless treasures of those, who seek or spend or save them, with a view to themselves and this world alone.

Some are revelling in the dreams of ambition; and imagine, that if they could attain a particular eminence, they should be happy: but the road is steep and slippery, toilsome and dangerous; and the summit, if ever they reach it, is not a land of repose, not the habitation of contentment and

peace; “seekest thou great things for thyself? seek them not.” ^[322] Ambition is always dissatisfied; if not the most unclean, it is one of the most tormenting spirits in the bosom of man; and yet it is fondly and generally cherished both by rich and poor. Be humble; be moderate; be content; if thou wouldest be happy.

In what are called the pleasurable scenes of life, it is unnecessary for me further to insist, how vainly we rove in quest of substantial delight: this indeed is a truth still more level to the experience of us all; it is a path we have often trodden, but never I think with satisfaction. Witness the continual changing, the endless variety of amusements, which are found necessary in order to relieve satiety and disgust, necessary even when they are innocent; and in sinful pleasures, in lust and intemperance of every kind, it is needless to tell you, there can be no peace; health is impaired and the conscience is burdened; they are like a two-edged sword, cutting on both sides, destroying both body and soul.

The force of these arguments may be made to appear from another consideration; for whatever delusions may be practised upon men, to induce them to reckon and build upon earth alone; to trust for happiness to their own inventions, to human schemes and devices; yet will they never, in their serious moments, contend for the wisdom of their choice; or say, that their expectations have been answered; they will never, when they come to die, recommend to their friends, assembled round their bed, the course which they pursued, as a sure foundation of comfort in their lives, and peace in their latter end; the dying father will not recommend it to his children, nor the dying brother to his brethren. No: it will then be seen, either by the tears of bitter remorse or the agonies of unrepented guilt, that the way of the world was “the broad way that leadeth unto destruction;” that the soul can never find rest, till it returns to the forsaken paths of righteousness, to the lost image of its God.

And thanks to the unspeakable mercy of God in Christ Jesus, the way of recovery is abundantly made known; the kingdom of heaven, with all its joys and treasures, is opened to every believer. Wisdom has come down from above, to tabernacle with sinful man; to lighten his darkness, and to rejoice his soul; and “*her* ways are ways of pleasantness, and all her paths are peace”—pleasantness and peace to those, who seek them with their

whole heart, implicitly and devotedly, as manifested in the gracious revelation of their God.

But unhappily, in the way of religion also, in their professed walk of faith, men will be seeking out many inventions of their own, instead of submitting themselves, with simplicity and godly sincerity, to the gospel of Jesus Christ. They are seeking to accommodate His divine law to their corrupt inclinations and indulgences, to the maxims and fashions and interests of an ensnaring world: and thus they fail of the happiness, which they were led to expect. No wonder, that they find not the christian promises realised; that they fall short of the comfort, as they do of the obedience of faith. To the believing in our crucified Lord, with all the heart and soul; to “the seeking first His kingdom and His righteousness;” to the “forsaking all and following Him;” to “the spirit of God dwelling in us, and mortifying the deeds of the body;” to the sincere desire after holiness “as He is holy;” to “the fulfilling of the law of righteousness;” to a living hope of “the inheritance that fadeth not away”—to these things, the promise of life is made; of joy and favour here, and eternal felicity hereafter; but if we, in dependence upon our own vain inventions, seek to be blessed in any other way; with a less entire belief, and a less holy profession, and a less devoted obedience, and a less exalted hope, we must not complain or wonder, if we lose our object and aim; “Be not deceived, God is not mocked; for whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap; he that soweth unto the flesh, shall of the flesh reap corruption; but he that soweth unto the spirit, shall of the spirit reap life everlasting.”

The merciful God, when He created man innocent and happy, graciously revealed to him the means, by which his innocence and happiness might be preserved; and shewed thereby, that they were inseparable, that the loss of the one would be the loss of the other. “The Lord God commanded the man, saying, Of every tree of the garden thou mayest freely eat: but of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, thou shalt not eat of it; for in the day that thou eatest thereof thou shalt surely die.” [\[327a\]](#) And no sooner had Adam disobeyed, no sooner was his innocence forfeited, than his happiness was gone; he found to his sorrow, as he would not believe to his comfort, the truth of his Creator’s word: and thus miserably ended the first covenant of God with man, the covenant of obedience and works.

Under the covenant of grace, by the blessed and eternal Son of God, it is revealed to us, with equal clearness, how the lost happiness of man is to be recovered; “the way we know:” “Believe in the Lord Jesus Christ and thou shalt be saved;” [\[327b\]](#) “set your affections on things above, not on things on the earth:” [\[327c\]](#) this is the way, call it by what name you please—a condition, or a means; it is the only way: happiness, here or hereafter, is attainable in no other. For this, we have the assurance of that word, which we have seen, under the first covenant, awfully fulfilled; of that word, which can never fail. My brethren, I cannot doubt, that we are all of us convinced of this truth: then let us pray fervently and faithfully, that the conviction may live in our hearts; that we may, from this day forward, go to “the fountain of living waters, and not hew out for ourselves broken cisterns, that hold no water;” [\[328a\]](#) that we may renounce the vanity of all human inventions, and seek our happiness in God, and God alone. “Be not conformed to this world; but be ye transformed by the renewing of your mind; that ye may prove, what is that good and acceptable and perfect will of God:” [\[328b\]](#) that ye may “have your fruit unto holiness, and the end everlasting life.” [\[328c\]](#)

SERMON XVIII.

THE KNOWLEDGE OF GOD REVEALED TO THEM THAT FEAR HIM.

PSALM XXV. 14.

The secret of the Lord is with them that fear Him; and He will shew them His covenant.

THE secret of the Lord means, that which cannot be known unless the Lord reveal it; and the phrase here implies, an intimate knowledge of the divine perfections, of the dealings and dispensations of God; a holy and vital communion with Him; an entire trust in His providential care and government; together with that peace, which always dwells in the bosom of a true, penitent, pious believer. All this, including, as it does, a full acquaintance with the doctrines and duties, the privileges and comforts of the life of faith, is called “the secret of the Lord,” because it is hidden from the natural man, and cannot possibly be comprehended or discovered without divine revelation.

Such knowledge and such blessings are not the growth of earth; they are not the produce of the human intellect or the human heart; they must come by spiritual communication, from the fountain of wisdom and truth. When man was driven from the bright abode of paradise, his understanding was darkened; losing the favour, he lost the image of his Maker, and thus became naturally estranged from those holy thoughts and affections, which constitute his chief happiness and glory. Nor is it possible for him to recover this spiritual frame of mind, these heavenly views, this holy and happy acquaintance with God, unless the hand, by which the image was originally stamped, repair the wretched ruin in which it now lies. Whoever would know the ways of God, must be taught of God; to all, who are not so

taught, they are impenetrably secret. Thus spake the wisest of men; “The Lord giveth wisdom, out of His mouth cometh knowledge and understanding. Then shalt thou understand righteousness and judgment and equity; yea, every good path.” ^[331a] And thus the apostle, “Eye hath not seen, nor ear heard, neither have entered into the heart of man the things which God hath prepared for them that love Him;” ^[331b] that is, man, in his natural state, of ignorance and rebellion against God, cannot form a notion of the value of heavenly blessings; of the enlarged views, the sublimed affections, the sustaining comforts and joys, attainable by an inheritance of the divine promises, both here and hereafter. But, as the apostle proceeds, “God hath revealed them unto us by His Spirit; for the Spirit searcheth all things, yea the deep things of God. For what man knoweth the things of a man, save the spirit of a man which is in him; even so the things of God knoweth no man, but the Spirit of God;” as we exercise our thoughts and judgment upon human matters, by the help of human reason, by the natural powers of the mind, so must we attain the knowledge of divine matters, by the aid of a divine spirit; by a holy illumination and guidance; not indeed by miraculous illapses, but still by the distinct and actual operation of heavenly grace, silently producing its effects upon the understanding and heart.

The pride of man, the disputer of this world, does not submit to this proposition and teaching; perhaps commonly regards them in the light of enthusiasm; he has no notion, that there are any secrets in religion, which his own skill and judgment are not sufficient to reveal; he disbelieves every thing, which he cannot comprehend or feel; and affects to throw a shade of discredit and contempt upon all those religious sentiments and affections, to which he is a stranger. There are not a few such persons in the christian world; who profess to believe all the doctrines of the Bible, and to know all that need or can be known, and yet never submit themselves to, scarcely can be said to pray for or desire, the aid and direction of Almighty God; who imagine, that their liberal education and their common sense entitle them to pass a full and adequate judgment upon all spiritual subjects; and to form a correct notion of all spiritual privileges and blessings.

This is a dangerous and fatal error; a most unfounded presumption; a gross ignorance of the very element and nature of evangelical truth: such persons only judge of the word of God, of the ordinances and benefits of religion, as they would judge of any mere human history; of any worldly occurrence or

advantage: they take, what they are pleased to call, a rational view of Christianity; but the only view, which deserves the name of rational, is, not that which appeals to reason alone, but that which is according to truth; according to the acknowledged revelation of God's sovereign will. Let us again hear the apostle: "Which things also we speak, not in the words which man's wisdom teacheth, but which the Holy Ghost teacheth.—But the natural man receiveth not the things of the Spirit of God, for they are foolishness unto him, neither can he know them, because they are spiritually discerned." ^[334] The merely rational man, therefore, is a carnal man; not indeed an absolute stranger to the word of grace, but unenlightened by it; he has no true taste for holy and divine things; it is altogether impossible for him to appreciate their merits, or to know any thing of their practical effects.

A familiar instance or two may serve to illustrate this truth. How can any man, who neglects the worship of God, pretend to decide upon its importance and utility? How can he presume to deny its comfortable and salutary influence upon the soul, its powerful efficacy upon the character and life? It is a matter of experience; of which he therefore is unqualified to judge.—He that is a stranger to the grace of God in his heart, may despise those, that regard it and live by it, as fanatical persons, who are deluded by visionary ideas and groundless assurances: but he is only judging others by himself; and it would be marvellous indeed, if he, who is avowedly living without the influence of divine grace, should bear witness to the benefit and happiness which it confers.—What can the intemperate man know of the blessings of temperance? Nothing: except by the want of them.—What can the covetous man know of the pleasures of benevolence and liberality?—the licentious of the excellence of purity, or the ignorant of the treasures of wisdom?—Because the sinner, when overtaken by sickness or affliction, declares that he derives no comfort from religion, are we therefore to conclude, that religion has no comforts at all? Could we think it probable, that the promises of the gospel would afford consolation to him, in an evil hour, when he had all along been an alien to their nature, when they had been unheeded or despised?

It is quite clear, that the benefits and blessings of our holy religion, that the knowledge of God's word, the power of His Spirit, and the effects of His ordinances, must ever remain a secret to those, who have no intercourse

with these things, and set their hearts against them. And whenever the Christian hears his conduct condemned, or his hopes undervalued, by such persons, he may treat them, not with proud disdain, but with a holy disregard: whatever their station in society may be, whatever their learning, whatever their reputation for judgment in worldly affairs, upon spiritual or scriptural matters their opinion is of no weight or worth.

“The secret of the Lord is with them that fear Him.” The fear of the Lord, in this passage, as in many others of Holy writ, denotes the sum and substance of religion; it implies a sincere faith and trust in God, an awful sense of His majesty, an humble and anxious enquiry after the knowledge of His will, with a holy determination of obedience. And, in addressing these words to a christian congregation, we may understand them as implying that fear and service of God, which proceed from a vital belief in the whole of His revealed law, in the gospel of His ever blessed Son, our supreme Lawgiver and King; as implying moreover an entire concurrence in all the measures ordained for our salvation. The fear of God, though common to all believers under every divine dispensation, will vary in its operation and extent, according to the nature and fulness of their dispensation; it will lead them to believe and love and obey, according to their knowledge, to their opportunities and means of grace, and therefore the believer in the gospel shews the working of this holy principle in the full bearing of evangelical fruit.

All who so believe and live, shall have the secret of the Lord abundantly revealed; “He that hath My commandments, and keepeth them, he it is that loveth Me; and he that loveth Me shall be loved of My Father; and I will love him and will manifest Myself unto him. The Comforter, which is the Holy Ghost, whom the Father will send in My name, He shall teach you all things.” [\[338\]](#) The humble disciples of Christ are blest in all their researches after divine truth and knowledge: when they contemplate the perfections of the Godhead, their capacities are enlarged, their affections devoutly engaged, their hearts disposed to profit withal. A deep sense of the majesty and power of Jehovah leads them to reverence Him; a sense of His justice leads them to walk uprightly; of His omnipresence, to live holily; of His goodness, to serve Him with gratitude and love. Whilst the cold philosopher, whilst the worldly-minded and the sinner view these great subjects only with a theoretical eye, without any moral or religious

improvement, the spiritual believer is powerfully moved and affected; and walks in the light of truth every day and hour.

In their devotional exercises, the faithful servants of the Lord are peculiarly blessed; are made sensible of His presence and His power. When they pour forth their prayers and praises at the throne of grace; when they thus hold a nearer communion with their reconciled God, a heavenly tranquillity and delight are spread over their souls; they know and feel their connexion with “the Father of spirits,” and they rise from their devotion with an humble confidence, that the tribute of their heart has been accepted; that their fervent supplications will be answered, in God’s appointed time and way, through the merits and intercession of a merciful Redeemer. To these inspiring hopes and persuasions the impenitent sinner is an utter stranger: if he prays at all, it is but the outward service of the lips; there can be nothing of the spiritual principle of devotion, and therefore nothing of its fruit.

Again: when the humble pious believer sits down to the study of the Bible, with a pure desire to discover and perform the holy will of God; to be nourished with the bread of life; and to draw, from the fountain of truth, the waters of eternal salvation; the grace of the Holy Spirit is with him, to remove the veil from his corrupt heart, and thus to open and enlarge his understanding: by this means he perceives “the wondrous things” of the divine law, and applies them for his own personal edification and comfort. The true import of the doctrines, there contained, is progressively unfolded to his view; and the full bearing, of every precept and rule of life, is pressed with increasing force and authority upon his heart. He admires and reverences the holy book; he loves all that it contains; his soul is rapt in the contemplation of the stupendous mystery of goodness and godliness; it elevates his prospects and affections above this lower world; he has “tasted the good word of God, and the powers of the world to come;” [\[341\]](#) he beholds, with the eye of faith, his inheritance in the skies; and this his heavenly view brightens as he advances.

Every sincere Christian can bear witness, that his acquaintance with the word of life is continually improving; that in every page, and almost in every passage, he is perpetually discovering fresh truth and beauty, fresh obligations and delights. Of all this, the carnal-minded and the sinner are profoundly ignorant; to them the Bible is comparatively a dead letter: they

see little of its harmony or its excellency; and where they do see, it has no lively or permanent effect upon their heart; no more, than any other book, of history, or morality, or amusement.

The righteous are not free from suffering and pain, from trials and afflictions; but then they enjoy, under every visitation, a source of comfort and satisfaction, which the thoughtless votaries of this world cannot possibly experience. There dwelleth, in their hearts and minds, the peace of God; and that must ever be the gift of God, which He will never bestow upon His enemies; the peace of God, which fills them with a holy calm, and reconciles them to every thing. In seasons of trouble, the triumphs of the gospel are especially manifested; and the “secret of the Lord” especially revealed. The soul is in a more impressible condition; more ready to learn of Him, who “was meek and lowly of heart;” and therefore more capable of the enjoyment of His promised rest. “Blessed are they that mourn, for they shall be comforted.” [\[342\]](#)

The sensual and the proud are disappointed and mortified and rebellious under the various troubles of life; the Christian receives them in a different spirit, as tokens of his heavenly Father’s love; and tokens of love he finds them to be. They, who “walk by sight,” are ever complaining of hardships and inequalities in the world; they who “walk by faith,” can perceive in them all the sovereign and gracious hand of the Almighty, who “doeth all things well.” They, who live upon the favour of the world, must always be rendered unhappy by its frowns; but the Christian lives above it, and cares little for any opposition or evil report: he is fortified and comforted by a secret power, and protected by an invisible arm: and this power shall continue with him, if he continue faithful, even unto the end. When his journey through the wilderness is about to terminate, when he has arrived at the borders of the flood, and is entering upon the shores of the heavenly Canaan, when nature sinks and the soul is departing, then does the Lord reveal himself, in a manner not to be seen and not to be told: there is a hidden energy, a light within, a sustaining spirit, a mysterious and merciful communion with the Lord of life and death. This indeed is an awful secret, and one which the guilty can never know; which none can know, who do not, with all their heart and soul, embrace the promises of salvation revealed to them in the gospel: the foretaste of heavenly rest, like the rest itself, remaineth only for the people of God. They who have so feared and

loved the Lord, as to have served Him with a good conscience and with integrity; they who have so believed and trusted in their Saviour, as to have followed whithersoever He led, as to have sacrificed every unholy gratification and pursuit, for the love of His name and for the “one thing needful,” they shall find, in their latter moments, a peace known only to themselves, a joy with which no “stranger can intermeddle.” The Lord will effectually “shew them His covenant:” they were made by baptism “members of Christ and children of God,” and became thereby entitled, through the free mercy of God in Jesus Christ, to an “inheritance in the kingdom of heaven;” having abided in that covenant, and walked faithfully therein, they will never doubt, but God will assuredly perform His part; and He will give them a full insight into the blessings, which He has covenanted to bestow; they have all along entertained a lively apprehension of the nature and principles of this holy covenant, and of their own correspondent obligations; its holy promises and its gracious rewards have been through life the solace of their souls; and it continues, yea increases, to the last; not indeed enjoyed in perfection here below, but enjoyed as the earnest and pledge of the fulness of their eternal felicity.

In this manner, my brethren, “acquaint yourselves with God,” and come to the true knowledge of His perfections and His ways, and live in the animating ennobling hope of a brighter manifestation of His glory hereafter—in this manner, by a spirit of humble, faithful, entire dependence upon Him, through the mercy of Jesus Christ; by fervent importunate prayer for the illumination and aid of the Holy Ghost; by “seeking first the kingdom of God and His righteousness by loving Him with all the heart and soul,” and “walking in His fear all the day long.” Thus are we to be taught of God, thus only can we acquire a capability and disposition to be taught; thus growing in grace, we grow in wisdom, in holy experience, in happy communion with our Lord and Saviour.

Receive this instruction, “high and low, rich and poor, one with another;” it is equally necessary for all. Unless this spiritual lesson be learnt, the stores of human science, the treasures of human wisdom, are vain and worthless; they can impart no knowledge, no true and saving knowledge, of the ways and dealings of the Most High; they cannot bring the sinner to his Maker: on the contrary, they prevent and hinder him, by ministering a spirit of pride and self-sufficiency. If thou wouldest know God, fear Him, and be taught

of His Spirit and His word; this is His own appointed means, and there is no other. And ye poor, unlearned as ye may be, seek the Lord in this way, and ye shall assuredly find Him: His secret shall be with you; and He will graciously teach you more, than you can attain from all the world besides; more than the wisest can learn in any other way.

“The way of the wicked is as darkness; they know not at what they stumble: but the path of the just is as the shining light, that shineth more and more unto the perfect day.” ^[347] The Lord revealeth Himself unto the righteous, day by day; they grow in wisdom, as in years: the nearer they approach to the completion of their hopes, to the end of their earthly pilgrimage, to their heavenly and eternal kingdom, the clearer will be their knowledge, and the more delightful their anticipations; even until that day, when the veil of the flesh shall be utterly removed, when they shall “see their God face to face, and know even as also they are known.” ^[348]

SERMON XIX.

RESIST THE BEGINNINGS OF EVIL TEMPTATION.

PROVERBS iv. 14, 15.

Enter not into the path of the wicked, and go not in the way of evil men. Avoid it, pass not by it, turn from it and pass away.

THIS is one of those short, comprehensive, moral directions, with which the holy Scriptures abound, for our safe conduct in life; directions, that are seldom attended to with the earnestness, which their importance demands. Studied such words should be, with devout meditation and the spirit of prayer; imprinted on the memory, fixed in the heart. We are apt to trust too much to generalities in religion; we do not sufficiently concern ourselves with its individual precepts and practical admonitions. And I wish now to enlarge upon this point, before we enter into a consideration of the text; hoping that it may induce you, by God's help, "to take heed how ye hear" such lessons of instruction.

For the attainment of a religious character, and the means of walking holily and uprightly in our course through life, doubtless the main thing is, to establish sound principles in the heart; and without such principles all the rules and helps in the world will prove of little avail; never to be depended upon in the hour of temptation and trial. Accordingly we find, in the word of God, these mainsprings of action continually insisted on, as of the highest necessity to be settled in the soul. A true, a right faith is inculcated, as the great foundation of all spiritual obedience; a vital faith in God, as our Creator, Redeemer, and Sanctifier; a faith in His revealed word, in all the great doctrines of life and salvation there propounded to fallen man; a faith in the necessity of obeying all the commandments therein delivered for the formation of our character and the regulation of our lives; a faith in the world to come, after the death of the body; a world depending, for

happiness or misery, upon our choice and conduct here. The love of God and the fear of God are also laid down as most powerful principles of thought and action; as spreading an influence over the whole of our behaviour.

Still however, the establishment of these first principles is not of itself sufficient for the complete direction and government of our lives. So manifold and various are the temptations to which we are exposed; so numerous the trials we are called to bear, that particular instructions and commands are also needful for us, in order that we may be prepared to meet the different circumstances which are perpetually arising, in order that we may be taught how to reduce our principles to practice; and to apply the declaration of God's will to our ordinary intercourse and experience with the world.

For this purpose, we find the old scriptures every where abounding with rules, for the performance of every duty, and the avoidance of every sin: for the immediate service and worship of God, for the discharge of every honest and honourable obligation we owe to our neighbour; for the correction of all those evil affections and passions, to which the corrupt heart of man is so lamentably prone. Nor in the new testament, where the foundation of faith is more clearly and broadly laid down, are such rules less frequent, or less urgently enforced. We might indeed expect, what actually is the case, that as a clearer and fuller revelation, that as a higher principle and view, would require a more holy and perfect observance, a greater purity and integrity and blamelessness of character, therefore the several duties demanded of us, in our walk with God, would be laid down and marked with the greater accuracy. Accordingly we do find, for this purpose, "line upon line and precept upon precept" repeated and urged with the greater fulness and particularity; that we may not, by any unholiness or deficiency in our conduct, disgrace that more glorious revelation, with which we have been favoured as believers in the gospel of Jesus Christ. Look at His own blessed discourses, especially His sermon on the mount; look at the epistles, which His servants, inspired by the Holy Ghost, have left for our guidance and government; and see what full instructions they contain, for our duty to God and our duty to man. It is wonderful, for how many cases they provide; for how many instances in our daily experience; how they teach us, on the one hand, the practice of every virtue, shew all

the bearings of it and the steps that lead to it; how they caution us, on the other, against every besetting sin; how they point out the manner, in which it gains an influence over us, and cut it up by the root.

I have embraced the present opportunity of enlarging on this point, with a view of awakening your attention to, and inducing you to study and treasure up, the various scriptural rules for holy living: I have done this, because many suppose, that the fixing of a good principle—of faith, for instance,—is all that is requisite; if it were so, why should so many rules have been given in that holy book, in which there can be nothing unnecessary or superfluous? God, who knows the heart and all the ways of man, knew how wise and needful it was, to deliver express admonitions and exhortations to each individual duty; that our faith might not be vague and unprofitable, but abounding in fruit, in the fruit of holiness unto everlasting life.

But it is time now to turn to the text, which furnishes us with one of the most important cautions for our safe and christian government. It might be thought, that every true believer in that blessed Redeemer, who came “to cleanse him from all unrighteousness,” would have such a horror of sin, as effectually to secure him from its dominion; as to prevent us from the necessity of admonishing him against its fascination and its power; but such unhappily is far from being the case. Many, who make a considerable profession of the gospel, are betrayed into grievous inconsistencies; many, who set out with promising hopes and good resolutions, are led astray and overcome; many, for want of attending to the warning given in the text, for want of narrowly watching the beginnings of evil. Feeling a sincere and decided abhorrence of the grosser sins, they expose themselves without fear to slighter temptations; should they be, in some small matter, inveigled and led into the path of error, it is expected that they shall instantly perceive their danger; that they shall repent and be forgiven, and be more guarded and resolute for the time to come.

But they have not formed a proper estimate of the seducing nature of sin; they know not how the power of the tempter increases with every success: instead of their being alarmed and disgusted with the first commission, they become, from the corruption of their nature, the more captivated and seduced: it is easier for the enemy to draw them on to the second step, than

it was to persuade them to the first; their conscience becomes more easily silenced and reconciled; they begin to think, that the strictness, for which they once contended, is not so requisite; they become accustomed to evil; make excuses for it; take delight in it; are flattered with the empty praises and congratulations of their new companions; and proceed by degrees to abandoned and ruinous lengths. The fact is, that they have been all the while provoking the Spirit of the Lord to desert them: He was grieved at their very first departure, from the path of innocence and integrity; it shewed a carelessness of the ways of God; it argued, that His fear and His love were declining in their heart: with every renewed commission of evil, the Spirit was more and more quenched, till at length He left them to themselves; weak, helpless, incapable of resistance; in the dominion of the enemy, slaves of sin.

What I am here describing, has been the miserable experience of thousands of unwatchful and irresolute Christians; who have fallen into the snare, yea at last into the ruinous abyss of evil, from which they have never afterwards escaped, because they were too “wise in their own conceits” and too confident in their own strength, to take a warning against the peril of yielding to the first temptation; because they ventured into the borders of forbidden ground, and were insensibly led on to the fatal lengths, which they once held in abomination.

How many a youth have we known, trained from his earliest infancy in the holy principles of the gospel, the hope and the promise of his anxious parents, the joy of his family and friends, yet, from incautiously listening, on some unsuspected occasion, to the advice of an evil counsellor, and induced to make experiment of some unhallowed pleasure, thereby shaken in his integrity and thrown off his bias; prevailed upon to repeat the pressing indulgence; thence to proceed to others; till, in the end, the character has been totally changed,—marred, corrupted, ruined. It seemed but a little matter that first courted his consent; what, though sinful pleasures did surround him in his new scene and his new company, he, poor innocent youth, had no intention of joining in them; was determined to stand aloof. For a while he did so; and maintained the pious and virtuous and christian habits, in which he had been trained; the habits of prayer, and holy reading, and holy meditation, and uprightness of conduct: but he began to give way, to “fall from the steadfastness of his faith in Christ;” ^[358] one

religious observance after another was broken in upon; one scruple after another overcome; till at last he was stripped of every portion of the garment of righteousness, and left “miserable and poor and naked,” with nothing to hide his wretchedness and shame; the dishonour of his father, the grief of his mother’s heart; disowned by his family, disowned by his God: a misery to himself; dying the death of a sinner. And whence came all this load of misery upon him?—on account of his first unguarded yielding.

This representation has been but too frequently verified: yet not to the young only has such heedlessness proved a snare and destruction. We may see its consequences ravaging around us almost every day; in persons of every age and condition. How many a sabbath-breaker has contracted his dreadful habit from a very small beginning of neglect? At the first he was tempted very occasionally to absent himself from the House of his God; to indulge now and then, extremely seldom, in worldly pleasure; or to engage, in a thoughtless hour, in the dispatch of worldly business; but his affection and reverence for the holy day by degrees grow colder, and the temptations became stronger: the Lord’s House was, in a great measure, forsaken; the Lord’s day became his day of dissolute pleasure; or his day of business and accounts, as best suited his condition; and hence followed, as it must of necessity, the total decay of religious principle and religious character.

Thus it is also, in a remarkable degree, with the vice of intemperance; no man proceeds to its abominable and fatal extremities all at once: but no man, whatever his principles may have been, is secure from its horrible influence, if he is once tempted habitually to depart from the holy rules of sobriety; however seldom the habit may be at first indulged. It is indeed especially true of this awful vice, that if the enemy once gains a footing in the heart, he seldom leaves it, till the heart is his own.

Thus it is, once again, with evil company of every description; it is ensnaring beyond all suspicion, and beyond all calculation: wicked or worldly companions infuse their venom, into the mind and the bosom, gradually and insensibly: even if they have no intention so to do, as in truth they too often have, their very presence and conversation and habits are so corrupting, that it is impossible for any one, who is familiarly acquainted with them, to escape the contagion; in fact, whoever seeks, or whoever tolerates such company, has a lurking disposition to evil, though it may be

unperceived and unsuspected by himself. Flee from every approach to this treacherous and dangerous ground, as you would “flee from the wrath to come.”

From this statement, which indeed is but imperfect and feeble in comparison with the magnitude of the evil, against which I am seeking to warn you, my hearers; from this you may be better prepared, by God’s grace, to receive and value and apply the important admonition of the text: you will observe how particularly, how urgently, with what repetition, what varied forms of expression, the wise man delivers his charge; so delivers it the more, because he speaks feelingly, from dear-bought experience; because he himself had been lamentably ensnared, for want of attending to it in his own case.

Let us hearken to the counsel of this inspired and experienced guide: he says, “Enter not into the path of the wicked;” never be prevailed upon to set your foot on this forbidden ground; “go not in the way of evil men,” trust not yourself in their company or in any of their goings: further he says, “Avoid it,” avoid this ensnaring way; be at pains to keep clear of it; use your utmost watchfulness to discover it; go in another direction, in the way of the upright and holy. And, as if this caution were insufficient for his purpose, he adds, “Pass not by it;” suffer not yourself even to approach it, to look upon it; lest you be beguiled by its false charms, and unwarily led to desire them. Not willing yet to cease from admonishing, in order to make a yet deeper impression, he concludes, “Turn from it and pass away;” the instant you perceive it, turn round with the dread of danger; as you would if you discovered yourself on the edge of a precipice, in fear of falling headlong; turn at once, and pass decidedly and quickly away.

In obedience to these rules, my brethren, consists our great security, under the guidance of infinite wisdom and the support of almighty power: the grace of God is ever ready to be bestowed, ever at hand to “preserve us from falling;” but God expects and requires us, in the use of this grace, to employ every means of prudence, and to strive with a holy and unbending resolution: this grace is afforded for the very purpose, that we may so watch and work; and if we do not thus improve it, with circumspection and diligence, it will be withdrawn. Never so much as listen to any sinful proposal, to any doubtful invitation; stay not to reason upon it at all; turn

away with holy jealousy; never suffer the eye to dwell upon a forbidden object, to dwell even for a moment; through the eye it may find a passage to the heart, and inflame it with unlawful and hurtful desire: resist at once; the first victory is the easiest, as well as the surest. Say to the temptation, as your Lord said to the tempter, “get thee hence, Satan;” “flee from him and he will flee from you”—“escape for thy life.”

And here I must add an observation upon the means, by which we may be enabled to follow this momentous advice of the wisest of men. We must “watch and pray, that we enter not into temptation;” ^[364] we must go forth into the world in the spirit of watchfulness and prayer; praying, not only that we may have the grace to watch, but also when the trial actually arises, when we are watching. In the presence of temptation, or if we do but perceive or suspect that it is coming, let the soul be lifted up to the “Lord of all power and might;” let the language of the heart, if not of the lips, be poured forth in pious aspiration to God; if it be but a word, a wish, or a thought, it will be clothed with strength, and minister a steadfastness to the mind and heart. We are thus animated by the assurance of divine support, and fixed in our holy determination of resistance to all evil. Much depends, for safety and success, upon this habitual spirit of devotion; it is our buckler and shield in every moment of conflict; without it, we are standing, in the feebleness of nature, before the mighty enemy of our souls; ready to “be taken captive by him at his will.” ^[365a] “Be ye therefore sober (that is, be serious) and watch unto prayer;” ^[365b] and thus “go forth conquering and to conquer.”

SERMON XX.

THE LOVE OF CHRIST FOR THOSE WHO DO THE WILL OF GOD.

MARK iii. 35.

Whosoever shall do the will of God, the same is my brother and my sister and mother.

FROM this, and one or two other passages in the gospels, it has been sometimes imagined, that our blessed Lord set no value on the common relationships, the natural ties, the tender endearments of life; and that He intended to teach His disciples, by His own example, to neglect such considerations altogether; as if all Christians had an equal claim upon our affection; as if the spiritual brotherhood were the only object worthy of our regard; as if parents and brothers and sisters were merely upon a footing with the rest of mankind. This notion is entirely erroneous; it is a mistaken conclusion from the words and conduct of our Lord.

His own example, on several occasions, has afforded a sanction to the feelings of private friendship, as well as of family affection. How deeply was He moved at the death of Lazarus! “Jesus wept, then said the Jews, behold how He loved him!” ^[367a] And of our Lord’s disciples we read, that there was one, treated with peculiar tenderness and regard; one, “who leaned on His bosom;” ^[367b] one, distinguished by the high and honourable name of the “beloved disciple.” And this disciple, the evangelist St. John, has drawn one of the most striking pictures of an affectionate family, ever represented to the eye and the heart of man: “There stood by the cross of Jesus, His mother, and His mother’s sister, Mary the wife of Cleophas, and Mary Magdalene. When Jesus therefore saw His mother, and the disciple standing by whom He loved, He saith unto His mother, Woman, behold thy

son! Then saith He to the disciple, Behold thy mother! And from that hour that disciple took her unto his own home.” Jesus not only loved and protected His mother through life, but was solicitous to provide for her future well-being, even amidst the agonies of the cross; commending her to His dearest personal friend; and by way of effectually securing *his* regard and *her* confidence, He calls John the son, and Mary the mother: Behave to each other as mother and son; and it is all I can ask or require. This must be admitted as a proof, that Jesus felt most tenderly and peculiarly for His nearest earthly relation: and it shews, that those passages, which have been supposed to favour a contrary opinion, have been wrongly interpreted.

Let us now consider the circumstances which led to the declaration in the text. It appears, that the earnestness and perseverance of Jesus in teaching the people, notwithstanding the opposition of the Pharisees, had given disquietude to His friends and brethren, that is, to His near relations, some of whom did not believe in Him. They seem to have desired Him to forbear and discontinue His ministry at that particular time, supposing that He had exceeded the bounds of prudence; and it further appears, that they had induced Mary, His mother, to concur in this improper design; which conveyed a reflection upon His wisdom, and the perfection of His character. They came, therefore, when He was teaching the people; and, not being able to approach Him for the multitude, they sent to speak with Him. But Jesus, aware of their intention, answered by enquiring, who His mother and brethren were; thereby intimating, that they had no right to interfere on such an occasion, nor had any authority over Him in respect of His important work; that His spiritual affection to His disciples, in the advancement of their eternal interests, was greater than any natural affection, which He bore to His relations, in a mere earthly point of view; that His love to men’s souls had the greatest consideration and weight with Him; that even His mother was nearer to Him as a true believer, than on account of her natural relationship; and that His brethren would derive no advantage or favour from Him, if they were not also believers.

Jesus then proceeded to declare, that His true disciples, even though they had no connexion with Him by the natural tie of blood, would be regarded in the light of relations; would be the objects of His sincere affection and esteem; “He looked round on them which sat about Him, and said, Behold My mother and My brethren, for whosoever shall do the will of God, the

same is My brother and My sister and mother.” We cannot but observe, that these words are addressed, not merely to the disciples of that day, but to every individual Christian throughout the world; *whosoever*, of any age or nation, should do the will of His heavenly Father, by hearing, believing, obeying His revealed word, by embracing the gospel of salvation, he would, in life, in death, in judgment, and for ever, be honoured and blessed; even as the brother, sister, or mother of Him, who is the Lord of all, and the King of glory.

How encouraging, how delightful an assurance, to be persuaded, that in all our difficulties and troubles, in all our bereavements and desertions and afflictions, through this vale of tears, we have a friend, a relation, at the right hand of God, the omnipotent Redeemer; who is advanced, after His earthly humiliation, to the throne above, for the very purpose of “receiving gifts for men;” and of distributing them for the relief and assistance of all His loving and faithful brethren. How fortunate do the needy children of men esteem themselves, if they have a kind relative or friend in a high quarter; one possessed of honour and wealth and power. They feel themselves ennobled by the connexion; and are raised above the fear and apprehension of want, by a confidence in his influence and generosity. But what are the highest and greatest of earthly relatives, in comparison with the glorious everlasting Son of God; with Him who “hath put all our enemies under His feet;” with the “high and holy one that inhabited eternity?”

Earthly friends may and do fail, often when they are most needed; an untoward occurrence, a groundless displeasure arises; and all our expectations from them are suddenly swept away. But with Jesus “there is no variableness, neither shadow of turning:” He searches our hearts; and as long as they are really and stedfastly united with Him, no casualties, no outward appearances can estrange us from His favour. Earthly friends die, one after another; and often at a time, when they are become most dear and most necessary to us; but Jesus liveth for evermore; and the union, we form with Him, is in no danger of being severed by any change of time or circumstance; but goes on progressively and perpetually increasing. The very disasters, which often tend to disunite us from our earthly friends and brethren, serve but to bind us the more closely to the Saviour; in adversity, in poverty, in contempt, in persecution, we find Him the nearer and dearer; always most ready to succour us, when most wanted and desired: always

ready, and always able. So that, if the whole world were to fail us, His abiding favour would more than counterbalance all the evils of our lot. “When even my father or my mother forsaketh me, the Lord taketh me up;” [\[373\]](#) He is in the stead of parents, in the stead of all: “the Father of the fatherless, and the God of the widow;” the Lord of consolation, and the Lord of love. The upholding of His Spirit will sustain our infirmities; one beam of His gracious mercy will cheer all the darkness, which the world casteth over our souls.

The disciples of Jesus experience His friendly comfort every day and hour: even if there were no other world than this, they feel themselves abundantly blessed in their connexion with Him, by His present affection and grace; but there is another world; where their joy and love will be continued, and their union with Him perfected in glory. He is called, in gracious condescension, “the first-born among many brethren;” [\[374a\]](#) He has suffered and died and triumphed and risen again, risen “as the first fruits of them that sleep;” [\[374b\]](#) and His brethren, “who endure unto the end,” shall also rise from the sleep of death, and “see Him as He is, and be like Him:” [\[374c\]](#) they shall “be the children of God, being the children of the resurrection.” [\[374d\]](#)

And “do not our hearts burn within us” at the representation of this blessedness? Do we not desire the honour, the privilege, the advantage, the excellency of being thus united, in a bond of holy endearment, to the glorious Son of God, to the Saviour of our souls? Undoubtedly we do: unless our understandings be so darkened and our affections so depraved and debased, that we are incapable of choosing between good and evil, that we “put darkness for light and light for darkness.” There cannot be one amongst us, who does not profess to set a value upon the favour and friendship of his Lord; upon the relationship which, as christians, we are graciously permitted to bear to Him. Not one of us would go to rest, content and happy, with the prospect of being deprived of this distinguished and heavenly blessing. Let us know and remember then, that our relationship to Him is not like that of earthly families, a mere name which we have inherited from infancy; and which will necessarily continue without our care or concern. We became related to Him by our baptismal covenant; but there must be something more than baptism; something more is required than a mere profession, than an outward belonging to His visible church, in order to our being acknowledged as His brethren. Brethren by

name all of us are; nay, we have been spiritually admitted into holy connexion with Him: but Jesus regards those only, as accepted members of His family, who believe in Him with all their heart and soul; who look to Him, with a single, entire, and constant dependence, for life and salvation; those, who “are daily renewed in the spirit of their minds;” and desire and strive to bring all their affections into a righteous subjection to Him and His holy law; those, in a word, “who do the will of God.”

We cannot sufficiently reprobate the practice of those persons, who boastfully claim the Saviour as their “familiar friend,” without an abiding concern and a strenuous endeavour to walk as He walked, in all the ways of spiritual and moral integrity. Consider, I pray you, His own clear text on this point: “If ye love Me, keep My commandments:” ^[377] there can be no other evidence of our saving interest in the Lord, but that which He Himself has established. His true disciples and brethren must bear His image; and not the marred, corrupted, hideous likeness of the author of sin and death. This it is, to be spiritually and effectually incorporated into the family of Jesus Christ; thus is our relationship to be proved and cherished: he that walketh as a brother and a friend, will be owned as such; he, that faileth so to walk, will be disowned and cast away, whatever his pretensions: “better had it been for that man if he had never been born;” better still, if he had never been born “of water and the spirit;” if he had never “named the name of Christ.” Let us then faithfully remember, not only the joys and privileges of the brethren of our Lord, but the means also, which are absolutely necessary for the proof and establishment of this holy title; the conditions, the evidences, and the duties of so high and happy a state.

And from our Lord’s example in the instance before us, we may gather several particulars for our instruction in life: He gave His relations to understand, that it was not so much the natural tie which He valued, as the spiritual; not, as we have already explained, that He was devoid of natural affection, but that the spiritual bond was of so much higher importance in His esteem. In applying this principle for our adoption and regulation, certainly great allowance must be made, and sound discretion used; allowance for our mutual infirmities; and discretion, for the sake of preserving domestic harmony and peace. Far be it from us, to disclaim and renounce every one of our family, who liveth not as a faithful follower of

Christ; he has a natural hold upon us, which must not be harshly or hastily broken.

Independently of a universal feeling of benevolence for all mankind; it is evidently the will of God, that the different members of each family should be especially attached together, for the sake of promoting each other's interest and comfort; and thus of contributing to the good of society at large; to the increase of the general stock of happiness, and the diminution of evil.

And this, the design of a merciful Providence, which is manifest to our common reason and our common feelings, is abundantly verified and enforced by the holy word of God. The fifth commandment in the law distinctly recognizes and requires the exercise of domestic affection; and it is repeatedly confirmed, under the gospel covenant, by the pen of an inspired apostle. That apostle has farther declared, that "if any provide not for his own, and specially for those of his own house, he hath denied the faith, and is worse than an infidel." ^[379] And the sense of this precept may be properly extended, to sanction and command all those peculiar offices, of kindness and countenance and support, which the members of a family can perform for each other. Under ordinary circumstances therefore, if there be no opposing necessity, the natural tie is to be respected by the Christian, and bound upon his conscience and his heart.

Nor is such a connexion to be dissolved, but in cases of extremity; for this among other reasons, that there is always a hope, of the recreant and abandoned becoming, by the mercy of God, at length reclaimed and converted; and of this great blessing the pious relative may be made an instrument, by his fervent prayer, his affectionate counsel, and the constant influence of his good example.

But all this hinders us not from looking, with a very different eye, upon the spiritual and the worldly relation; upon the good and the evil; though both may be objects of our kind personal offices, the nature and degree of our affection may vary most exceedingly. Our love for the truly christian relative has a fervour, a purity, a delight, which nothing but the mutual working and spirit of religion can possibly generate: the happiness proceeds from that sacred, heavenly source, from which both of us draw our

principles and hopes; from the consciousness of our common interest in the great Redeemer, and our common relationship to Him: we are both “members of Christ and children of God;” inheritors of a better kingdom; to which we are journeying together, and of which we love to be discoursing; it is a bond of union, which nothing can separate; not distance, not death: for this is the great consideration, the great enhancement of our joy and comfort, that the love which we are bearing for one another, in the kingdom of grace, shall be renewed and matured in the kingdom of glory. And unless there be this principle of attachment between relations, this common faith and hope, this exercise of piety and godliness, this interchange of holy affection, all other attachments, however requisite for this world, are but time-serving and poor: death will be the dreadful extinction. But when the natural affection is thus combined with the spiritual, and draws its nourishment from it, they produce together a happiness, which none but such relations can know.

And further, we are taught by this example of Christ, that every sincere believer, with whom we are made acquainted, with whom we have intercourse, is to be treated as a brother; whatever be his situation in life, he is an object of affection far more noble and delightful, than any human tie can possibly produce; and is entitled to our best and most benevolent services. We may not be familiarly associated; we may not dwell with him as with an earthly relative; there may be a distance of rank between us; but we love and honour him, for the Lord’s sake and his own sake, as one of God’s redeemed people, with whom we hope to dwell in love for ever; and therefore our soul delighteth “to communicate with him and to do him good.” Pity that there is not, in the christian world, more of this spirit of the blessed Jesus; more friendly sympathy and brotherly interchange; more regard for one another, as members of the same holy family; the rich for the rich, the poor for the poor, the rich and poor for each other. Far different would be our condition in this world, if all were thus regarding, thus feeling for, thus helping one another. Why is it not so? For the want of a true christian faith and principle. If the tree were good, the fruit would be thus beautiful.

My brethren, allow me affectionately to recommend this subject to your private and most serious consideration; to your daily prayers; as a subject, in which your own interest in the Saviour is deeply involved; as a subject,

intimately connected with all your best promises and hopes, in this life and the life to come. And may the God of love shed His spirit abroad amongst us, and “pour into our hearts this most excellent gift of charity, the very bond of peace and of all virtues.” Has Jesus, our common Lord and Master, our heavenly and eternal King, declared, of every faithful disciple, that “the same is to Him, as a brother and sister and mother?” Then remember His example, and remember His words, “as I have loved you, that ye love one another:” remember them, or you will be forgotten by Him: “love the brotherhood,” or you do not belong to Christ; your profession is hypocrisy. “Walk in love, as Christ hath loved you;” let it be your daily walk: the reward is great, in every point of view; great upon earth, in present comfort and peace and honour; greater on the latter day, in the approving declaration of your Lord; “Inasmuch as ye have done it unto one of the least of these my brethren, ye have done it unto Me:” ^[384] greatest in heaven, where we shall be made “perfect in love;” in the love of God, and of the holy angels, and all His redeemed people, for ever and ever.

SERMON XXI.

ON SEEKING OUT THE WORKS OF THE LORD AND PRAISING HIM.

PSALM CXI. 1. 2.

I will give thanks unto the Lord with my whole heart; in the assembly of the upright and in the congregation.

The works of the Lord are great, sought out of all them that have pleasure therein.

ONE of the greatest hindrances to the Christian life, in the true believer, is his perpetual intermixture with the world, his constant occupation with the business of his daily calling, with earthly pleasures and pursuits. The world, in its very nature, in the spirit which it breathes, in the cares which it engenders, in the temptations which it spreads, stands in opposition to the gospel, to the Christian's walk with God; it unfits his mind for spiritual contemplation; it gives him a disrelish for holy delights; it calls aside his thoughts from God, from heaven, and from heavenly things; and makes him forget his obligation to, and dependence upon, the merciful and over-ruling providence of the Most High.

And yet it is undoubtedly our duty to live in the world; to partake, in a certain degree, of its pleasures, as well as of its labours and cares. It is the will and decree of God, that mankind should provide "by the sweat of their brow" for their subsistence and well-being in life: integrity and industry in the exercise of our calling are among the appointed means, by which we must "Work out our salvation." Since therefore we are obliged to mix with the world, our great object should be, to guard against its engrossing and corrupting influence; to retain all our possessions in a spirit of humble and constant reliance upon the sovereign power and disposal of the Almighty; to

be lifting up our hearts, in the course of our daily employment, above all secular concerns, to the author of our being, to the giver of our talents and our time, to the judge of all our actions. And besides, some portion of each day must be distinctly set apart for holy reading, meditation, and prayer. Without such rules and observances, the christian principle cannot possibly be maintained; faith and zeal will grow cold, the communion with God be gradually impaired, the affections estranged, and the obedience destroyed.

These remarks may serve to introduce an exposition of the 2nd verse of the text. “The works of the Lord are great:” yet great as they are, they cannot be understood nor perceived by those, who are absorbed in earthly ideas and pursuits. The attention will thus be entirely drawn off from a contemplation of the works of Jehovah; and the mind will entirely rest upon its own labours and objects. To our own hand and our own arm, to our own skill and enterprise, to our own advantage and honour, we shall refer all the transactions of life, and all the success and enjoyment with which we are blessed. The dealings of our heavenly Father, both with ourselves and with the world around us, will be utterly overlooked; and however we may believe, as a speculative truth, that His “providence orders and governs all things both in heaven and earth,” we shall be in no way improved or affected by that belief; in fact, we shall have no real or practical persuasion of His providential government: we shall be blind to His manifold mercies vouchsafed to ourselves, to our brethren, and to the Church at large.

The works of the Lord must be “sought out;” that is, they must be mindfully and diligently observed, in order to their being adequately understood; nay, if we would know any thing of their vastness or their excellency. We must be continually looking beyond human motives, human exertions, human experience, if we would in any measure, comprehend or perceive the merciful interpositions and dealings of God. We must be in the constant habit of connecting the ordinary operations and occurrences of life with a higher power, with the counsel and government of heaven; a gracious promise is given, that “all things shall work together for good to them that love God;” and we must be always endeavouring to trace this working, and observe the striking manner in which this effect is produced. We shall thus be able to perceive, how continually our merciful Father is watching over us, is crowning our honest designs and labours with success, and is bringing good even out of evil itself. We shall perceive, how wonderfully He directs

us to the most suitable means of accomplishing our laudable purposes: how He over-rules those events, over which we had no controul, for our benefit and prosperity; how He raises up to us friends and fellow-workers, when we least expected them; and provides us comforters, where we looked for none; how, in the season of danger, of which we are not even aware, He spreads over us the shield of safety, and we come forth unhurt; how He compels the designs, even of our enemies themselves, to minister in the end to our advantage; how, in the various calamities and sorrows, privations and disappointments, sicknesses and pains, which He does permit to befall us, He brings us consolation under them, and makes us to see and acknowledge, that what we lamented as a grievance, is turned into a signal blessing. And whenever, in any of our concerns or experiences, we fail to trace the mercy of God, it is, for the most part, because we do not sufficiently seek it out; because we are resting in our own short-sighted views; because we are “walking by sight and not by faith,” in “the flesh and not in the spirit;” desiring benefit in our own ways, and not humbly discerning the ways of the Lord; impatient under the means, and not considering the end; looking at the earthly instrument and agent, and forgetting the prime Mover of all.

What I am seeking to recommend to you is this, not a mere principle or matter of belief, but the importance of a constant, daily observance of the events and transactions of life, in reference to the almighty power and goodness of God. It is a point not attended to, even by many sincere Christians, as it ought to be; as to the generality, day after day passes by, without any such reference at all. Every thing proceeds, in their notion and view, from their own will and work, from the good or evil working of others; and they are affected accordingly; rejoicing or complaining, elevated or cast down. They have no consideration of the great Ruler and Preserver; they might almost be said to “live without God in the world;” it amounts, at least, to a practical disowning of His providence.

But I must repeat, that even from many sincere Christians this great influential doctrine does not receive all the attention, which its importance demands. They are convinced, that “the works of the Lord are great;” that His mighty operations are continually manifested, in the moral and spiritual government of mankind; but they do not sufficiently carry this conviction into their own daily walk in life. Far would we be from implying, that such

reflections ought, in any way, to interfere with our circumspection or diligence in worldly concerns; or that we are familiarly to mix up religious observations with ordinary business or pleasure; but we should have a mind and heart ever open to perceive the gracious interpositions and visitations of heaven; we should be alive to every providential deliverance from accident or danger, both in ourselves and others: to the vouchsafement of every blessing, both temporal and spiritual. And they, who are thus disposed and ready, will find many opportunities drawing them to God: many circumstances and events, which they once regarded somewhat in the light of chance, they will then clearly ascribe to the sure, though silent working of that invisible power, by which every thing in the universe is governed and sustained.

But the works of the Lord are “sought out” by those only, “who have pleasure therein:” and this will explain to us the true cause, why such lamentable numbers of professed believers seldom or never seek them out at all. They have no *pleasure* in their thoughts upon the Almighty: they love Him not, serve Him not with a devoted and delighted heart; their conscience is uneasy and self-condemning, and therefore they reluctantly turn their thoughts to their great Sovereign and Judge; it is rather a pain than a pleasure to them, so to do. “Loving the world and the things of the world,” they have no taste for spiritual enjoyment of any kind: in extraordinary emergencies, when the interference of an over-ruling power is irresistibly thrust upon their notice, they do not refuse to join with their brethren in acknowledging the fact: but as for searching out His ways and dealings in their daily experience, they are decidedly disinclined and averse to it; the injunction of such a practice is repugnant to their views and feelings and desires.

Nor can any, but the pious and faithful servant of God, find delight in this holy and profitable exercise: and the longer he lives, the more clearly he perceives the hand of the Almighty in every thing; in discomfiting the evil and blessing the good: he sees and admires the wonders of grace, as well as the wonders of providence, vouchsafed to others as well as himself; to the Church in all ages. He reads, in the word of truth, of the signal manner, in which the Lord has delivered His people from the foundation of the world; not only by the miraculous interposition of His omnipotent arm; but also in the ordinary course of His dealings with them. How merciful and manifold

have been His ways of enlightening them when in ignorance, and converting them when in sin. How pitifully and patiently has He borne, not only with their infirmities, but with their guilt and rebellion; and graciously reclaimed them from the path of error and ruin, by the mercies of His chastising rod. Nor do the defeat and destruction of wicked men afford less decisive proof, than the deliverance of the righteous, of the greatness of the Lord's works: the whole history of the Church shews Him to have been great in justice, as in mercy: and, we may add, in truth also. Often indeed have the promises of divine favour, and the denunciations of vengeance, been fulfilled in the most unexpected and marvellous manner; by instruments apparently altogether unequal to the momentous object designed. But "the Lord worked for His people; and there is no restraint to the Lord to save by many or by few." [\[395\]](#)

And amongst his friends and brethren in the Lord, the christian also beholds many satisfactory and encouraging instances of the working of heavenly power: he sees them advancing in their spiritual course, steadier in principle, and improved in character, "growing in grace and in the knowledge of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ." And wherever he observes the increase of true religion, there he also finds, to his heart's delight, a correspondent increase of contentment and happiness; the power of the gospel is manifest before him, in the altered characters and lives of men; and in all this, he perceives and admires the gracious operations of a merciful God.

But the christian is best acquainted with himself; studies the most narrowly his own conduct, and life; he judges indeed, with deep humility, of the manifestation of divine power in his behalf, sincerely conscious of his undeservings; still he can truly bear witness that in his own case, his own experience also, the works of the Lord have been great. Though still far, in spirit and in character, from what he ought to be and would be; he finds himself continually gaining the mastery over his evil affections and habits, and drawing nearer to God; perpetually advancing in holiness, as in knowledge; more "hungering and thirsting after righteousness, and more filled;" taking more delight in spiritual ordinances, and shewing the fruit of them in his life and conversation. And when he considers his own sinful nature, and the powerful enemies opposed to him, he cannot but ascribe this change in his heart, this improvement in his conduct, to the mighty

workings of heavenly grace. Unworthy as he is of God's favour, he does find a well-spring of comfort established in his soul; comfort at all times, especially in the hour of tribulation; either he is provided with the means of deliverance, or the tribulation itself is converted into a blessing. He is also made in many ways, the instrument of benefit to others, to his family or friends; and every door of usefulness that is opened to him, he gratefully acknowledges to be opened of the Lord. In all the good he receives or does, and all the evil he escapes or prevents, he traces the power and mercy of his God; "not unto me, O Lord, not unto me, but unto Thy name be the glory and the praise." Thus he imitates the conduct of the Psalmist, recorded in the text; "I will give thanks unto the Lord with my whole heart:" it is not a formal service, not a partial tribute, not a reluctant offering: all the powers of his understanding and all the affections of his soul are employed in magnifying the majesty and loving-kindness of the "author and giver of every good gift."

And the grateful Christian imitates the Psalmist yet farther; he does not hide the sense of God's goodness within his own bosom; nor confine the mention of it to the narrow boundary of his closet; but declares it openly as opportunity serves; first of all "in the assembly of the upright," or, according to the better version of the Prayer Book, "secretly among the faithful;" in the company of his family and his religious friends. When he has experienced or observed the peculiar mercies of his almighty and merciful Father, he delights to speak of them; though with humility, yet with fervour and joy. Such is the natural disposition of man, when he feels deeply the obligation of benefits conferred: if an earthly friend has enriched or favoured him, he thankfully makes mention of the kindness: and shall he do less for the abundant, the infinite goodness of his God? Shall he not rejoice to proclaim it in the very overflowing of his heart?

There are persons, who would draw a line of distinction between the two cases; and say, that our obligations to God should be felt only, and our obligations to man should be both felt and proclaimed. It is probable, that such observations, however sincerely made, generally proceed from the want of spirituality of heart: there is an aversion to the introduction of religious topics, however sober or seasonable. That they are often indiscreetly introduced, often in a spirit of self-righteousness, and fanatical pretension, we cannot deny: but the abuse of any holy exercise is not to

prevent us from the use. Look at the recorded lives of any pious Christians, of those who are held up to us as patterns of righteousness, whom in fact we profess to admire; and see how ready and forward they were, on all occasions, to speak of the manifold works which God had wrought for them, of the kindness which they had experienced at His hands. The Psalms are full of such expressions and resolutions: the text is a decided instance: let it have its effect upon us: let every one who has been favoured of the Lord, delight to be “talking of His doings:” not intrusively, not boastingly, as if he were a special favourite of heaven; as if he would make it appear, that the Lord were kinder to him than to others: but with simplicity and singleness of mind. The true believer abhors the two extremes, of spiritual pride on the one hand; and of cold-hearted insensibility on the other. He feels himself all undeserving of the bounty of the Lord, and is astonished that it should be so bestowed upon *him*, who is “not worthy to gather up the crumbs under his master’s table;” but the bounty *is* bestowed, and he cannot let it pass unnoticed or undeclared.

Again, the Psalmist says, “in the assembly of the upright and in the congregation.” He vows, that not only in the company of his faithful friends, but also in the great congregation, in the holy temple, the power and mercy of Jehovah shall be publicly proclaimed. ^[401] Not that any particular acts, of providence or grace, could be there mentioned by name; but that the thankfulness, which he feels for them, would put new life and energy into his praises, in the House of God. And this also we shall do well to imitate; this we shall assuredly imitate, if we have the true spirit of faith and piety. At all times, the sincere worshipper has so powerful a sense of the divine goodness in his heart, as to preserve him, in his public thanksgivings, from indifference and languor; but there are times, when he is visited with peculiar favour, with signal deliverances and blessings; and the remembrance of them will inspire him, when he next visits the temple of the Lord, with more than ordinary ardour; “out of the abundance of the heart, the mouth speaketh;” and as his love and gratitude rise, his tribute of praise will ascend, in a loftier strain, to the fountain of mercy, to the throne of grace.

And God will hear him, and accept the free-will offering; he will return from worship in a holier frame, and with a more heavenly temper; the incense which he has been wafting to the skies, will leave a fragrance

behind, and spread to his character; and he will be rendered meet, through the grace and intercession of his Redeemer, for further manifestations of divine love. And O still better fruit, still happier effects of his devout thanksgiving! he will be preparing his soul for more exalted praises in the world to come, amid the countless multitude of worshippers, in the courts of the Lamb; where the holy-angels and the glorified saints shall rejoice together, in seeking out and recounting the surpassing love of God to His church and people, to His universal creation in all ages. Exulting in the light divine, and sharing together the blessedness of the Saviour's triumph, praise shall be their constant employment; and the vaults of heaven shall eternally echo with this their joyful theme, "Great and marvellous are Thy works. Lord God Almighty; just and true are Thy ways, Thou King of Saints." [\[403\]](#)

SERMON XXII.

DILIGENCE AND PERSEVERANCE IN THE CHRISTIAN RACE.

PHILIPP. iii. 13, 14.

Brethren, I count not myself to have apprehended; but this one thing I do, forgetting those things which are behind, and reaching forth unto those things which are before, I press toward the mark for the prize of the high calling of God in Christ Jesus.

FROM what St. Paul had said in a few verses before, he feared, lest he should have seemed to make himself sure of salvation, without the necessity of any further anxiety or labour; as if he might rest quietly satisfied with his present views and attainments; and had nothing to do, but to wait for the certain result. And truly, if such confidence and relaxation could ever have been justified, it must have been in the case of this apostle; witness the sacrifices which he had made for the gospel; his unswerving and invincible faith; his holiness of character; his unparalleled labours; and the many signal marks of divine blessing, with which he had been distinguished.

But still, he was far from presuming in this way; and the resolution which he expresses in the text, and the account which he gives of his own spirit and conduct, may furnish us with a very suitable lesson, and teach us the absolute necessity of continued watchfulness and diligence and perseverance unto the end; may teach us, that we are not, as the prophet Ezekiel expresses it, to “*trust* in our own righteousness;” ^[405] in any principles we have formed, any views we have entertained, any holiness we have acquired, any experiences with which we have been blessed; and thus grow heedless and secure: but, that the further we advance, the more we must be convinced of the need of exertion; the more we shall find to do, and the more we shall be enabled to do: who loiters, loses; loses the advantage

of the ground he has gone over; loses the means of a victorious and successful accomplishment.

It will be improving, to those, who listen with humble and teachable hearts, who spiritually receive the word of God as the teaching of the Spirit of God, if we repeat a considerable portion of the important passage connected with the text; let us begin then with the 7th verse. "What things were gain to me, those I counted loss for Christ, yea doubtless, and I count all things but loss for the excellency of the knowledge of Christ Jesus my Lord; for whom I have suffered the loss of all things, (all earthly things) and do count them but dung, (as mere refuse and worthlessness) that I may win Christ and be found in Him, not having mine own righteousness, which is of the law, but that which is through the faith of Christ, the righteousness which is of God by faith: That I may know Him and the power of His resurrection, and the fellowship of His sufferings, being made conformable to His death, (by dying to sin that I may live to God;) if by any means I might attain to the resurrection of the dead," (to that perfect felicity, to which the saints are admitted at the resurrection.) From these words, it might have appeared to some, as if the apostle had expected his great object to be already accomplished; as if he had arrived at a state of faith and holiness, by which he had actually secured this felicity, independently of any further vigilance or labour: and therefore he immediately adds, by way of caution and correction: "Not as though I had already attained, either were already perfect; but I follow after, (keep following after the object before me,) if that I may apprehend *that*, (may lay hold of *that* prize,) for which also I am apprehended of Christ Jesus;" (for which He, as it were, has graciously laid hold of me, arresting me in my course of blindness and obstinacy, as a malignant persecutor of Him and His gospel.) Then follows the text; "Brethren, I count not myself to have apprehended;" I reckon not upon the prize as actually won; however high and fervent my hope, however undoubted my assurance of ultimate success, I cannot be careless, I must not diminish my anxiety or activity; my hope can only be sustained in proportion to my vigour in the contest; success must depend upon my unbending resolution and unabating constancy: the victory is not gained in the middle of the course, and cannot be gained till it is finished.

Many of us, no doubt, are aware, that the apostles, as well as our blessed Lord, were in the habit of drawing their observations and modes of

instruction from the common transactions of daily life; from the circumstances, by which they were surrounded; from the manners and customs of the people, amongst whom they sojourned. Thus, when our Lord called Peter and Andrew, who were fishermen, to be His disciples, He said, "Follow me and I will make you fishers of men." And St. Paul, on the occasion before us, alludes to certain games or sports, generally celebrated, and highly esteemed by the people, whom he was addressing. One of these games was the foot-race, in which a number of competitors contended together for the prize; and, in the result of which, they and their friends were deeply interested. Severe was the previous training, which it was necessary for them to undergo; and great and persevering the exertion necessary, in order to gain the prize. It would readily occur to their minds, that if the racer, who was out-stripping his opponents, were so to please himself by the advantage he had gained, by thinking of the ground he had successfully gone over, as to relinquish his efforts, as to stop and look back upon his wonderful feats, and indolently enjoy his satisfaction, that, by such folly he would soon lose his superiority, that his past endeavours would have been to little or no purpose; it would be perfectly manifest to them, that nothing could ensure his success, but the continuance of that activity, which had placed him foremost in the trial.

Agreeably to this view and this figure, the apostle took his resolution, and formed his principle and conduct in the christian race. "This one thing I do;" this is the unswerving purpose of my soul, this the plan and object by which my whole course is constantly regulated; "forgetting those things which are behind, and reaching forth, (stretching out and forward all the faculties of my body and soul) to those things which are before, I press toward the mark." Great and successful as his attainments already were, he did not dwell upon them with a complacency and security, which should induce him to relax; on the contrary, he forgot them, in the comparison and prospect of the exertions which yet remained.

And how much less reason have we, my brethren, to be satisfied with our past character, with any thing that we have already achieved. Woe to me! (may many of us say,) how large a portion of my time has been consumed in indifference and trifling! how long was it before I earnestly set out in the race at all! and even after it was begun, I proceeded carelessly and supinely, as if the prize had not been worth contending for. How idly and

insufficiently did I prepare for the contest; expecting to gain the victory without a sacrifice or a struggle! yea, and perhaps the best of us may look rather with shame than satisfaction upon our christian attainments: how much further might we have advanced, than we have done, if we had commenced the good work in earlier life, or been more diligent: how much more enlightened might our minds have now been, had we more fervently sought, and more implicitly yielded to, the teaching of the Spirit of God; had we been more frequently and earnestly “searching the scriptures,” more devout in meditation and more constant in prayer: how much more purified our hearts, and “cleansed from all unrighteousness,” by a more sincere and unqualified subjection to the divine will; how much higher our affections elevated, had they been more conversant with heaven; how much more firmly and blamelessly our feet have been fixed in the way of God’s commandments, in all the blessed ordinances of the gospel, in the narrow path of life eternal, had we been more zealously and faithfully walking with God. Nearer should we have been drawn to Him, in holier and happier communion, had we not been so long, and so often, cold and remiss.

No, my brethren, we have no reason to be dwelling, with such delight and confidence, upon the progress we have already made, as to feel ourselves privileged to be content. In no case, would this be considered the evidence of a true christian principle or view; in no case, would it be the means of safety; nor even consistent with the hope of salvation; no, not even in an apostle; much less in us, whose faith is so weak, whose knowledge so moderate, whose resolutions so wavering, whose attainments so comparatively poor. On the contrary, we should sorrow over our past failings; be deeply affected on considering how far we have come short of what was required of us; and heartily desire and pray, that the grievous remembrance may stimulate us to fresh endeavours, with a “new heart and a new spirit;” that so we may be “reaching forth to those things which are before.” All that we have well done, and all that we have left undone, should have, for this purpose, the same effect; experiencing the blessed consequences of our holy labour, on the one hand, we should be animated and encouraged to persevere in the conflict, that we may gather thereby additional comfort and success; and sensible of our deficiencies, on the other hand, in a work of such inconceivable and everlasting importance, we

should be anxious to repair our neglect; and thankful for our opportunity of “redeeming the time,” and making further advances.

Thank God, whatever our negligence may have been, all is not lost; the course is yet before us, and we may go onward in the spirit and strength of the Lord; the prize is yet before us, and it may be won. But it requires a full purpose of heart, a fixed determination, an undaunted courage, a strenuous exercise of every faculty and every nerve: all that we are, and have, must be devoted to the securing of the one great object. All the talents of reason, with which our Creator has endued us; all the energy of grace, with which our souls are supplied, must incessantly be brought to bear upon our high and holy calling. We must be daily and hourly proceeding; no lingering, longing looks upon the world we are leaving behind us; no loitering amid its vanities and follies; no backsliding to its sinful pleasures and pursuits; no declining from the strict line of duty, as if it were become wearisome, as if it were not fully believed to be right or requisite: “the just shall live by faith, but if any man draw back, my soul shall have no pleasure in him. But we are not of them who draw back unto perdition; but of them who believe to the saving of the soul.” [\[415\]](#)

St. Paul says, “I press toward the mark;” alluding to the mark, or line, drawn across the end of the course, to shew where it terminated. The end of our course is death; that is the mark, to which we must constantly press; never, till we reach it, can our striving be over, can the victory be gained. If we perceive ourselves languishing or weary, if the enemy of our souls would tempt us, as he undoubtedly will do, to indolence or repose, let us instantly pray to our Almighty Father, for a double portion of His Holy Spirit, and he will enable us to renew our vigour, and maintain our steadfastness. Yea, though the race be so protracted, that our limbs may be growing feeble with age, and our vital energies decaying, still we shall be inspirited with a courage and strength, that will be found abundantly sufficient; and as we near the end, our hopes will rise, and our prospect will brighten; the weakness of nature will be assisted and compensated by a merciful increase of faith; and we shall press onward, through the latter part of the trial, with holier confidence and fuller expectation.

And all this, “for the prize of our high calling in Christ Jesus.” What was it, that led the people of former days, to enter into the list, and engage in the

race? Why were they content to undergo such previous hardships and privations, in order to qualify them for the task? Why did they exert themselves in the contest, so laboriously and painfully, as if willing to sacrifice their lives in the struggle? It was for a little crown of withering leaves; for the honour of their countrymen's applause; and the approval of their families and friends. How then do they put to shame the negligent and indifferent christian; him that refuses to train and labour for the conflict of life, for the cause of salvation! What is our prize? what are our objects? "an incorruptible crown," a "crown of glory that fadeth not away;" an eternal inheritance in the heavens; the approbation of all good men; the welcome acclaim of a "multitude of angels which no man can number;" the approval, the everlasting reward of the Judge of our christian race. Are not these objects worthy of our supreme regard? Is not this worth contending for? Does it not demand all our attention, all our anxiety, all our watchfulness and diligence and labour? Should not our whole soul be devoted thereto? Ought it not to be, comparatively speaking, the sole purpose, for which we care to live and hope to die?

Especially when we consider the consequences of our failure, in this great enterprise and work. He that lost the earthly race, lost little; perhaps it was somewhat of an honour for him to have contended at all: but he, who loses the christian race, loses every thing; loses his own soul, his precious immortal soul; defeat will be ruin, eternal misery and perdition. He that lost the earthly prize on one occasion, might run for another on a future day: but when once the spiritual race is run, when we have arrived at the mark, at the goal, at the gate of death, no further trial will then be vouchsafed; there will never be another opportunity. Anxiously perhaps we may desire it; and resolve, as we find ourselves approaching to the border of eternity, that if we could be permitted to continue our race for a little season, we would "use all diligence" for a successful termination; to gain the great prize we appear to be losing: but the desire will be vain. We knew the nature of the prize before; we knew what was necessary in order to gain it; we declined and refused; we chose the broad and easy way of idleness and sin: the night will be come, and there will be no more working.

O that before, that long before this time shall come, all our hearts may be thoroughly fixed upon the high calling of our God; upon that blessed revelation of the gospel, which calls us to life and immortality. O that the

heart of every hearer may be fixed this day, so as never to be diverted from the holy and heavenly purpose; so as to be filled with a zeal and ardour, that shall never be extinguished; with invincible courage, and irremovable confidence; so that we may never “be weary of well-doing,” but persevere unto the end.

The Saviour, on His lofty throne, calls us by *His word*, which announces the glorious prize and the conditions of the race; by *His spirit*, “which is striving with us;” by His *heralds* and *messengers*, warning, animating, exhorting, persuading; He promises strength for the contest and victory in the end, to all who will engage in the great cause, with earnestness and sincerity. Awake, arise, we have nothing to fear: “the Lord is with us; who shall be against us?” who shall let or hinder? Listen, listen to the invitation and the promise! Take them for your government and your comfort; “so run as to obtain;” so, that on arriving at the end of the christian course, you may be calmly delighted to behold, with the eye of faith the crown of victory and of glory, ready to be placed upon your head. Often indeed are we permitted to behold the evident superiority of grace, at the latter hour; the peculiar accordance of divine mercy and strength, triumphing over the weakness of expiring nature: many pious Christians have then openly exhibited the most undoubted and convincing tokens of heavenly assurance and support; their Lord thus manifestly affording them an anticipation of their “crown of rejoicing,” and cheering them before their dissolution.

At this awful hour, there may be, and doubtless are, differences of spiritual experience in different individuals: but whatever, when we are ceasing to labour, be the foretaste of that rest, “which remaineth for the people of God;” whatever, when we are setting our foot upon the goal, be the outward and visible sign of approaching glory; sure we may be, if faithful unto death, that we shall soon enter upon that rest and that glory; but a small moment is remaining: the prize is ready at our departure: heaven will rejoice over us; the spirits of just men made perfect, (many whose names we have honoured, some whom we have seen and loved) will rejoice over us; and we shall rejoice with them for ever.

FINIS.

J. GARDNER, PRINTER, BOLTON.

FOOTNOTES.

[vii] These Sermons, though written for particular Sundays, are most of them generally applicable; indeed all of them, with very slight alterations or omissions.

[4] Isaiah, ix. 2. Matt. iv. 16.

[5] Eph. iv. 18.

[7] 1 Cor. i, 26–29.

[8] Isai. xxvi. 19.

[9a] Isai lii. 1–3.

[9b] Isai. lx. 1–3.

[10] Matt. ii. 1.

[12] Matt. vi. 23.

[13] 2 Cor. v. 20.

[18] John i. 9.

[19] Col. iii. 3.

[21] 1 Cor. ii. 9.

[23] Eph. iii. 5–9.

[26a] John xvii. 5.

[26b] Philipp. ii. 7.

[26c] John i. 1. 14.

[\[29a\]](#) 1 Tim. iii. 16.
[\[29b\]](#) Rom. v. 8.
[\[29c\]](#) 1 Pet. iii. 18.
[\[32\]](#) Prov. iii. 17.
[\[34a\]](#) Matt. xxv. 34.
[\[34b\]](#) 2 Pet. iii. 13.
[\[36\]](#) Col. i. 12–20.
[\[39\]](#) Acts xv. 18.
[\[43a\]](#) Gen. vi. 3.
[\[43b\]](#) 1 Pet. iii. 20.
[\[50a\]](#) Acts ix. 6.
[\[50b\]](#) 1 Sam. iii. 9.
[\[53a\]](#) Matt. xxiv. 37–39.
[\[53b\]](#) 2 Pet. iii. 5–7.
[\[54a\]](#) 2 Pet. iii. 13, 14.
[\[54b\]](#) 1 Thess. iv. 17.
[\[55\]](#) Eph. iv. 30.
[\[57\]](#) Heb. xi. 7.
[\[59\]](#) Heb. vii. 26.
[\[60a\]](#) Gen. vi. 9.
[\[60b\]](#) Psal. xvi. 8.
[\[60c\]](#) Psal. cxix. 105.
[\[62a\]](#) Gen. vi. 17, 18.

- [\[62b\]](#) Gen. ix. 9–11.
- [\[63\]](#) Wells's Paraphr. on Gen. vi. 18.
- [\[65\]](#) Gen. vii, viii.
- [\[69\]](#) Gen. viii. 13–21.
- [\[71\]](#) Ps. ciii. 1–4.
- [\[73\]](#) Psal. lxxxix. 37.
- [\[75\]](#) Rev. iv. 1–3.
- [\[78\]](#) Gen. xxxix. 1–4.
- [\[80\]](#) Gen. xxxix. 8.
- [\[89a\]](#) The season of Lent.
- [\[89b\]](#) Ps. cxxxix. 24.
- [\[90a\]](#) Heb. xii. 1.
- [\[90b\]](#) Rom. ii. 4.
- [\[92\]](#) Eph. vi. 10–13.
- [\[96\]](#) Luke xxiv. 15, 16.
- [\[101\]](#) Luke xxiv. 18–21.
- [\[102\]](#) Luke xxiv. 25, 26.
- [\[103a\]](#) Matt. xvi. 16.
- [\[103b\]](#) Luke xxiv. 27.
- [\[104a\]](#) Luke xxiv. 28, 29.
- [\[104b\]](#) Deut. vi. 7.
- [\[105a\]](#) Ps. xvi. 8.
- [\[105b\]](#) Matt. xvii. 20.

[\[105c\]](#) Luke xxiv. 30, 31.

[\[107\]](#) Psal. cxix. 18.

[\[108\]](#) Phil. iii. 20.

[\[113a\]](#) Psal. lxiii. 1.

[\[113b\]](#) Eph. iii. 18, 19.

[\[117a\]](#) John ix. 4.

[\[117b\]](#) Micah vi. 8.

[\[125\]](#) Art. x.

[\[130a\]](#) Isaiah lv. 6.

[\[130b\]](#) Prov. i. 26.

[\[132\]](#) Heb. iii. 15.

[\[136\]](#) Psal. lxxiii. 25.

[\[137\]](#) Second Sunday after Trinity.

[\[138a\]](#) Psal. cxi. 10.

[\[138b\]](#) Psal. lxxxv. 9.

[\[138c\]](#) Malach. iv. 2.

[\[138d\]](#) Acts x. 35.

[\[138e\]](#) Luke i. 50.

[\[139\]](#) Psalm viii. 4.

[\[144\]](#) Lev. xix. 2.

[\[145\]](#) 1 Peter i. 15.

[\[148\]](#) Rom. viii. 35–39.

[\[149a\]](#) Heb. x. 22.

[\[149b\]](#) Heb. vi. 11.

[\[150a\]](#) Tit. ii. 4.

[\[150b\]](#) Col. i. 12.

[\[152\]](#) 1 John iii. 2.

[\[158\]](#) Isaiah xlv. 9, lxiv. 8.

[\[161a\]](#) 1 Sam. ii. 6–9.

[\[161b\]](#) Isaiah lvi. 12.

[\[161c\]](#) Prov. xxiii. 5.

[\[168\]](#) Psal. xxx. 5.

[\[169\]](#) Isaiah liv. 7, 8.

[\[171\]](#) Psal. exxvi. 5.

[\[174\]](#) 2 Sam. xii. 1–5.

[\[177\]](#) Isaiah v. 20.

[\[178\]](#) 1 Sam. xiii. 14; Acts xiii. 22.

[\[179\]](#) 1 Cor. ix. 27.

[\[181a\]](#) Jeremiah xvii. 9.

[\[181b\]](#) 1 Cor. x. 12.

[\[183\]](#) Rom. vi. 1, 2.

[\[185\]](#) 2 Pet. iii. 18.

[\[188\]](#) Lament. v. 21.

[\[192a\]](#) Isaiah lxvi. 24.

[\[192b\]](#) Dan. xii. 2.

[\[193a\]](#) Jer. v.2; Is. vi. 10.

- [\[193b\]](#) Prov. viii. 36.
- [\[193c\]](#) Prov. xiv. 12.
- [\[194a\]](#) Rom. viii. 13.
- [\[194b\]](#) Rev. ii. 11. xx. 14. Pol. Syn. in loco.
- [\[195\]](#) Ezek. xviii. 20–23.
- [\[197\]](#) Ezek. xviii. 21, 22.
- [\[198a\]](#) Heb. xi. 6.
- [\[198b\]](#) Habbak. ii. 4; Rom. i. 17; Gal. iii. 18; Heb. x. 38.
- [\[199\]](#) Isaiah i. 18.
- [\[200a\]](#) 1 John ii. 1.
- [\[200b\]](#) 1 John i. 9.
- [\[200c\]](#) 2 Pet. iii. 9.
- [\[200d\]](#) John vi. 37.
- [\[202\]](#) Eph. v. 14.
- [\[204\]](#) Ezek. xviii. 24.
- [\[205a\]](#) Luke xi. 24–26.
- [\[205b\]](#) Heb. vi. 4.
- [\[206a\]](#) 1 Cor. x. 12.
- [\[206b\]](#) 2 Pet. i. 10.
- [\[206c\]](#) Heb. x. 38.
- [\[207a\]](#) Rom. viii. 37.
- [\[207b\]](#) Rom. ix. 20.
- [\[207c\]](#) Gen. xviii. 25.

[\[207d\]](#) Isaiah xlv. 22.
[\[208a\]](#) Rom. viii. 32.
[\[208b\]](#) Tit. ii. 11.
[\[208c\]](#) 1 John i. 7.
[\[208d\]](#) Psalm lviii. 11.
[\[211\]](#) Col. iii. 20.
[\[213a\]](#) Isaiah l. 10.
[\[213b\]](#) Ezek. xxxiii. 11.
[\[214a\]](#) Ezek. xi. 19, 20; xxxvi. 26.
[\[214b\]](#) Ezek. xviii. 31.
[\[214c\]](#) Lev. xix, 2; Numb. xvi. 5; Heb. xii. 14.
[\[218\]](#) John vi. 27.
[\[220\]](#) Phil. ii. 12, 13.
[\[226a\]](#) Luke i. 6.
[\[226b\]](#) Tit. ii. 12.
[\[227a\]](#) Gen. ii. 7.
[\[227b\]](#) 1 Cor. xii. 11.
[\[229a\]](#) 2 Cor. v. 17.
[\[229b\]](#) Rom. xii. 9.
[\[229c\]](#) Acts xxvi. 18.
[\[231\]](#) Prov. ix. 16.
[\[232a\]](#) Isaiah xxv. 6.
[\[232b\]](#) Luke xxii. 29, 30.

[\[233a\]](#) Matt. iii. 8–10.
[\[233b\]](#) Heb. iii. 12.
[\[234a\]](#) 2 Cor. iv. 4.
[\[234b\]](#) Isaiah xlv. 20.
[\[234c\]](#) John iii. 19.
[\[236\]](#) Joel ii. 28, 29; Acts ii. 17, 18.
[\[242a\]](#) Acts iv. 12.
[\[242b\]](#) 1 Cor. iii. 11.
[\[243a\]](#) Isaiah lv. 1–7.
[\[243b\]](#) Zechar. xiii. 1.
[\[251a\]](#) Rev. xxi. 23.
[\[251b\]](#) Psalm xvi. 11.
[\[260\]](#) 2 Cor. iii. 5.
[\[262\]](#) Eph. iv. 1.
[\[265\]](#) James ii. 10.
[\[267\]](#) Matt. xiii. 12.
[\[269\]](#) 2 Pet. iii. 18.
[\[291\]](#) Matt. xxiv. 3–8.
[\[302a\]](#) Tit. ii. 12.
[\[302b\]](#) Gal. vi. 8
[\[304\]](#) 2 Sam. 1. 23.
[\[305a\]](#) Rom. viii. 6.
[\[305b\]](#) Ezek. xviii. 20.

[\[307\]](#) Rom. ii. 16.
[\[308\]](#) 2 Cor. v. 10.
[\[309\]](#) Thess. iv. 17.
[\[311\]](#) Eccl. i. 14, 15.
[\[314\]](#) Gen. i. 31.
[\[315\]](#) Gen. i. 27.
[\[317\]](#) 1 John ii. 16.
[\[322\]](#) Jer. xlv. 5.
[\[327a\]](#) Gen. ii. 16, 17
[\[327b\]](#) Acts xvi. 31.
[\[327c\]](#) Col. iii. 2.
[\[328a\]](#) Jer. ii. 13.
[\[328b\]](#) Rom. xii. 2.
[\[328c\]](#) Rom. vi. 22.
[\[331a\]](#) Prov. ii. 6. 9.
[\[331b\]](#) 1 Cor. ii. 9.
[\[334\]](#) 1 Cor. ii. 13, 14.
[\[338\]](#) John xiv. 21–26.
[\[341\]](#) Heb. vi. 5.
[\[342\]](#) Matt. v. 4.
[\[347\]](#) Prov. iv. 18, 19.
[\[348\]](#) 1 Cor. xiii. 12.
[\[358\]](#) Col. ii. 5.

[\[364\]](#) Matt. xxvi. 41.

[\[365a\]](#) 2 Tim. ii. 26.

[\[365b\]](#) 1 Pet. iv. 7.

[\[367a\]](#) John 11. 35, 36.

[\[367b\]](#) John xiii. 23; xxi. 20.

[\[373\]](#) Psal. xxviii. 10.

[\[374a\]](#) Rom. viii. 29.

[\[374b\]](#) 1 Cor. xv. 20.

[\[374c\]](#) 1 Joh. iii. 12.

[\[374d\]](#) Luke xx. 36.

[\[377\]](#) John xiv. 15–21.

[\[379\]](#) 1 Tim. v. 8.

[\[384\]](#) Matt. xxv. 40.

[\[395\]](#) 1 Sam. xiv. 6.

[\[401\]](#) I will make my thankful acknowledgments to the Lord, not only with my lips, or with some slight affections of my mind, but with all my heart and soul; and that not only in the private society of those good men, whom I am more intimately acquainted withal, but in the public congregation of all His people.—*Bishop Patrick*.

[\[403\]](#) Rev. xv. 3.

[\[405\]](#) Ezek. xxxiii. 13.

[\[415\]](#) Heb. x. 38, 39.

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